

THE PERFORMANCE TRAP

THE ACHE NO SUCCESS WILL EVER FIX



CHAD HERST

The Performance Trap

The Ache No Success Will Ever Fix

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*For my brother Scott. Your life and your death left marks
I'm still learning to name. This book bears your imprint.*

*The ache you've been running from isn't the problem. It's
the signal. And it's also pointing the way back.*

Contents

Foreword	xi
Intro	xiii
 PART ONE: FINDING MY WAY HOME	 1
Chapter One: The Day the Mask Cracked	3
Chapter Two: Am I a Man or a Mooch?	13
Chapter Three: I Thought the Hard Part Was Over	25
Chapter Four: The Beginning of the End	35
Chapter Five: Proving Myself Into Pain	39
Chapter Six: The Good Kid	45
Chapter Seven: Walls	51
Chapter Eight: Snot All	57
Chapter Nine: My Way Home	65
Bridge: The Performance Trap	73
 PART TWO: FROM UNDERSTANDING TO EMBODIMENT	 81
How to Use This Section	83
Methods: Breaking the Performance Trap	91
Chapter Ten: Overwhelm	97
<i>Try This: Overwhelm</i>	103
Chapter Eleven: The Inner Critic	107
<i>Try This: Inner Critic</i>	115
Chapter Twelve: Emptiness	119
<i>Try This: Emptiness</i>	125

Chapter Thirteen: Self-Abandonment 129

Try This: Self-Abandonment 135

Chapter Fourteen: The Pressure to Perform 139

Try This: The Pressure to Perform 145

Epilogue: The Hidden Trail 149

Keep Exploring 155

Acknowledgments 157

Notes & Resources 161

Glossary of Terms 177

Appendix: Practices in One Place 183

Selected Bibliography 187

About the Author 189

Foreword

There are very few people in this world who can hold space and walk alongside someone in the deepest parts of themselves. Chad is one of those rare people. I first met Chad nearly 15 years ago when he became my coach. From the beginning, I felt truly seen. Not only did he understand me in a profound way, but he coached me at a level unlike anything I had experienced before. Or since.

His wisdom, experience, and presence created an environment that challenged me to grow beyond what I thought was possible. Today, I have the joy of partnering with Chad through Connected EC, a coaching firm dedicated to supporting executives. Our work lives at the intersection of leadership, teams, and culture. Yet sometimes what appears to be a leadership challenge on the surface is something much deeper. Sometimes the ache underneath needs to be tended to. When that happens, Chad is the first person I call.

He has a rare ability to stay with people in the places most of us spend our lives avoiding. He does so with extraordinary compassion, courage, and presence. He helps people illuminate the parts of themselves that are broken, fragile, beautiful, and often hidden from view. Rather than turning away from those places, he gently guides people through them.

Over the years, I have watched profound transformations unfold through his work. I have seen people discover a level of self-love they never thought possible. I have seen leaders reconnect with parts of themselves they had lost long ago. I have seen people move from carrying wounds that quietly shape every aspect of their lives to finally naming them and understanding them. Most importantly, I have seen leaders who are no longer driven by an ache they cannot name, but who instead lead and live from a deeper connection to themselves and their purpose.

This book is a rare invitation into that same journey. Chad shares himself

in these pages with extraordinary authenticity and vulnerability. In sharing his truth, he gives all of us permission to tell the truth about our own lives. Through powerful stories, practical guidance, and deep wisdom, he has translated the transformational work he does one-on-one into an experience readers can access for themselves.

There are very few books where you can genuinely feel the author's heart and presence on every page. This is one of them. Chad changes lives. This book is his gift to bring that work to a wider audience. I have seen what happens when people finally understand the ache that has been driving them. They stop performing, stop protecting, and stop carrying burdens that were never meant to define them. They become more fully themselves. This book is an invitation into that same possibility.

Jamie Shapiro, Connected Executive Coaching

Intro

I'm sitting in the den with my father and grandparents on his side. The usual tray of hors d'oeuvres is between us: matchstick carrots, celery, cucumbers, and black olives, each in its own neat pile. The fire is crackling. The scent of leather hangs in the air.

My feet barely touch the floor, but I'm holding my soda water with a single drop of scotch in it, a watered-down echo of the drink in my grandfather's hand.

My grandfather, the patriarch of the family, is holding court in the den with his scotch and soda. He's broad-chested, dark-skinned from hours by the pool, and has a shock of white hair. He's always dressed sharply. You might have mistaken him for a mafia don if you'd seen him.

My grandmother sits beside him, her golden bouffant sculpted into place. She's warm and affectionate as long as you're adoring. If you challenge her at all, her switch flips.

Even their house matches them. It's grand and perched high above Marin County with sweeping views of Mount Tamalpais.

That night, they're talking about someone I don't know. Someone who, from the sound of it, had admitted he couldn't handle things on his own. The tone in the room wasn't just disappointment, but disgust. As if needing anything, comfort, care, a hand to hold, was pathetic. Proof you don't deserve respect.

"A complete schnorrer," my grandmother says. "The second life gets hard, he crumbles and needs someone to hold his hand."

"Of course he does," my grandfather says. "That's all he's ever done."

I turn to my dad. "What's a schnorrer?"

My grandmother waves it off. "Nothing you ever need to worry about, Chaddy boy."

But my grandfather sets his glass down, looks at me for a beat, and then nods.

“Schnorrer is a Yiddish word,” he says. “It means a beggar. It’s not just someone who’s poor, but someone who can’t stand on his own. In this family, we don’t lean on others. We’re not weak.”

He picks up his glass, gives it a slow swirl, and adds, “There are only two types of people in the world: the doers and the schnorrers. And in this family, we are doers, not schnorrers.”

In that den, with the fire crackling and the olives on the tray, the world split in two. There was no third option. You were either strong, or you were nothing. No room to need. No asking for help. Sitting there with my feet barely touching the floor, it was clear: the rule had already been written.

What I didn’t know then was how far that rule would push me or how many of us live by rules we never chose.

This book isn’t just about my story. It’s about a weight so many of us carry: the relentless pressure to prove we’re enough, the fear of falling short, and the exhaustion of trying to hide the part of us that feels small.

That weight doesn’t feel like performance from the inside. It feels like ordinary life. It sounds like the things we say to ourselves: *I can’t stop replaying that conversation. I’m exhausted, and I’m snapping at the people I love. I can’t figure out what decision to make. I should have seen this coming. I know I should set boundaries. I know I’m being too hard on myself. I know I shouldn’t care so much about what people think. Why does everyone else make it look easy? And mostly, I just feel stuck.*

That’s how it sounds when someone first sits down with me. And when we slow down enough to ask where all of it lives, the body answers. A tight jaw. A tight throat. A tight chest. A knot in the stomach.

And it isn’t for lack of trying. Most of us have already done the therapy. Read the books. Tried meditation, journaling, and the apps. Some of it helped. We understand ourselves better than we used to. And still, when the pressure is real, we return to the same reactions. We say yes when we mean no. We push through. We snap at someone we love. We land back in the same place we thought we had already come to grips with.

We’ve learned the tips and tricks. We already know what’s happening. What we haven’t answered is why we keep doing it anyway.

I call this the performance trap.

The trap is simple: if we just keep performing, keep proving, keep holding it all together, then one day we’ll finally secure our place. We’ll finally be safe from the judgment I heard in that den. It’s a contract that says worth is something you

earn, not something you have.

The performance takes different forms. Mine was achievement: if I win, I'll finally feel like I'm enough. If I get the grade, the title, the company, then I'll be wanted when I walk into the room. For others it's caretaking: if I solve your problems and manage your emotions, then maybe I won't be left out. Or invulnerability: if I don't cry, if I'm fine no matter what, then I won't be a burden. Different strategies. Same ache.

And for a long time, the contract works. It fuels us. It builds careers, companies, and reputations. It makes us the one everyone leans on, the one who's fine no matter what. But it has a cost. To keep the contract, you have to leave parts of yourself behind. You have to override the part of you that is tired, or uncertain, or needy. You learn to trust the performance more than you trust your own body.

This book is an invitation to break that contract. It is about learning to stop running from the ache of not-enoughness and instead turn toward it. It's about discovering that the very part of you that you've been trying to hide, the part that feels things deeply, the part that needs, isn't a flaw. It's the doorway back to yourself.

But let's be clear: this isn't just about feeling your feelings. It's about change.

There are two movements to this work. First, we stop abandoning ourselves internally. We learn to pause the rushing mind and rebuild trust with the quiet signals in our bodies that we learned to ignore. Second, we stop betraying ourselves externally. We learn to take that truth and bring it into our relationships, finding a way to stay connected and stay honest at the same time.

Together, these two movements create the third option that didn't exist in my grandfather's den: the ability to be strong *and* open, to do *and* to feel.

GOLD STAR MONKEY

I worked hard to get good grades, but even when I did well, it never felt like enough. So I found another way to stand out. On stage, I could be a real ham. I knew how to play to the back row, make people laugh, feel something, and pay attention.

I auditioned for A Midsummer Night's Dream in my junior year, hoping for a lead role. I got The Wall.

The Wall? I blinked. *What the hell is The Wall?*

My entire role was to stand between two lovers as they whispered sweet nothings through a crack formed by the gap between my index and middle fingers. That was it. I was just a human prop. This was a joke part, and I was

insulted.

But I wasn't about to fade into the background. Doers don't sulk. So I threw myself into the part and made myself the most memorable wall the stage had ever seen. I stretched every moment, twisted every expression, and played a complete fool, thrilled to be a slab of stone with a crack between his fingers.

It was absurd, and it worked. The audience laughed. Teachers raved. And for a moment, I felt seen.

That's when it clicked. If I could win as *The Wall*, then winning depended entirely on the performance.

THE SEARCH BEGINS

But no matter how well you perform, some moments cut right through the act. I didn't know it yet, but one of those moments was coming.

It happened in the fall of 1991 with a phone call. My brother had taken his life.

After that, my ability to perform just disappeared. I still went to class, showed up to fraternity parties, and hit my marks on stage, but it was like I was moving through fog. My body felt heavy. Everything was dimmer, quieter. I was going through the motions, but I wasn't really there.

I didn't realize yet that the rules I'd learned were useless now. Grief doesn't give two shits about performance. It forced me to look for the part of me I'd left behind in my grandparents' den, the needy, vulnerable side I'd learned to hate. I wasn't even sure that part was still there.

So I did what high achievers often do when things fall apart. I took on a new role. Before, I was the performer. Now, I became the seeker. It was a different role, but still a mask to hide my weakness.

That search took me to India, halfway around the world, with a one-way ticket and no real idea what I was looking for. It wasn't a noble quest. I wasn't running toward something. I was running from grief, and the question of whether I had any self left under the act.

I'll return to that part of the story soon.

Years went by, and my roles started to change. More people came to me for answers. I was still trying to figure myself out, but I found myself sitting across from startup founders, executives, and high performers who seemed untouchable. Their lives looked perfect, but underneath I saw something familiar: the same polished self I knew too well, and the same hidden need.

WIRED TO PERFORM

That's when this book really began.

At first, I thought I was writing about them, the high achievers who seemed untouchable but felt the same inner pressure I did. But I soon realized I couldn't tell their story without facing my own.

When I sent an early draft to someone I trusted, a founder, he read a few chapters and sent back a single line.

"Why should someone like me listen to you?"

He wasn't attacking me. He was being honest, and it stopped me in my tracks. That question pulled me deeper. It forced me to stop writing as an expert and start writing as a human being. It made me realize that the patterns I was seeing, the burnout, the emptiness, the inner critic, weren't just business problems. They were the result of an old agreement we made to trade our real selves for safety.

That's why this book has two parts.

Part One is the story of the trap. It's a personal account of how I spent years running from my own vulnerability, how the strategy of performance eventually broke down, and how I was forced to confront the wound I'd been hiding.

Part Two is the way out. It turns to the stories of my clients, people dealing with overwhelm, emptiness, and the pressure to please, and offers a map for how to break free.

But this isn't a book about fixing yourself. The performance trap thrives on the idea that you need to be fixed. This is a book about returning. It is about learning to stay with yourself when the pressure spikes, to listen to the signal underneath the noise, and to finally stop performing for your life so you can actually live it.

That's where this story begins. Not with a breakthrough, but with the moment the mask started to crack.

PART ONE

Finding My Way Home

*The endless chase to be enough and the unraveling that
finally let me tell the truth.*

The Day the Mask Cracked

It was the fall of 1991. The phone rang, and nothing made sense after that. It was a family friend, and he sounded serious. Hearing his voice, I knew instantly that something was wrong.

“Are you sitting?” he asked.

“Yeah, I am. What’s going on?”

And then he said, “Scott jumped off the Golden Gate Bridge.”

The world went still. My body froze. I went flat. Like my insides just turned off, and instinct took over.

And then I said, “Did he succeed?”

I didn’t want him to live. I was imagining him in a hospital bed, his body shattered into pieces, with my parents sitting beside him, trapped and taking care of their invalid son for the rest of their lives.

“Yes,” he said. “He’s gone.”

Relief hit first. Then guilt. What kind of brother feels relief that his own brother actually died? But he was my only brother, and we had been archenemies for years. He had pushed me away, but now he was gone, and he was just twenty years old.

“Okay,” I said, just going on autopilot. “I’ll be on the next plane.”

On the flight from L.A. to San Francisco, I kept thinking about what life would be like without him. I remember telling myself, almost defiantly, that I wouldn’t let his death change me. That lie didn’t last long.

Scott’s memorial was beautiful. Friends and family gathered from everywhere. Our home was full of people who loved him, loved us. People who were

grieving with us. At one point, we stood in my parents' living room, maybe fifty of us, hand in hand, a circle of loss and love.

I felt more connected that week than I ever had. Yes, his death was devastating. But in the middle of all that connection, I felt a closeness to friends and family that I'd never known. And then, all of a sudden, it was gone.

THE BLACK HOLE

My grieving had barely started when my parents, with the encouragement of well-meaning friends, decided it was time for me to go back to school. The message was clear: go back, get back to your life, you'll be fine.

But I wasn't. I wasn't ready. What I needed was to be around people who knew me, people I felt safe with. Instead, I was put back on a plane to Los Angeles with the unspoken family rule hanging over me: *pull it together*.

The first time it knocked me flat was when I was walking across campus at UCLA. I'd just come back from Scott's memorial. The sun was blazing. Students walked to class like nothing had happened. Couples held hands. From a dorm window, you could hear music blasting. Flyers were being passed out for a comedy night, blood drives, and the usual campus noise.

My legs went shaky. My chest felt hollow. I just stood there, scared and alone. Two weeks after we buried my brother, I was surrounded by thousands of people, but I had never felt more disconnected in my life.

That week, I was sitting in the fraternity house when one of the older guys shoved a pledge brother into my room.

"Talk to Herst," he said. "His brother just committed suicide."

The poor kid stood there like a deer in headlights. I felt bad for him, for both of us. I told him he didn't have to do this, that he could just leave. Neither of us knew what the hell to say.

I kept trying to go through the motions, show up to class, and show up at the fraternity. But the smallest things would set me off. I remember being at the Tijuana border, sent by my pledge class to buy Everclear for some idiotic tiki party we were putting on.

Cars inched along, uneven and restless, while beggars and vendors wove through the gaps. Kids with tanned faces knocked at windows, selling Chiclets, blankets, or whatever they had. I didn't understand their lives, but I knew the raw edge I saw in their eyes because I felt it, too.

And some days, when I needed to just hide out, I would go to this little

café, one of those dim, worn-in places with mismatched chairs and the smell of burnt coffee. I'd sink into a corner table and then spend hours doodling in my notebook, making these strange, dark shapes over and over. Lines parallel to one another, filling the page. In those moments, moving the pen across the paper, I could just disappear.

Some mornings, I couldn't even move. I'd wake up in my dorm room under a crushing weight. Midterms, auditions, papers, none of it mattered. I couldn't summon the energy. I couldn't fake it anymore. A black hole had opened in my chest, and it was pulling me under.

My mind kept replaying Scott's final moments. His fall from the bridge. The way the water must have risen like a pane of glass. The obit said the Coast Guard pulled him from the freezing bay with faint vital signs. I couldn't stop wondering: was he conscious? Did he feel the pain, the cold, or had he already slipped past the point of feeling anything at all? I ran the scene over and over in my head, not to make sense of it, just trying to make it real.

When the grief wasn't paralyzing me, something else crept in: fear. This endless, creeping dread that something even worse was coming. Another shoe would drop. Maybe my parents would die. Maybe something else would happen that I couldn't handle. I felt like I was always bracing, waiting for the next disaster.

I stumbled through the next few years, searching for anything that might help me feel okay again. I chased new experiences, new landscapes, anything that promised relief. For brief moments, I could almost convince myself I was free. But beneath every change of scenery, something in me was still unraveling. That's when the guilt started to creep in.

THE VOICE

I was lost. I had dropped out of UCLA and moved back near my parents. I was still grieving my brother's death and had just blown up one of the few friendships that still meant something to me.

My friend Steven and Theo, the guy I'd crossed, were close, and when I got involved with Theo's girlfriend, Luna, I crossed a line. When it all blew up, Steven cut ties, not just out of loyalty to Theo, but because I'd broken an unwritten rule between friends, a line you don't cross.

As he put it, "You think your shit doesn't stink, but it does."

A few others followed. I stopped getting calls, stopped hanging out. They

clearly wanted nothing to do with me. And Luna? It was messy. She couldn't handle it, and honestly, neither could I. When it ended, I was more alone than I'd ever been. The depression felt bottomless.

That's when a friend offered me some LSD. I bought enough tabs for three days. I didn't have a grand plan. I just wanted something, anything that might crack the fog of depression open. It was a Hail Mary move.

The trip itself drifted in and out. I remember riding my bike through town at night, ending up under a stand of redwoods. I stood there for a long time, surrounded by towering trunks and silence, the air thick and still. The moon cast faint shadows on the forest floor, and in my altered state, they looked like ghosts.

I started talking to them, softly at first, then out loud, like they might listen, like maybe someone or something might answer. But there was no reply, no sign, nothing. Just me, reaching into the dark for something that wasn't there.

Whatever I was hoping for didn't come. Mostly, it was a blur of exhaustion and static, and by the time the third and final night came about, I was no closer to clarity. If anything, I felt even more hopeless than when I started.

As the final night ended, I put on this grainy black-and-white silent video a friend had left me. On it was footage from 1938 of the father of modern yoga, T. Krishnamacharya, and his young student B.K.S. Iyengar, who would later become one of yoga's most influential teachers.

Krishnamacharya looked like a kind of warrior-priest. He was stern, commanding, and moved with razor-sharp precision. His protégé, Iyengar, moved with such incredible grace and fluidity, this young man twisting and bending into impossible postures. There was nothing soft or serene about what I was seeing. It was all discipline, and I remember thinking, *I could use some of that.*

I went to bed feeling defeated. Whatever door I'd hoped LSD might open, it stayed shut. But that video stayed with me, those two bodies, that kind of power and control. It stirred something in me. It looked spiritual, elevated somehow.

Sometime in the middle of the night, I heard a voice that jolted me upright.
India!

It wasn't a thought. It wasn't a dream. It was just a loud, clear message as if it had been spoken directly to me. And with it, I felt a sudden calm wash through me. I knew what I had to do. I lay back down, and within two weeks, I was on a plane to India.

Shaktipat... Not Really

I'd come to Mysore to study with Pattabhi Jois. He was the guru of Ashtanga Yoga, a practice thick with discipline, precision, and flow. His teacher was the

master I had seen in that 1938 black-and-white video, Krishnamacharya. Western students traveled from all over the world to learn from Jois. I hoped that under his guidance, I would find what I couldn't find on my own: structure and a way to heal this grief.

The streets in Mysore buzzed with life. Rickshaws weaved between bullock carts, old women pressed cow dung patties onto walls to dry, and the smell of exhaust hung heavy in the air. India was chaotic and overwhelming, but it also felt alive. I didn't know exactly why, but I knew I had to be there.

The night I arrived, a friend took me to meet Jois at his house. He opened the door himself. He was small, pudgy, and smiling. For a moment, I thought I was in good hands. He seemed warm, almost grandfatherly.

But the next morning, in that cramped back room behind Jois's house, his warmth was gone. He sat on a little stool in the corner, barking commands like a drill sergeant.

The room barely fit twelve mats, jammed edge to edge. The lower walls were painted a screaming maroon, the barred windows trapped the heat like an oven, and by five a.m., the air was already thick with sweat, nerves, and tension.

Everyone moved at their own pace, but the room pulsed with unease.

"Hey! Bad lady!" he'd yell from his perch. "Incorrect!"

People braced, waiting to be corrected, injured, or ignored. And some, especially the women, braced for something worse because the truth is, he didn't just bark orders. He groped women. That morning, I saw it happen repeatedly. He pressed his pelvis into their backs, touched their breasts.

There was this one woman in the corner whom he seemed especially fixated on. She was doing a series of advanced poses, deep backbends that most students couldn't even approach. I watched him go over to her again and again, adjusting her, hovering, and then literally grabbing her genitalia as he "assisted" her in those postures.

It wasn't subtle. It wasn't ambiguous. He did it in plain view of the entire room.

Then every so often, someone would finish their practice, get on their knees as he sat on his stool, and bow to him. Their middle three fingers would touch his puffy feet, then their forehead three times.

It was a ritual act of submission, white kids, mostly, all surrendering to a man they barely understood. It wasn't reverence. It was people losing themselves in groupthink.

I sat on the steps outside the room, right next to a squat toilet. The smell was full-on diarrhea. People were so wrecked with nerves and intensity in that space,

they'd bolt from the stairs mid-breath to explode in that stall, then shuffle back out, pale and shaking. Through the grated window, I could see bodies folded, yanked, shoved into deeper poses. Limbs trembling. Grunts escaping. My heart was pounding.

Shit, it's my turn.

I stepped inside, trying to match the vibe, but everywhere I looked, it felt like I'd stumbled into the Yoga Olympics. People moved like gymnasts and contortionists, their legs resting casually behind their heads and spines bending in ways that didn't seem physically possible.

I watched a friend launch from downward dog, hover in midair, then land in some insane pose, hold it for several breaths, press up into a handstand, and float back down like it was no big deal. It was beautiful and terrifying at the same time. I was so intimidated that my body seized up.

Yoga is supposed to be about awareness. There's this idea that real change happens when you meet your edge, that point where something is challenging but not damaging. Where you're tuned in, not just muscling through pain to prove something.

But that's not what Jois was teaching. His version of "spiritual growth" didn't care where your edge was. He cared whether you obeyed. Whether you let him take you past your limits without question. And if you didn't resist, even when it hurt like hell, that meant you were doing it right. That meant you were a real yogi.

During one of the standing poses, with my foot resting in half-lotus on my thigh, Jois came up behind me. Without a word, he grabbed my foot and wrenched it higher, pulling it into my groin. My knee popped so loudly it turned my stomach.

Pain shot through my body, and suddenly, I couldn't ignore the truth: I had flown halfway across the world and handed my body to someone who didn't give a shit if he hurt me.

But I didn't say a word. I just kept breathing, pretending it was fine. I couldn't go home empty-handed. I'd staked everything on this trip, off some weird LSD revelation, and there was nothing waiting for me back home anyway.

My friends didn't want anything to do with me. Steven had made that clear. I was the guy who thought his shit didn't stink, and after what happened, I couldn't afford to be wrong again. I had to prove this wasn't just another reckless, self-serving choice.

So day after day, I kept going back to the *shala*, where Jois kept forcing my knees further and further, grinding them past their limits. His students called it

shaktipat, a sacred transfer of energy from guru to disciple.

But what I felt was something else entirely. My knees kept getting redder and more inflamed. Part of me still clung to the lie that this was sacred. That if I let him hurt me enough, something good would happen.

THE MESSENGER

And then one late afternoon, at a yoga potluck, I noticed this young man named Cole sitting cross-legged on the floor while we were all eating. His spine was perfectly straight, his hands resting lightly on his knees. He looked like a Buddha. There was a stillness about him, almost luminous. He was different from the others.

Curious, I asked him, “You seem different. Why is that?”

He smiled, a knowing look in his eyes.

“I practice *Vipassanā*,” he said. “It’s a meditation the Buddha taught. There’s a course a few hours away in Sri Lanka. You should try it.”

His words felt like a lifeline. I had come all the way to India in search of peace. But by now, my knees were red and swollen, my body breaking down. Every morning, I watched students limp out of the *shala*, one after another. Then one day, I saw a friend leave class barely able to walk. Jois had ruptured his ligaments.

That was it. I knew I would never be able to surrender to him.

VOLUNTARY TORTURE

Within a few weeks, I found myself cross-legged on a thin blue square of foam, barely a cushion, in a run-down Sri Lankan meditation center. The place was a cesspit. Rusted pipes that were supposed to be showers jutted from cracked walls. Toilets reeked. It wasn’t exactly the sanctuary I had hoped for.

I stood there, swallowing hard, staring at this shit hole I was about to willingly lock myself into for the next ten days. There would be no speaking, no escape, just me, trapped in this decaying prison of a retreat center with nothing but my own mind. This was going to suck.

The rules were simple: no talking, no eye contact. From four in the morning until nine at night, I was to sit with my attention turned inward, scanning every sensation in my body. I was to notice tingling, warmth, tightness, heaviness, jumpiness, and even the pressure of my clothes.

I was not to react. Not to move if I felt pain or discomfort. Not to scratch if I itched. Not to get up, no matter how unbearable it became. I was to sit and observe, letting whatever sensation I experienced arise, stay, and eventually pass away.

Whatever I experienced, I was to remind myself that it was just a sensation, and it was neither personal nor permanent.

But sitting still for hours was pure torture. They had to prop me up against the wall just to give my back some support, and even then, it ached constantly. My knees hovered above the ground, my hips screamed. Every muscle was firing. All I could feel was pain. Over and over again. There was nothing else, just pain, and the question running through my mind: *What the hell am I doing here?*

NO HIDING

Without any distractions, the memories I'd buried about Scott came crashing in like waves. I couldn't escape the cruel words I'd hurled at him, the fights that got so vicious they left me bruised. The ways I'd taunted him about his acne, about how weird he was. Honestly, I just wanted nothing to do with him. He embarrassed me.

Every regret gnawed at me. This sour, burning flavor would rise from my stomach up to my throat. My chest felt heavy. I was trapped in a storm of guilt. Drowning in the realization that I had been horrible to my brother, and now there was nowhere to hide.

The stillness and silence only highlighted how much I had misunderstood him. Up until that moment, I had not recognized that he actually had a mental illness. I had just assumed he was weak and that he had let himself fall apart.

SEEING THROUGH THE VEIL

In the final moments of the retreat, something profound happened. There was this heavy pressure in the center of my chest that kept getting sharper. But by then, I'd learned to sit perfectly still. As I tried to focus the pain away, it just kept getting more and more tender inside.

It felt like a finger pressing on something raw. The harder I tried to control it, the more it slipped from my reach.

Then something inside broke loose. It was more like a pressure valve blowing out. It was raw, sudden, not beautiful but necessary. The hall had been dead silent. There were maybe fifty people meditating in stillness, and now, my scream was slicing through it like a blade. I could feel every eye in the room on me, even though I couldn't see them.

But then, in the stillness that followed, a vision of Scott appeared. He wasn't the broken version I had carried in my heart. He was whole and at peace. His eyes met mine, and I felt everything: release, forgiveness, the knowing that he was okay. There were no words or explanations, just understanding.

And then something inside me shifted. The story I'd been telling about him and about myself cracked open. I saw how much fear had been hiding beneath my judgment. How hating his weakness had been a way to avoid facing my own.

The wall between us finally fell, and in its place came something quieter. Compassion. For him. For me. For how hard we'd both been trying to survive.

In that moment, I could also see the rules that had shaped us both. The same expectations that crushed him had lived in me too: the belief that love had to be earned, that belonging came only through achievement, that tenderness made you weak.

Maybe allowing myself to feel wasn't weakness at all. Maybe it was courage. Maybe this was the only way through: by feeling it, not fixing it.

For the first time, maybe ever, I wasn't running or proving or holding anything together. I was just there, breathing inside the ache, letting it be. I took a deep breath, and something in me finally eased.

At twenty-one, I didn't have the words for it, but I knew one thing: I couldn't keep living by those rules anymore.

Am I a Man or a Mooch?

I came home from India and Sri Lanka, sure I'd figured it all out. I remember sharing my journey and insights with my parents, thinking I sounded like a junior Ram Dass, the psychedelic Harvard professor turned spiritual guru I'd been worshiping for years. I really believed I'd found something profound, that I was forever changed.

It's only in hindsight that I can see how naive I was. But back then, I thought I'd come back from the East with a new calling. When I was younger, what I wanted to be was an actor. But on that meditation retreat, I decided I didn't want fame. What I wanted was to be enlightened, so I gave up the stage and decided I was going to chase freedom instead. I thought that would be the beginning of a new life, a new self.

But within days of coming home, my body started to rebel. I couldn't keep food down or in. Everything I ate hurt. I refused to call a doctor. I wouldn't even consider it. Instead, I sat on the floor in my childhood bedroom trying to breathe through it. I figured if I just stayed present, the pain would pass. But needless to say, it didn't work.

My parents kept knocking on the door, asking, even begging, me to see a gastroenterologist. I told them I didn't need one. I was convinced that the answer to whatever my gut was going through was awareness. If I just scanned my body, my gut would miraculously fix itself.

Meditation was the answer. I just had to stay present and not react. What I couldn't admit was that I was way out of my depth, and that what I actually needed was help.

For two years, all I could eat was broccoli. That was the only food that

wouldn't come back up like fire. That's not an exaggeration. My regular weight is about 150 pounds. I've weighed that since high school, but at my lowest, I was hovering around 120 pounds. I was a fucking rail.

Every bite of food lit my gut up like a firebomb. I worried I was burning holes in my intestines, and I never knew which food would be the next matchstick. I needed a lifeline, or at least something that looked like one.

THE CREDIBILITY FIX

I transferred to Columbia primarily to be with Johanna. We'd fallen for each other when we were in India, and when we got back to the States, she moved to New York for grad school. I was still at UCLA, still spinning from everything I'd just seen and felt abroad.

Then, over lunch one afternoon, not long before she moved, she said, "Why don't you apply to transfer so we can be together?"

I wouldn't have thought of that on my own. Columbia didn't feel like it was in my league. I didn't think I was dumb, just somewhere in the middle.

I'd gone to a prep school full of kids who made achievement look easy. Many got perfect SAT scores and early acceptances to Stanford or Harvard. Then there were all the endless announcements for the National Merit Scholars. I was never failing, but I was never exceptional either.

So when that acceptance letter came, it felt like an invitation to a world I didn't belong in. Not only was it validation, but it was also a smokescreen for the shame I carried. From the outside, those two years probably looked like a trust-fund hippie phase: yoga retreats and backpacking paid for with money I hadn't earned.

The inheritance lifted a weight off my shoulders. It gave me space to focus on what mattered most to me. But no one saw the strain of living on an inheritance. People assume that if money isn't your problem, then nothing is. And they're half-right. The money bought me a safety net that most people never experience. It meant I could travel to India or afford an Ivy League education.

But it also came with shame, a constant voice telling me: *Don't waste it. Don't fuck it up.*

So I tried to justify it by hiding it. I lived well below my means. I dressed down. I avoided anything that might signal privilege. At the same time, I felt the terrible responsibility to make good on it. Like I had to justify my existence with results.

I could already hear the verdict: I was just a poor rich kid whose problems were an embarrassment. It was a low-grade, corrosive shame. I knew, objectively, that I was lucky. I wasn't worried about rent or food. But the nervous system doesn't check your bank balance. It just knows shame. Because the safety wasn't earned, it never felt like permission, only something I had to justify. Needs didn't register as allowed.

This was the schnorrer's rule at work: either you're a doer, or you're a schnorrer. That's why I felt so compelled to justify my existence with perfect results because the alternative, being seen as a mooch, felt like a death sentence to my dignity.

So I held that Ivy League ID like my ticket to legitimacy. Every class, paper, and exam became proof that I was smart. That I could be disciplined. That I had grit. And if I couldn't earn the money itself, I'd earn the right to have it, one perfect grade at a time.

A POCKET FULL OF TUMS

But New York's constant noise and motion overwhelmed my nervous system and my gut. Just getting from my apartment to class felt like white-knuckling it. My insides burned constantly. I carried a pocket full of Tums but wouldn't slow down. I couldn't. I was hell-bent on getting straight A's.

I studied obsessively and spoke up in every class to show I'd done the reading, that I was smart enough to be there. I clung to this new identity. I was the yogi scholar, bending my body at a downtown yoga studio most mornings, bending my brain through every academic gauntlet Columbia threw at me. Underneath it all, I was just a bundle of nerves.

One morning, Johanna and I were in a car with a college friend of hers, one of those classic New York socialite types, glossy and unflappable, heading to a concert with her brother, a tall, blond surfer type who looked like he'd never had a bad day in his life. He was driving. I sat quietly in the back seat, twenty-two and still raw from India, while everyone else in the car seemed older and much cooler than I was.

We had tickets from Johanna's new friend, Alanis Morissette. Yes, that Alanis. She was playing that afternoon, and we were invited backstage to meet her. Johanna was in full cool girl mode. I could feel the discomfort radiating off her, bringing her vaguely weird boyfriend around her new super-famous friend, her

hip friend, and her effortlessly confident brother, just hoping I wouldn't melt down or say something embarrassing.

Meanwhile, I was supposed to be Johanna's zen boyfriend, the spiritual guy who'd supposedly transcended all this human mess, but my chest was tightening, and acid crawled up my throat. I kept trying to breathe through it, hoping it would pass, but the harder I tried to keep it down, the more uptight I felt. I didn't say anything. I just sat there, trying to breathe, hoping I wouldn't ruin it for her or for myself.

I remember catching Johanna's glance. She wasn't angry, just tired of having to manage me. Tired of being with the boyfriend who was always going through something heavy. I could feel her patience wearing thin, could almost hear her thinking, *For once, can't we just have a normal day?* I didn't want to be the guy who made everything hard, but I was.

NO APPLAUSE, JUST ACID

By now, I wasn't against seeing GI doctors; in fact, I was desperate for answers, for relief, for anything that might let me eat without fear. They ran tests. One was an endoscopy, where they slide a long tube with a camera down your throat to look at your esophagus and stomach.

Most people are put under for it. Not me. I had an exam the next day and needed to stay sharp if I wanted to ace it, and besides, I was a yogi. Pain was something I was supposed to breathe through, to master, not avoid. What actually happened was I gagged and choked my way through it while my doctor looked at me like I'd lost my fucking mind.

But the shame never eased up. The grades didn't help, the yoga didn't help, and all that self-denial only made it worse. I still felt like I didn't really belong, like I was just passing as someone who had.

I remember sitting in my Literature Humanities class on Plato, listening to some nineteen-year-old rattle off arguments like he'd been prepping for Harvard Law since birth. I looked down at my notebook. All I had written was:

Justice = ???

Next to it, I'd drawn a nervous doodle.

And I remember thinking: *Why do I still feel like a fraud?*

THE SHOPS THAT CALLED ME

My only relief came on weekends when I'd wander through Chinatown. I was drawn to this little shop with rows of glass jars filled with herbs and roots. I'd stop and stare at the seahorses, the thick, knotted ginseng roots, all those strange things I couldn't name or had no idea how to use.

I kept going back, weekend after weekend, thinking maybe I'd pick something up just by being there, that I'd start to understand what all those roots and flowers were for.

Later, I'd squat in the bookstore, surrounded by titles on Chinese medicine, flipping through pages about herbs for anxiety, digestion, and depression, hoping to make sense of what my body was doing.

Sometimes I'd come across something and think, *I wish Scott had known about this*. And then I'd sit there, staring at the page, wondering what might've happened if he'd tried a different path, something gentler, something that didn't hurt him in the end. By the time he died, he was on eight medications, a walking experiment in the early days of psych meds. His body was bloated. His eyes were vacant. He was drowning in prescriptions.

I hated those doctors for what they did to him, and I knew I couldn't let my life become a repeat of his. I was struggling too, but I didn't want to pop pills until I couldn't feel anything. I didn't want to end up like him. And I sure as hell didn't want to die like him.

So I started going to the acupuncture school clinic near Johanna's apartment. It was a teaching hospital. I'd sit across from Colleen, my student practitioner, and describe what was happening with my sleep, digestion, and whether I felt hot or cold. She'd ask questions, listen intently, feel my pulse, and then look at my tongue. She had this quiet, nurturing presence, and she noticed things no doctor had, like the way my tongue quivered when I was tired. I was drawn to the way she understood what was happening to me. It made me feel seen.

She'd hand me a paper bag full of dried, twisted roots, and I'd take it back to my tiny apartment across the street from school. The whole place would stink when I cooked it, but I loved it. I'd drink that dark tea and feel something shift inside. A calm would settle in, and I would feel relief.

PLAYING THE PART

When I graduated from college, my dad made me an offer I couldn't refuse, at least not without guilt. A few years earlier, he'd picked up a strange virus in China that left him weak and worn down. He couldn't run the family lighting

business on his own anymore, the one my great-great-grandfather had started in the early twentieth century, originally selling gas mantles and eventually light bulbs door-to-door. It had been passed down through three generations of men who'd each carried it like both a badge of honor and a burden.

Now it was my turn, or at least that's how it felt. He asked if I'd consider stepping in, not just to help, but to eventually take it over. I didn't want to disappoint him, so I said I would give it a shot.

But after a few months of sitting in meetings about amperage, wattage, and footcandles (yes, that's a real unit), I realized I was about to trap myself in a technical industry I had zero interest in.

When I finally told my dad I wasn't the guy for the job, he understood, but he also said, "Then we'll have to sell it. And if we want the sale to go through, you need to stay on. It has to look like the company is staying in the family, at least until the deal closes."

So I stayed, but staying meant pretending. Every morning, I showed up at the office and pretended to work. I had a cubicle, a company email, and absolutely nothing to do. I checked my messages, chatted at the coffee machine, strolled the halls, and did whatever I could to look engaged. But mostly, I played the part of the loyal son in a family business I had no desire to inherit.

At some point, I found an unused storage closet in the back of the office that was barely big enough to sit in. It had no windows, no ventilation, and just one flickering bulb. Broken office chairs were stacked against the wall, a few boxes of outdated catalogs were piled in the corner, and one of those sleek aluminum lights my dad used to design sat cracked and unplugged across two filing cabinets.

But it had a door. And that door was my escape hatch. I snuck back there for hours, shut myself in, and meditated on a flattened cardboard box. It was the only thing that made pretending to be there even remotely bearable.

Every so often, someone would open the door and catch me mid-meditation, cross-legged on the floor with my eyes closed. They'd freeze, mumble a quick apology, and back out slowly, careful not to make eye contact. Most of them were Vietnamese, longtime employees who worked for my dad, and I realized later they weren't just being polite. They were protecting his dignity, making sure the boss didn't lose face because his son had apparently lost his mind. Nobody ever mentioned it again.

THE DRAWER WHERE I DECIDED MY FUTURE

When the deal finally went through, and my dad sold the company, I got on a plane to Thailand for a meditation retreat. On the way home, I had a layover in Japan and checked myself into a capsule hotel, which was nothing more than a glorified drawer for humans. The inside was a slick white coffin, just wide enough to lie down, with a radio looping three static-filled stations and a ceiling-mounted TV flashing Japanese game shows I couldn't understand.

There was no place to stand, barely enough room to sit up, just a capsule. Jet-lagged, disoriented, and mildly claustrophobic, I told myself I wouldn't move until I made a decision about who I was going to be now that the family business and the life tied to it were over. Agonizing hours passed as I sat upright in that pod. My back throbbed, my legs went numb, but eventually I decided: I'd go back and study Chinese medicine.

It's not that I wanted to heal the world. But my gut was still a wreck. I'd tried everything: herbs, supplements, acupuncture, and even pharmaceuticals, but nothing helped. If nobody else could fix me, maybe I could fix myself. I wasn't looking for purpose but relief. And if a degree came with it, fine.

LOST IN TRANSLATION

In school, Chinese medicine was taught as if it were a universal system, elegant, ancient, and supposedly applicable across all cultures. But the more I studied, the more I sensed something was off. The language of the medicine didn't match the way Westerners actually described their symptoms.

We memorized patterns like liver *qi* stagnation, which includes things like rib-side pain, chest tightness, frequent sighing, and irritability, but no one I knew ever described feeling anything like that. Western patients talked about being stuck, anxious, or low instead.

It became clear that the way Chinese medicine described illness didn't line up with how Westerners actually experienced it. The symptoms on the page sounded tidy, even poetic, but real life was messier. Westerners don't usually talk about their bodies in those kinds of physical terms. We talk about emotions, not sensations.

I didn't fully get the mismatch until I saw my first real patient. She came in with severe back pain. I remember asking all the right questions, taking her pulse, looking at her tongue, checking every box from the textbook. Then I walked out to present the case to my clinic supervisor, Dr. Wei, an eighty-year-

old acupuncturist from Hong Kong who had been practicing longer than I'd been alive.

I laid out the case: A significantly overweight thirty-five-year-old woman with chronic back pain. Probably spleen and kidney deficiency with wind-damp invasion.

Dr. Wei nodded and said she wanted to see the patient herself. We walked into the tiny exam room. My patient was at the far end. Dr. Wei stood by the door while I was stuck in the middle, awkwardly holding space between the two of them.

Dr. Wei looked at the patient and asked, in her thick Cantonese accent, "You got back pain?"

"Yes," the patient said. "It's been going on for months."

"Back pain?" Dr. Wei asked again, like she hadn't heard herself the first time.

"Yes," the patient replied, still respectful. "I have back pain."

Dr. Wei paused. Then she pointed at the patient and barked, "Back pain because you fat. You lose weight. Then back pain go." Her voice was loud, sharp, and punishing. Then she turned and walked out of the room without hesitation.

I stood there frozen, watching my patient burst into tears. She was absolutely humiliated. And there I was, a brand-new intern, trapped in a tiny room with a woman who had just been body-shamed, trying to figure out how the hell I was supposed to handle the emotional wreckage from this cultural collision.

I don't remember what I said. I remember the heat in my face, the shame, and the scramble to protect both her and my own fragile sense of competence.

That was the moment it hit me. The medicine isn't culturally neutral. It was developed in a completely different world, with different values, assumptions, and ways of speaking about the body. If I wanted to practice it with Western patients, I would have to do a lot more than translate the words.

EARNING MY WORTH

In the middle of all my studies, I went to visit my other grandfather, the one on my mother's side, who was dying but still sharp. My mom mentioned I was training to be an acupuncturist, and he turned to me and asked, "Do you actually make money doing that?"

This wasn't really a question. It was a verdict dressed as curiosity.

What he meant was: *How lovely you've found your passion. Pity it doesn't pay. When are you going to grow up?*

It was the same message I'd heard my whole life, just spoken in a different accent. *Don't be a schnorrer. Don't be a mooch. Pull your weight.*

Like my father's father, my mom's father had grown up in the Depression. In that world, earning wasn't optional. It was how you became a man.

And there I was, standing at his bedside, thirty years old and still unsure if I was doing anything that counted. I wanted to tell him the truth: *No, Grandpa, I haven't really earned anything. I'm still coasting. Still trying to figure it out.*

But instead, I nodded and said, "Yes, Grandpa, acupuncturists can make money. A lot of money."

The lie hit harder than the question. Even after he was gone, his words kept gnawing at me. Until I was really earning, was I just a mooch? A schnorrer? A disappointment? Would I ever be a man if I didn't make as much as he had, or my other grandfather, or my father?

And those doubts didn't take long to surface.

FIRST PATIENT, FIRST BLACK EYE

My first real test came when the ink on my master's degree was barely dry. I was packing up my life to move to Auroville, a small town in South India, where Monica, an Italian woman I'd fallen in love with during acupuncture school, lived with her two boys, Sanjay and Satya.

On paper, the logical next step would've been to graduate and open my acupuncture practice. That was the responsible move, the one my grandfathers would've applauded: maybe even the one that could've convinced them I was a man.

But instead, I decided to forget practicality. I would follow my heart. And I knew how it looked from the outside. Moving to India for love instead of launching a career was clearly a luxury move. It wasn't the smart choice, just the only one that didn't make me feel trapped.

Plus, it would allow me to take everything I'd learned in acupuncture school and actually use it. I would serve the community and, in exchange for my work, I'd have a place to stay and something to eat. The exchange felt honest, simple, fair, and human in a way my life hadn't ever felt.

Maybe that's why Auroville felt like such a lifeline. It was kind of a United Nations of seekers, drawn from all over the world (India, France, Germany, Italy,

the Netherlands). But more than that, it was a place full of people willing to experiment. They were trying new ways of living and being human and were open to alternative forms of healing. It was the perfect place to test what I'd learned.

My first patient was Jocelyn, a forty-five-year-old American who couldn't fall asleep. She tossed and turned all night and woke up exhausted.

I'd studied this exact pattern prepping for the state boards. Her case was practically textbook. I remember thinking I'd fix her in one treatment. Then word would spread around town that the new guy was a prodigy.

I placed two needles at her wrists, two near her inner ankles, and two just beneath her eyes, a reckless move I'd only read about.

In the middle of congratulating myself, she asked, "Is it normal to feel pressure around my eyes?"

I had no idea. But I couldn't say that, so I forced a smile and said, "Yeah, totally normal."

I lied.

Thirty minutes later, I came back to remove the needles. As I pulled out the first one, a dark bruise bloomed around her eye like a drop of ink in water. Then the same thing happened on the second side. I had given her two black eyes.

Then the floor tilted. My ears rang. Everything went black.

When I woke up, I was flat on the cold tile.

My patient, bruised eyes wide, was staring down at me from the table. I tried to stand up, but she stopped me.

"No," she said. "You stay down. You're the one who needs help."

I laughed, but my stomach twisted.

She tried to reassure me, said it was no big deal, that she'd be back. But it was a big deal. She never came back. I kept seeing her around town in oversized sunglasses, no matter the weather.

And every time, I wondered if I had any business doing this work at all. I could still hear my grandfather's voice, asking if I even made money doing this. It was like the question had been stitched into my nervous system.

NEEDLES ASIDE

And this doubt crept in every time I'd see a patient walk into the treatment room looking for relief but leave unchanged. I felt this overwhelming need to prove myself, especially as uncertainty kept eating away at me. Some patients did get

better, but the ones who didn't were the ones I couldn't forget. Their lack of progress felt like more proof that maybe I was missing something essential.

So I doubled down with obsessive studying and relentless second-guessing. But the harder I tried, the worse it got. Technique didn't matter anymore, and my confidence was shot.

Then, out of nowhere, one of my patients said something that stopped me cold.

"I really hate your acupuncture needles," he said. "They hurt."

He paused, and I felt myself tense, bracing for a complaint about my skills.

"But I love our conversations."

He looked me straight in the eye.

"Can we just skip the acupuncture today and talk?"

That stopped me in my tracks. I didn't know what to say. I had spent years learning and trying to perfect this craft. But the guy just wanted to be heard, and that messed with me.

Had all my training been a waste?

But if I'm honest, I've always been attuned to what people weren't saying out loud. Even as a kid, I could help people make sense of their problems. But I never thought of that as being particularly valuable, not in any professional sense. Now, for the first time, I started to wonder whether that was actually what my work was supposed to be.

Even so, I started noticing something. The patients who actually got better weren't just the ones I treated with needles. They were the ones I really stayed with. The ones who got better were the ones who finally had space to say the things they'd been holding back for years, the shit they'd buried so deep they forgot it was even there.

I didn't quite trust it yet, but when I really paid attention to someone's words, something would happen. That didn't mean I stopped trying to prove myself through point precision or the perfect diagnosis. I wasn't done trying to get it right.

But then one day, a German patient came in with some serious gut turmoil. It was exactly what I'd trained for. I remember being ready to insert the needles, but then I hesitated. In his paperwork, he'd mentioned that he and his wife had just recently been separated. Could that have something to do with his digestive woes?

It felt risky to ask, maybe even a little out of bounds. But I said, "How have you been since your wife left?"

He blinked and, in a defensive tone, asked, "What does that have to do with

my stomach pain?”

But then it all came out. He spoke about the grief, the loneliness, and the weight he hadn't quite let himself feel.

The treatment worked, but it wasn't the needles. It was the conversation we had. For once, I wasn't performing or proving. That alone felt honest. Strange, but honest.

Time passed. When I came back from India to San Francisco, I thought I was ready to build a life. I was thirty-three, old enough to know better, but still young enough to think I could start from scratch. After years of trying to fit into Monica's family, I wanted one of my own.

At first, I poured myself into co-creating an Ashtanga Yoga program with a colleague. We built a large, devoted community that met at dawn to move and breathe together. The space was electric. Around the same time, I was slowly growing my acupuncture practice. Many of my first clients came from the yoga studio. The work grounded me, gave my days a rhythm, and for the first time in years, I began to feel at home.

Over time, that small, simple life opened up to include friends, students, clients, a community, and eventually, Melissa.

I Thought the Hard Part Was Over

It's 2008, and I'm standing under a *chuppah*, the traditional Jewish wedding canopy, in my parents' backyard. The sun is high, and the day is hot. I'm wearing white linen slacks, a gray button-down, a *kippah*, a small skullcap on my head, and a *tallit*, a prayer shawl, over my shoulders, the kind worn during prayer.

I'm not religious, and I can't really explain why I feel compelled to wear the religious paraphernalia, but I feel like my grandfather would've wanted that.

Our rabbi, Michael, the one I grew up with, is standing in front of me. The brick patio is filled with maybe forty or fifty people: family, lifelong friends, and everyone who actually mattered.

Melissa walks down the aisle toward me, her parents on each arm, sunlight catching the shimmer of her dress, the soft lines of her makeup, her eyes shining with this weightless, out-of-body kind of joy, like pure elation has taken over.

My throat catches, my chest tightens, and then it's like I'm in two worlds at once. There's the wedding unfolding in front of me, and then there's the last seventeen years I've been living. The weight I didn't even know I was carrying. All those dark tunnels I hadn't even known I was walking through alone.

But her presence somehow rearranges everything, like I've just finished a long sentence I didn't even know I was serving. And it feels like I can finally exhale, like I'm no longer alone. For the first time in a long time, maybe ever, I feel safe and at home.

I hadn't known what Scott's absence had done to me. I couldn't name it while I was living in it. But the moment she stepped into view, something clicked. That old, familiar loneliness I'd lived with so long seemed to loosen its grip. If my body could've spoken, it would've said: *You can rest now. You're safe.*

Just weeks into being with her, I knew I'd marry her. She was funny, soulful, and deep in a way that felt like home to me. While I previously had beautiful relationships, Melissa was something entirely different. With her, I didn't just feel seen. I felt, and still feel, like I can finally just be.

By the time she reaches the chuppah and we start our vows, I am completely choked up, tears streaming down my face. Then, out loud and in front of everyone, she says, "Honey, your zipper's down."

Perfect. The most emotional moment of my life, and of course, she finds a way to make it funny.

I'm not saying that moment erased the loss of my brother, but it made wholeness feel possible again. And really, the belief that died that day was the one that told me I was alone in the world. I hadn't even realized how long I'd been carrying that belief, or how heavy it had been, until we both said 'I do.'

For a while, I felt a kind of peace I hadn't known was possible. I thought the hard part was over. But peace has a way of making room for things you don't expect, like purpose. Which is how I ended up in a beige conference room asking a stranger, "What's the fizz in your ginger ale?"

THE FIZZ IN MY BULLSHIT DETECTOR

The room wasn't fancy, but it was clean, and there were big windows along one wall looking out onto round hills dotted with dried grass and scrub brush. There were no desks or lecterns, just metal-framed chairs arranged in a perfect circle. The whole setup made it clear that we weren't there to be lectured at but to face each other.

The two facilitators sat in the front. They had that calm, steady presence you often see in workshop leaders. Their voices were soft, their shoulders relaxed, their pauses well-timed. Everything about them seemed polished and slightly curated, like they'd studied how to sound safe. They had all this *namaste* energy on the surface, but underneath, something felt more uptight and controlled.

Then came the icebreaker. They asked us to stand up, find a partner, and ask them this question: "What's the fizz in your ginger ale?"

Apparently, that meant what makes you fulfilled, which somehow made it worse. Now I had to stand up, find someone I didn't know, and ask them, and, even worse, answer a deep question in metaphor with no warm-up or context. Just instant intimacy, packaged in cute language.

To be fair, I don't think they were trying to be cheesy. I think they were

just trying to get us there faster, but speed has never been my way in. When intimacy is required on a schedule, my body goes straight to threat. That's when the sarcasm shows up, not because I'm above it, but because it's how I protect myself from getting exposed too quickly.

The moment I stood up, I felt lightheaded. That familiar thing kicked in: the need to clear my throat, to swallow over and over, so I could finally push the anxiety back down. You wouldn't notice it unless you really knew me, but inside, I was struggling to think straight, already losing my grip on what I was supposed to say.

This is the kind of panic I've overridden my whole life. I've learned to just stand up, smile, puff my chest, and keep going. It reminds me of being a kid at one of those events my parents would drag me to, where they'd nudge me in front of a stranger and tell me to introduce myself, shake hands, make eye contact, ask good questions, and be polite. I always hated those moments, but I learned to push through them.

I can't tell you what a relief it was when the exercise finally ended. But then, immediately after sitting down, of course, we had to debrief it.

This is when one of the facilitators leaned in and asked, "What did you notice? What shifted in people's tones when they talked about what really mattered to them? Did you notice their posture change, their breath, their facial expressions? How about their energy?"

There are always a few gung-ho people in rooms like that, the first to raise their hands, the first to jump in. They were quick to name things like presence, resonance, and aliveness. I nodded along, but inside, my bullshit detector was going off.

That detector is sharp. It catches posturing and inflated language. And it's how I keep myself composed. It wasn't depth I distrusted. It was the way it was being expressed. It felt thin and hollow, so my body shut down.

Then came the introductions. "All right, everyone, let's go around the circle. Share your name, a little bit about who you are, and what brought you into this space today."

One by one, people shared their stories with more of the same ready-made language. "I'm here to reclaim my truth." "I'm stepping into my power." "I'm ready to break through my limiting beliefs." It was like everyone had memorized the same page from the same self-help book.

Meanwhile, the whole time they're talking, I'm rehearsing what I'm about to say, looping the same lines in my head, trying to avoid sounding like a complete idiot.

When my turn finally comes, I hear myself say, “I’m an acupuncturist. I’ve been working with a coach myself, and it’s helped a lot, so I figured, why not see what’s behind the curtain?”

It sounded fine, maybe even innocuous, but I wasn’t calm. I was just trying to get through the moment.

ANOTHER WEEKEND, ANOTHER SCAM

I didn’t walk into this coaching seminar because I believed in it. I walked in because Melissa convinced me to join her. She’d been overhearing my coaching sessions from the next room and started to recognize the fact that what my coach was doing was something she’d already been doing herself. At the time, Melissa was a hairstylist. But what she did actually went much deeper than cutting hair.

She spent her days listening to her clients open up in her chair about their marriages, their health scares, their dreams, their sex lives, their fears, the kind of stuff that most people don’t even tell their therapist. She had a knack for being with people and realized she was doing the same thing with her clients as my coach was doing with me.

“I want to learn how to do this, and you should come, too,” she demanded, with that spark in her voice that meant I wasn’t getting out of it.

Back then, coaching wasn’t really a thing. In 2007, it sat in the same bucket as those high-intensity personal development seminars, and I should know, because I’d been to them.

Sixteen-hour days. Chairs you couldn’t escape. Clapping on command. Facilitators trained to crack you open, then sell you the next level. You didn’t just have breakthroughs; you “earned” them by breaking down in public and convincing five of your friends to sign up.

I let myself get swept up in it, manipulated, hooked by the hype, convinced that collapse meant growth. Having come out the other side, I couldn’t help wondering if coaching was just another version of the same thing.

But Melissa is one of those people who could charm a brick wall into conversation, part hype woman, part drill sergeant. She’s not pushy, just impossible to resist. I didn’t say yes because I was convinced. I said yes because she was, and if I’m honest, I was a little curious.

LISTENING DIFFERENTLY

Then, the instructor gave a short introduction, just a few minutes, not even a deep dive, just a simple breakdown of what she called The Three Levels of Listening.

Level one is when you're just listening to the voice in your head. You're not really listening. You're waiting for your turn to talk.

Level two is when you're really listening. You're locked in, and your focus is laser-sharp. You're tracking every word the other person is saying with your full attention.

Level three is when you're softening your attention to sense the whole context of the conversation. You're not just hearing the words. You're listening to the tone, the mood, the breath, the tension in the space, and letting your intuition speak.

It sounded like something they taught you during one of those managerial trainings. What do they call it? Active listening? You know, that full eye contact shit. Nodding in the right places, repeating back what they're saying, pretending you're not just waiting for your turn to sound profound.

But then she said, "Now, go do it." Just like that. There was no prep, no demo. She just asked us to pair off with a stranger and start.

I was like, *Wait, that's it? We're doing this now?*

I got paired with this woman who was about my age and started with the question they gave us, which was: "What would you like coaching on today?"

And then she launched into some corporate speak I didn't understand, something about strategic goals, bandwidth issues, and cross-functional dynamics. But then she mentioned someone at work, this guy, and something in her tone shifted. I heard her voice catch. I don't even think she heard it herself.

You could see her body tense. And then she sped up the way most people do when something actually hurts, and you're not quite ready to acknowledge it yourself.

I heard myself say something like, "Wait, go back to that thing that you were talking about. Go back to that guy you just mentioned. What's happening to you with that?"

She froze, took a breath, and then I saw her face change. Her eyes welled, not in some dramatic breakdown, just the kind of moment where something unexpressed surfaces, and you finally let yourself feel it.

She said, "I think I've been pretending his words didn't get to me, but they did."

I didn't say anything to that. I didn't try to analyze or fix her or reach for some kind of insight. I just gave her the space to feel what had been waiting to

be felt. I was with her inside the hurt. And for the first time in a long time, I wasn't performing a role. I was just being me. Finally.

TIRED OF FIXING

I didn't walk away from that workshop thinking, *I'm a coach now*. I still had no idea what I was doing. But something was different. Unlike acupuncture, which always felt like I was performing a part, this didn't feel like pretending. I could just be me.

Still, I told myself I was just borrowing a few tools, nothing major, just something to sprinkle in when the needles weren't enough. But the more I used them, the more obvious it became. This wasn't a side hustle. Something was happening when I coached a patient. The room felt different. I felt different.

That's when I started telling patients I was also offering coaching, almost apologetically. I still clung to acupuncture like a safety net. But one by one, my patients stopped booking time for needles. They wanted the conversations instead.

I remember a woman coming to me, completely paralyzed by a decision about whether or not to come clean with her husband about an affair she was having. She didn't want to leave the marriage, but the emotional intimacy she was craving, the feeling of being chosen and connected, had gone missing a long time ago, and that's what had sent her looking elsewhere.

She was torn between competing parts. So we gave each one its own corner of the room: her body, her heart, her spirit, and her intellect, each with something different to say.

Her body wanted closeness. Her heart was afraid of the hurt she'd cause. Her intellect was screaming about consequences. And her spirit just wanted honesty. When she stood in that corner, I remember her saying, almost like she was surprising herself, "I just want to stop hiding."

When we came to the end of exploring each part, I could see her eyes light up. It was like she was hearing her whole self for the first time. For me, it was no big deal. I was just holding space, but for her, there was a shift. She wasn't spiraling in panic or guilt anymore. She was finally in dialogue with herself.

That's what coaching felt like. It didn't feel like fixing or guiding, but it did feel like magic, just staying present long enough with someone so they could actually hear themselves. It drew on everything I'd studied: meditation, yoga, philosophy, religion, psychology, and it pulled all of it together into one

coherent, embodied, and alive relationship. It felt like me, like I was finally using everything I'd always known but never allowed myself to act on.

Acupuncture never felt like this. Yes, I had my master's degree and a license, but I was always troubleshooting and never fully trusting my instincts. Half the time, I'd overdo it with the needles, just so my patients would feel something. Coaching, on the other hand, was much more natural.

Still, letting go of acupuncture wasn't particularly easy for me. There was a lot of pride wrapped up in that title and security in being able to say, "I'm a licensed professional." Coaching sounded like one of those things people did when nothing else worked out.

I'd say it like a footnote: "Oh, and I do a little coaching, too." I was still a little worried that people would think I was a fraud, or worse, that I'd poured years into a career where I was competent, respected, and still not doing my best work.

But eventually, even going through the motions started to feel hollow. I kept treating people and thinking to myself, *Does this shit even work?*

Slowly, acupuncture just dropped away. And I was so happy that I was doing something else, something more me.

OPTIMIZED AND EMPTY

Once I crossed that threshold, it was like a fog lifted. Suddenly, the work just flowed. My practice took off in a way I hadn't expected, like I was finally doing what I was meant to do. For the first time, I was successful in a way I could never have been as an acupuncturist.

This was the early 2010s in San Francisco, the height of the Web 2.0 boom. My clients were startup founders, engineers, and product leads who spoke in pitch decks and metrics. They came to me burned out, but still buzzing with the pressure to optimize everything: their teams, their bodies, their relationships, even their downtime.

At first, I just felt lucky to be busy, grateful the work was landing. But over time, I started to notice that the people coming to me weren't so different from the ones I grew up with or the version of me I might have become if I hadn't lost my brother or gone through everything I did. But they weren't coming to me for healing.

They were coming with the same hunger I knew well. On the surface, it looked like they wanted strategy, optimization, and a way to get unstuck with-

out slowing down, but underneath, it was the same pressure I'd been carrying, too.

At first, I bought into it. Strategy sounded interesting and useful, and it felt like something I could actually help with. But the more I sat with my high-performing clients, the more I started to notice something else. There was this quiet, almost desperate pain underneath all that sharp, efficient language. They talked about KPIs and ROI, but what I heard underneath was anxiety and a kind of hypervigilance that fueled their performance. There was no in-between. They had to be exceptional, and that's what kept them stacking wins.

That mindset wasn't limited to the office. It bled into everything. Even celebrations were branding opportunities. One of my clients invited Melissa and me to a wedding that was held at this sleek, high-profile event space in San Francisco. It's not the kind of place you'd rent casually.

But even with all the gloss, the perfect lighting, the craft cocktails, the carefully curated outfits, the night felt cold and anonymous. It was like just another product launch, only this one had flowers. Guests showed up in designer suits and sneakers, like they'd all gotten the same memo. There was no warmth to be felt in that room, just a bunch of tech bros and media types scanning for who else was more important in the room. They took selfies more than they actually made eye contact.

The one guy I actually knew spent the whole night dropping names. I could see what he was doing, but I couldn't fully judge him. I felt that same tug myself, the pull to seem important, to look like I fit in.

Meanwhile, Melissa kept whispering in my ear, "When the fuck are we going to get out of here?" She's always had a better bullshit detector than me.

At some point during the reception, the groom pulled me aside. It was one of those "I'm pitching you, but I'm trying to sound casual" kind of moments.

He started telling me about this startup he was dreaming up. His eyes lit up. "We're building a next-gen wellness platform," he said. "The idea is to unlock human potential at scale."

I nodded. *Wow, I thought. Good for him.*

But it got weird fast. He wasn't talking about people. He was talking about users. It wasn't about healing. It was about engagement. He described emotional insight as a product feature, something to be optimized with predictive analytics and "scalable empathy modules."

Eventually, he managed to raise millions for it, and for a moment, it looked like the next big thing. But it flopped. Turns out you can't swipe your way to enlightenment. The platform felt less like growth and more like surveillance in

a hoodie.

Later that night, Melissa and I walked out into the cool San Francisco air, looked at each other, and said, “What was that?”

Something about that evening stuck with me. It wasn’t just the awkwardness or the vibe. It was the disconnect. It was a room full of ambition and people posturing for one another.

That’s exactly what I was seeing in my clients. They kept it all together, but underneath, something else was happening. They were confident and bold but also disconnected.

Many were reading *The 4-Hour Workweek* and dreaming of moving to Thailand, answering a few emails from a hammock, and calling it “scaling impact.” But underneath all the metrics and mindset hacks was pain and a deep, unspoken fear that none of it was real. The status they had built could vanish the moment they stopped producing.

And what hit me hardest was that I knew that fear. I had lived it. The more I listened, the more I realized how easily I could’ve been one of them.

No, I wasn’t a tech bro, but I grew up in almost the same world, Marin County in the ’80s and ’90s, where perfection was the price of admission. My friends’ parents were stockbrokers, CEOs, and lawyers. They had the big houses, the German cars, the country club memberships, but not a trace of joy.

You’d think all that comfort would translate to happiness, but it didn’t. There was this low, constant hum of tension in their homes, like everyone was holding their breath, terrified of slipping out of the image they’d built.

Most of them were aggressively competitive, and they passed that aggression down to their kids, who by high school were already fluent in status and social hierarchy. You could feel the entitlement in the way they talked, like they’d been taught they were better without anyone ever needing to say it out loud.

But what I knew about them was that it was all fear. Fear of falling behind, fear of not being enough, fear of being found out.

So when high performers came to me looking to level up, I started listening for what was underneath the strategies. And more often than not, it was the same thing I’d grown up around, a simmering panic dressed up as ambition.

They couldn’t yet identify this fear in themselves. Because asking meant slowing down, and slowing down meant risking everything they thought made them valuable.

RIGHT BEFORE THE BODY SAID NO

For a long time, I thought I'd made it through to the other side. The grief I'd suffered from my brother's loss had softened. The questions about my path had gone quiet. I was doing work that felt good. I was in a marriage that didn't ask me to perform, only to be me. I had a daily rhythm that felt simple, solid, and mine.

And then COVID lockdowns hit, and I thought, *Oh shit, my practice is done for.*

Everything I'd built had relied on being in the same room with another person. But instead of dissolving, my practice exploded. I started getting calls from all over the world: Japan, Europe, the Middle East, and throughout the U.S. The work cracked open, and I was coaching leaders through breakdowns they hadn't been able to name until everything stopped.

Everything looked fine on the surface, but something was beginning to come undone.

The Beginning of the End

I'd close my eyes and start to drift off to sleep, and then I'd feel this tap in the same spot every time, the lower left side of my gut. It didn't feel like pain exactly, more like this message:

Hello, are you awake? It's our favorite hour. Don't fall asleep. Let's talk.

Then I'd be jolted back awake, like my body just couldn't let go into the surrender of sleep.

That's when the racing thoughts would kick in. I'd wonder what was wrong with me, why I couldn't sleep, whether I was going to fall apart on my calls the next day, how much longer I could keep this up before something really broke.

I tried everything I knew. Instead of sleeping, I'd just sit upright in a meditative position and not move for two hours. I overhauled my diet. I took more herbal remedies than I care to admit. I did a ridiculous amount of yoga. But nothing made a dent in what was happening inside my gut.

Whatever it was, it was in control, not me. And it didn't just feel physical. It felt old, like something I'd buried a long time ago was pushing its way back up. I'd move through my days like I was sleepwalking, afraid that if I stopped or slowed down, it would destroy me. It was something I didn't even know how to name.

It didn't show up overnight. It crept in slowly. At first, it was just a little gut pain, some tightness, and a few nights of bad sleep. I blamed it on that old stomach bug I picked up in India in my early twenties. But by fifty, the cramping, the bloating, the inability to really eat anything had become a permanent fixture in my life. And now, it was wrecking my sleep.

I told myself I could handle it, but I couldn't. I just kept going and repeating that old Buddhist line: *This too will change*.

Meanwhile, my work was about teaching people how to stay with their own discomfort. But I was having an impossible time doing it with myself. Not when every second inside my body felt so uncomfortable, and sometimes like I wanted to crawl out of my own skin.

What I didn't realize was that whatever had been living under the surface wasn't willing to stay quiet anymore. Not even subtly.

NO LONGER A SCHNORRER

When the world shut down, my work didn't dry up the way I feared it would. It exploded. Overnight, I became the guy people called when the wheels were coming off.

It's not that I was trying to build a brand or scale a business. It just happened. Everyone wanted my steadiness, and I knew how to give it. And honestly, it felt good at first. It was amazing to have my inbox full, my schedule packed, and the money finally flowing.

I was finally getting the recognition I'd always wanted. I was in demand, and I was being paid generously for it. For once, after all those years of grinding, it felt like everything had finally paid off.

I wasn't the schnorrer anymore, the guy living off his inheritance, the one everyone whispered about. I was respected. Or at least, that's what I told myself. Because underneath the surface, something else was happening. I was burning out.

The work didn't feel bad. It just felt endless. The calls came nonstop: anxiety, uncertainty, grief, shame. I knew how to handle it. I could track tone, match breath, hold space. That's what people were paying me for, not just to listen, but to meet them right at the edge of their pain and stay there until they could find their own center again.

And it worked. But it cost something. When you attune like that, it's your whole system opening, so theirs can open, too. And when you do that all day, every day, something in you starts to fray. It takes its toll.

I didn't notice it at first. I just started leaving sessions with no memory of what we'd talked about. I'd stare at my inbox like it was written in code. I'd wake up more exhausted than when I went to bed.

But beneath all that fatigue was a question I couldn't shake: *Why doesn't this feel better?*

I'd worked for years to prove I could build something honest, that I wasn't just a trustafarian coasting on privilege. Now I had clients, income, and referrals. I was the guy people leaned on. And still, I felt like shit.

What I didn't realize yet was that success doesn't heal shame. It just camouflages it. I thought making money would finally silence that old voice that said I was living off an inheritance. But all it did was intensify the pressure.

Every day, I was earning my keep by showing up flawlessly, by being the guy who never needed help. I wasn't a schnorrer anymore, but I was still proving I deserved to exist. And the thing about being the steady one, the listener, the container, is that no one ever stops to ask if you're okay. And even if they did, I wouldn't have known how to answer.

That question didn't really come until later. When I was supposed to be helping someone else hold it together, and I couldn't hold it together myself.

THE SLIP

One afternoon, I was on a Zoom call with a senior executive who was panicking about layoffs and the chaos of the COVID lockdowns. I played my part. I was calm, steady, and professional. The guy he could trust when everything around him felt like it was falling apart. But something was off that day.

My mind felt foggy. My gut twisted every time I shifted in my chair. I tried to look present on the screen, nod along, and ask engaging questions. I did my best to hold the container like I always did, but inside, something was wearing thin. I could feel myself losing my grip, just slightly, but enough to know something was seriously wrong.

Then he paused, looked at me through the screen, and asked, "Everything all right there?"

He said it casually, but it cut right through me. My body froze. I could feel my face tighten, and a wave of heat rushed up my throat and into my face.

Shit, I thought. He sees what's happening. Don't blink. Just smile. Hold it together.

But then there was a split second where I thought, maybe I'll tell him the truth.

Fuck no, I'm not all right. My gut hurts like hell. I haven't slept in days. I'm so

tired I can't even think straight. Honestly, I don't even know what you just said. I've been nodding and pretending to follow, but I'm not with you.

Then, habit took over, and I said, "Yeah, just a rough night. All good here."

He nodded and kept going. The moment passed, but not for me. I watched myself do the thing I always did: pull my shit together, smooth it over, and make it easy for everyone else. I didn't even think about it. It was automatic.

But what was clear was that I wasn't hiding it well anymore. He could see it, and so could I, and that only intensified my panic. I started to wonder how much longer I could keep this up.

Proving Myself Into Pain

I thought I was finally getting what I'd always wanted: respect, recognition, and remuneration, but I was actually pressing on something much older. A wound I didn't even know I was touching.

I wasn't just burned out. I was caught in the same old trap: prove your worth by pushing past your limits, hide the pain, earn your place by out-suffering everyone around you. And no place brought that out more than the mat.

Yoga was the only thing that gave my mind a break. I didn't use it to soothe myself. I used it to shock my system hard enough to turn the volume down. I'd push myself to the edge, making sure I left the mat wrung out. That was the metric. If I wasn't spent by the end, it didn't count.

I loved the sun salutations. They made me feel calm and strong, but halfway through my practice, my energy would just collapse. I'd start belching uncontrollably. The knot in my stomach would tighten. That's when I'd start bargaining with myself to finish. I'd tell myself I'd feel better if I just got through the whole thing.

It didn't actually bring relief. Just that old, familiar sense of doing it the "traditional way," the way I was taught by Pattabhi Jois.

BACK TO MYSORE

Yes, I left Mysore, India, at twenty, after having my knees wrenched by Jois and watching him grope students. But leaving physically wasn't the same as walking

away. I kept going back. First at twenty-four, then in my late twenties, and multiple times throughout my early thirties.

When I first went, it was to heal. But later, I kept going back because I wanted the authorization to teach. It wasn't that I felt a deep devotion to Pattabhi Jois himself. If anything, I felt guilty that I didn't. But I was devoted to what his approval meant.

At the time, the only real way to teach was to get the guru's blessing. That stamp of approval was the currency. If you had it, you were in. Without it, you weren't.

And even now, telling this story, I can still feel that part of me, the part that kept going back, chasing legitimacy. That part is still in here.

But I have to keep reminding myself. Jois built a system that sanctified pain, blurred consent, and demanded submission. And while I'd like to think I had a more evolved take on all of it, that I wasn't a disciple, that I'd never fully surrendered to him, I was still shaped by the same architecture.

I believed in the system. I believed that if I practiced hard enough, long enough, with enough discipline and intensity, something would burn clean. That if I could just purify myself, burn off the doubts, the cravings, the noise, I'd reach this kind of inner clarity. That was the promise. So no, I didn't follow Jois. But I still followed the logic.

Why did I keep going back? I've asked myself that question a thousand times. I still don't have a clean answer, but something in that practice had a grip on me. Maybe it started with that grainy black-and-white footage of Krishnamacharya and B.K.S. Iyengar that I watched on the tail end of that acid trip I wrote about in Chapter One. Maybe that's what planted the seed.

It gave me structure when I was lost, but more than that, it gave me a sense of belonging, not just to a lineage or a set of poses, but to a community. I had taken a path that pulled me away from the worlds I grew up in. I wasn't part of the Jewish community anymore, at least not in a way that felt grounded or alive. And my old friends didn't understand the path I'd taken. They were headed in more conventional directions.

The truth is, I just didn't feel like I belonged anywhere, and Ashtanga Yoga gave me that feeling. It gave me something to be part of. A tribe. A shared language. And honestly, I think most of us are just trying to find some place where we feel like we belong.

So that's what I found in Ashtanga Yoga. There were people from all over the globe waking up before dawn, practicing the same sequences as me, and making a pilgrimage to Mysore every year or so. We'd swap stories, laugh, eat together,

and wake up the next day to get our asses kicked again in that hot, crowded yoga room. There was an intimacy in that, a sense that we were all part of something special.

We all carried a kind of superiority over other forms of yoga, too. We told ourselves we were doing something deeper, something more evolved. Iyengar Yoga was too stiff, too obsessed with alignment and props, and holding everything in place. Hatha Yoga was for people who needed a nap more than a practice. Anusara? That was for people who liked their yoga with affirmations and rainbows. Power Yoga was Ashtanga ripped off and sold for parts at the gym. Kundalini was just... weird. Ours? That was the real yoga.

I remember a T-shirt they were selling when Jois was on tour in San Diego in the early 2000s. It said, *Ashtanga Yoga: Pure for Sure*. It sold like hot cakes. That shirt summed up the whole vibe, this belief that we were doing something authentic, ancient, and uncorrupted. We were the real yogis. The true lineage. The pure ones.

What we refused to admit was that Ashtanga was basically calisthenics dressed up as ancient wisdom. The truth is, what most of us call yoga today wasn't passed down from some ancient lineage. It was put together in the early 1900s in India to promote strength and national pride. T. Krishnamacharya, the man I saw in that 1938 footage during the tail end of my LSD trip back in Chapter One, pulled from Swedish gymnastics, Indian wrestling, British military drills, and mashed it into something that looked ancient enough to pass. We thought we were part of something timeless. Really, we were practicing a modern invention with a mythic backstory.

But like many of my friends, I really needed to believe that it was ancient. I needed that feeling of being part of something timeless, sacred, and elite. It gave meaning to a part of me that still felt so untethered. But over time, the cracks started to show.

By the time my business partnership with my co-teacher in San Francisco fell apart in my late thirties, I was ready to walk away from all things Ashtanga. I'd outgrown the adolescent vibe, the intensity, the hierarchy, and the blind devotion, so I stopped going back to Mysore. I distanced myself from Jois and took no part in the community that had once meant everything to me.

But at fifty, I was still getting on the mat every day, still clinging to that idea of purity. I was still chasing the same intensity, the same discipline, like some ghost of my younger self might finally hand me a gold star. I told myself I had moved on. But I hadn't. I was still carrying the same rigidity, the same drive, the same instinct to push through. I hadn't really left that world behind. I'd just brought

it with me.

ONE LAST TEST

At one of my lowest points, my mentor Kathy gently suggested I pull back in my yoga practice. Maybe the fatigue and gut pain were related. But I couldn't hear her. I wasn't ready to. I still believed yoga was holding me together. It was the only place I could unplug, the one thing that made the rest of my life feel manageable, and, if I'm honest, the one thing I could still control. I didn't think it was hurting me. I thought it was saving me.

Then, I heard about a class led by Kevin, someone I knew from the yoga community. I told myself I was going for inspiration, maybe to reconnect with the practice. But if I'm honest, I was looking for proof. Proof that I still had it, that at fifty, I was still strong, still flexible, still vital. Going to that class felt like one last shot at outrunning the truth my body had been trying to tell me for years.

One morning in Kevin's class, he asked if I wanted to work on drop-backs. I said I did. A drop-back is a full-body surrender. You lean backward, hands reaching for the floor behind you, chest wide open. It's a move that only works if you know where your limits are. I didn't.

I arched my back and let him guide my hips forward until my hands touched the floor. Then he told me to walk my hands closer to my feet. I did, even as my body protested. I told myself to trust him, but really, I was just overriding my system. The override wasn't subtle. It was loud and practiced. I heard the old voice again, the one from Mysore, the one that said: *You're fine. Just keep going.* That voice had been running the show for so long, I didn't even notice it was a choice.

He pulled my wrists toward my heels, past what I knew was safe. I didn't stop him. I was too caught up in proving I still had it. Then my back gave out. Not a pop or a snap, more like something deep inside me finally saying, *No*. I froze, holding my breath, trying to keep my face neutral so he wouldn't notice.

He said something about good work and moved on to another student. I stayed there for a few breaths, pretending to adjust, pretending I was fine. But I wasn't. I knew something had gone wrong. I just wasn't ready to admit it, not to him, and definitely not to myself.

I wish I could say Kevin's drop-back was the first time I ignored my body, but it wasn't. I'd been training myself for years to override what I felt. Mysore

had taught me that pain was part of the path. When Jois repeatedly wrenched my leg into half lotus until my knee popped, I told myself it was just part of the tradition.

But with Kevin, I didn't have that excuse. He wasn't a guru or wrapped in any mystique. He was just a guy helping me into a pose. And still, I let it happen. I pushed past what I knew was safe. I didn't need a guru to fuck me up. I was doing just fine on my own.

THE RECKONING BEGINS

I went home that morning and tried everything I usually did when my body acted up. I scraped my back with a *gua sha* tool. I stretched. I backed off poses. I tried to ease into it, but nothing helped. The pain would not let go.

Then Melissa looked at me and said, "You're not okay. You look like hell, and I don't want to keep watching you kill yourself, telling yourself this is okay."

I almost told her to buzz off. I didn't want to hear it, not because she was wrong, but because admitting it meant I couldn't keep pretending. She was right. I was in over my head. I'd spent years overriding my body, but now it wasn't asking. It was demanding. My body had had enough.

I didn't need another stretch or supplement. I needed something that would make it impossible to hide from myself anymore.

The Good Kid

I didn't know it yet, but something had broken loose inside me. After Kevin's class, I couldn't stop thinking about what had happened. Not just the physical pain, but the fact that I had let it happen. I watched myself get hurt and did nothing to stop it. I even went along with it.

Yes, I knew I was pushing too hard and that I was burned out, but something older was driving me in that moment. I had turned against myself like I was the enemy. Even as I was coming undone, some part of me was still telling me to push harder, to keep going, to hold my shit together.

That voice didn't sound loud or cruel. It just felt normal. Familiar. It had always been there.

But now it was wrecking me, and I needed to figure out why.

NO LONGER LYING TO MYSELF

But instead of jumping straight into therapy, I returned to something I already trusted. I was already part of a community that I had been sitting with for a decade. The couple who led our circle, Shemesh and Sofía, had become more than guides. They were friends and, in many ways, family. (I've changed their names here to protect their privacy.) His music carried the room. She held the space with a kind of grounded tenderness that made it safe to fall apart. We traveled together, sat through long nights of song and silence, shared meals, stories, and prayers. They were the ones we trusted to hold the space for us in our darkest, loneliest places.

So it wasn't that I went to *ayahuasca* to check out. I went because it was the safest, most held space for me to face what I tended to skip over. It was the one place I couldn't lie to myself. And after I pushed too far in Kevin's class, I knew I couldn't keep pretending I was fine. I needed help finding the one thing I couldn't get to on my own, whatever it was that was hiding under the surface but messing with everything.

The room was dark, except for the crackling in the hearth and the faint glow of a full moon spilling through the back windows. Outside, you could just make out the outline of snow-capped mountains. We were sitting on a rug, our knees tucked in, our backs straight. Shemesh was to my left, Melissa to my right, while a semicircle of others surrounded us. No one spoke. The only sound was Shemesh, chanting soft, steady, ancient healing songs meant to steer the medicine and steady the room.

But when the medicine came on that night, it completely ambushed me. One moment, I was upright. Next, I felt this hot and dizzying surge drop me onto the shag rug. I could feel my pulse go wild, and I fought the urge to panic.

Then the visuals overwhelmed me. I saw these kaleidoscopic colors, shapes that made no sense, corridors folding in on themselves. Then more heat, cold, and sweat. My thighs began trembling uncontrollably.

At the same time, I could hear the soft shh-shh of the *chakapa*, a bundle of dried leaves that Shemesh shook in a steady rhythm, like a gentle brush against the air. The sound gave me just enough to hold onto.

Then I felt this deep, profound exhaustion, like my energy had completely dropped out from under me. I saw this image of a piece of fruit, maybe an orange, bruised and soft on one side. The skin looked intact, but you could tell it had been rotting inward, like it was collapsing on itself, and it wasn't ever going to go back to being firm again.

It felt like me. I had drawn myself so inward and downward. I had withdrawn from everything and everyone around me. I couldn't let myself be seen like that, not in that state. It would've felt like breaking the oldest rule I'd learned: don't be weak.

And the image of the rotting orange gave way to this loneliness that felt older than the moment. I wasn't just collapsing inward. I was collapsing alone. I wasn't sharing any of it. I was still pushing myself through sessions, wearing the mask I always had. At the same time, I was slowly disappearing from my relationships and anything that didn't have to do with work. Even the closest people to me, my parents and a few friends, didn't know how bad it had gotten. Not because they didn't care, but because I couldn't bear the thought of them

seeing me fall apart.

I know how this might sound if you've never done psychedelics. It can seem like just a bunch of strange visuals or hallucinations. But the altered state didn't give me anything I didn't already know. It just stripped away the noise until I could finally see what was actually going on.

I remember walking away from that ceremony, looking at Melissa, and feeling this intense guilt. Up until then, I'd been convincing myself I was managing some private inner battle, but that was a lie. She had been managing it with me, even as I kept pulling away. The weight of it was not just on my shoulders. It was on hers, too. And that was too much to place on one person.

I had withdrawn so far from my other relationships that she had become my only outlet, for better or worse. She was handling everything. The logistics. Our life. And all the while, she was carrying the emotional weight of watching me come undone. She was the one making sure I didn't fall apart while I kept pretending I was fine. I had been so deep in it that I couldn't see what it was costing her.

That ceremony didn't offer relief, but it did offer clarity. I finally saw that I was not strong enough, not smart enough, and not evolved enough to figure this out alone. And I couldn't keep leaning on Melissa to carry something that had clearly become too much. I needed someone else to be in it with me.

I hadn't worked with Randall in years. Melissa and I had seen him together back when things were calmer, before everything started to crack. But when I realized I couldn't keep holding all of this alone, he was the one I thought of. I needed someone who could meet me in my loneliness and pain without rushing to fix it.

THE KNOT

"Where do we start?" Randall asked.

I didn't even know where to start. My body felt like it was coming apart, and I was out of tools to hold it all together. So I just said the first honest thing I could: "My gut's a wreck. It cramps all the time. It feels bloated and tight. I'm wiped out. My back hurts. I can't sleep. Everything's just..." I gave a half-laugh. "Honestly? I feel like I'm coming apart. Randall, can you fix me?"

And then he chuckled. "Alright. Why don't you close your eyes? Take a breath. See what's going on in there."

That was the last thing I wanted to do, but I sat back and then closed my eyes. I scanned my body. It didn't take long.

"There's this knot," I said, without opening my eyes. "In my gut. It's low down and deep. It just sits there."

He waited.

"It feels stuck, like a rock in there." I opened my eyes, swallowed. "Like something's been sitting in there for years, and it doesn't want to move."

I stayed with it longer than I usually would. I wasn't analyzing it, just feeling it: the heat, the density, the way it pulsed, like it had been waiting for me to notice it all along.

It got more intense for a moment, but the longer I stayed, the less it scared me.

At some point, as the feelings began to settle, Randall asked, "If it could talk... what might it say?"

I shifted in the chair. I looked down. "I don't know. Probably something like... 'I'm holding it together.'" I paused. "I've always been holding it together."

Then I felt my throat tighten.

THE CONFESSION

And then, it popped out. "Before he took his life, Scott was the problem. I was the proof our family wasn't totally fucked up. I was the good kid."

I exhaled. "His death didn't give me that role. It just made it permanent."

And it's not like I chose it. My dad was always on the road, and when he was home, his moods could turn on a dime. Sometimes he'd snap over small things. Other times, he'd go quiet without explanation, and I'd be left trying to piece together what I'd done wrong. My mom was in over her head trying to raise two boys, one with undiagnosed mental illness, and the other pretending he was fine. I figured out fast that I couldn't add to the chaos, so I learned to be low-maintenance.

By the time he was ten, Scott's body was covered in hair. He worked out like a fiend and got buff. The other kids smelled weirdness on him like blood in the water. They teased him mercilessly. One called him Neanderthal.

I, on the other hand, got good grades. I made things easy for my parents compared to Scott. And then over time, I got completely lost in that role, so completely that I even forgot I was playing one.

The unspoken rule was: Don't cause problems. *Your brother is already enough to deal with. Play your part, or we'll ship you off to boarding school.*

So I learned early: if I had problems, I was on my own. I learned to go to my room if I was upset, overwhelmed, or too much. To shut the door and figure it out myself.

Randall nodded. He didn't fill the space. He just let me sit in it.

"A few days after we buried him," I said, "I was sent back to school with no space to grieve. Just go. The message was clear: 'You're fine. You got this.'"

Nobody said it directly, but the message was: *We're already dealing with enough. We can't worry about you, too.*

So I did what I always did. I pulled my shit together as best as I could. I doubled down on being the good kid, the one who was okay. Not because I made some conscious decision, but because I couldn't stand to make it any harder on them than it already was. And maybe also because having a son who took his own life already carried enough stigma. I couldn't risk adding to it.

I didn't look at Randall. I didn't move. It felt like I'd said something I wasn't allowed to, that I'd broken a pact I never agreed to. Part of me wanted to take it back. Admitting this made my chest tight. Heat rushed to my face.

For a moment, I just sat in it: the shame, the heat, the fear. It got more intense, and then slowly it calmed down again. I didn't push it away. I just let myself feel it.

And then I said, "Looking good was a shield we all learned to hide behind. With Scott having taken his life, I had to prove we were still respectable. We were already the family with the kid who killed himself. I couldn't give people something else to whisper about."

And it didn't help that we lived in a culture that worshiped perfection. The rule was clearly to hold your shit together. No matter what was breaking inside, you keep going, you stay productive, and you never let them see your weakness. After Scott took his life, that's how I survived.

I could feel the tightness in my gut throb now. It was the same ache I'd tried to stretch out, meditate away, and bury in accomplishments. But now I wasn't turning away from it. I was turning toward it. And as uncomfortable as it was, something about it felt honest, like I was finally naming something I hadn't let myself say out loud.

Because the truth is, I couldn't have turned toward it any sooner. Not with the messaging I grew up with: *You got this. You're fine. Keep going. Unless you're the star, unless you're shining, stay in your room. Don't make it harder. Don't add weight. Contribute something. Be what your brother wasn't.* That was the subtext.

So I became like that rotting orange I'd seen on the medicine, still intact on the outside, but caved in on the inside. Hidden. Held back. I spent years trying to overcome the ache through some trick of yoga, some breakthrough in meditation, or some new spiritual tool. But those were all ways of managing around it, not through it.

It was only now that I was beginning to understand what I had spent so many years trying not to feel: the grief, the shame, the pressure, the role, and the silence. And now, I was finally starting to face it.

Still, no matter how much Randall and I unpacked it, life wasn't about to let me off easy. Just as I was beginning to understand the roots of that pain, things got harder in the one place I thought was safe, with the friends I trusted most to hold me in my time of need.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Walls

By then, they weren't just friends. They were like family. We'd spent almost a decade in ceremony together through nights of *ayahuasca*, song, and silence. We celebrated each other's birthdays and showed up for one another in the hardest moments of our lives.

So when their house burned down in the summer of 2020, we didn't hesitate. We took them in immediately, welcomed them and their daughter, making space in our lives without a second thought. Melissa helped them find a rental in a good school district, and when they moved into their new home, we gave them furniture and drove for hours to help them set up. We weren't doing them a favor. It was just what you do when you love people.

THE FIRST SIGN OF TROUBLE

Then one weekend, while we were helping them set up their new place, Melissa and I saw an alert on our phones: an atmospheric river was heading for California. We'd never heard the term before, but it sounded ominous. We made the decision to leave a day early. We expected understanding, something like, "Hey, totally get it, better to be safe."

But instead, Sofía got sharp. She pushed hard on the guilt. Why were we leaving? They'd taken their daughter out of school to be with us, stocked the kitchen, and we all had plans for the weekend. How could we just leave?

And just like that, I could feel the wall go down. It was instantaneous. I'd experienced this before. My brother Scott could flip on a dime like that. One

moment, I was someone to him, and the next, I was nobody. And there it was again, only this time it wasn't my brother, it was Sofía.

THE SLOW FADE

What followed was a slow fade. We kept seeing each other for events and ceremonies, but then we sent a simple message asking to talk, and days went by with nothing but silence.

Eventually, we received a cryptic voice message about how the medicine had shown her something about us, something she couldn't speak about despite our requests. Several months went by without a word. It was like being locked out of a major part of our lives.

At first, we questioned ourselves. Maybe we had done something wrong. Then shame crept in, followed by confusion, and eventually hurt.

Then I finally got Shemesh on the phone. I thought maybe we'd get some clarity there, but what he said confused me. Sofía believed Melissa had flirted with him and that the medicine had told her to cut contact with us to protect her family. It didn't make sense to me, and still it hurt.

But here's the thing: if Melissa had flirted, it wouldn't have meant anything. She's warm with everyone. It might read as flirtation, but only if you're looking for something nefarious, because that's part of Melissa's charm. It's who she is.

After all those years and all that we'd been through, I couldn't understand how Sofía could read Melissa that way. What made it worse was hearing Shemesh say he didn't believe Melissa had flirted with him, but still realizing he was going along with Sofía.

Despite all the times they said they loved us, there wasn't a single conversation. Not one. No one asked what happened. No one said, "That hurt." We could have handled confusion, even conflict. But silence does something different. It works on you. It makes you question your worth, your sanity, and whether any of it was ever what you thought it was.

I kept reaching back out to Shemesh, asking if we could talk. Not to argue. Not to defend ourselves. Just to sit down together and try to understand what had happened. I told him we could work it out. I meant all of us.

For a while, he tried. He said he'd talk to her. He said he understood why this mattered to me, to us. And then, quietly, the effort stopped, and the door closed.

WHAT HURT THE MOST

What stung wasn't the accusation. It was how easily we were dropped. Like we hadn't mattered the way I thought we did. And I think the hardest part for me was how he didn't take responsibility for what had happened.

Shemesh wasn't just a friend. He was like a brother, and having lost my real brother, I don't use that word lightly. He knew things about my health, my struggles, and my fears that I didn't share with most people. I never really held back with him.

There was one moment that really stuck with me. My health was in the dirt, and I was feeling exhausted. In the middle of the ceremony, he started to sing Tom Petty's *Walls*, the one about how even the hardest defenses eventually give way.

He wasn't singing it to me, but his voice had this way of slipping past the mind and straight into the heart. In that moment, I could feel something softening between us, a kind of brotherly warmth I hadn't known before.

With Scott, that kind of connection was never really possible, not because I didn't want it, but because it was too complicated and too fraught. So it wasn't that I lost that bond with him, it was more that I never got to have it in the first place.

As Shemesh sang, something in me began to open. It felt unfamiliar, like a part of me had always wanted that kind of closeness and was finally letting it in. He had always been a little reserved, a little hard to read, not someone who let people in easily. Even after years of sitting in ceremony together, there was still a distance.

But little by little, that started to change. We began to let our guards down, and as the friendship took form, it felt like something rare was taking shape, the kind of trust that builds slowly without needing to be spoken.

I'd cry a lot in those ceremonies, and he teased me a bit, but it was always brotherly, not cruel. Afterward, we'd laugh and crack jokes. We didn't always have the deepest conversations, but we didn't need to. We knew we mattered to one another without even having to say it.

And it's not like I didn't love Sofía, too. One of the things she knew I really struggled with was faith. Having grown up in an atheistic family, faith had always felt foreign. I remember one night, she took me out to a quiet spot on their land where other rituals had taken place. She asked me to kneel and pray. At first, I doubted anything would come of it, but under that moonlight, I felt connected to God in a way I never had before.

And then, right before things ended, she showed me how to ceremonially smoke tobacco through a pipe. I remember sitting beside her and feeling her nurturing presence. Between the music, the medicine, and the tobacco, I started to feel how my prayers might be focused. At the time, I didn't think I'd lose all of that overnight.

THE SEND-OFF

So when it all crumbled, my first instinct was to give him some of that poison back. First, I texted him, "I'm out."

Then, in a moment of total reactivity, I tried to hurt him as much as they had hurt us. I aimed straight for his marriage. I texted him that his wife was a "mess" and told him to call me when he was ready to get out.

It was the exact opposite of the work I teach, but I felt abandoned, so I tried to burn the house down on my way out.

For months, I tried to move on. Melissa and I both did. But then my health started to return. I was coming out of the crisis I'd written about in the previous chapters, and in that moment, I was ready to let go.

So I wrote a letter apologizing for my text and explaining that it came from a place of hurt. I said I was no longer holding anger, and that what I really wanted was to thank them for everything they had given me. I told them I still loved them. I even said the break had been a blessing, and I meant it. I believed that if it hadn't happened, I might never have healed.

But the reply I got was polite, spiritual, and final. He wished us well, but he didn't leave the door open.

When I read it, my body sank. I wasn't looking for a repair or a way back in. I just wanted some acknowledgment that we had mattered.

Instead, the message read more like, this was just one of those things that happens, unfortunate, but not anyone's responsibility, something to accept, not necessarily address. Maybe that was true, given the confusion and projection that can show up in those kinds of spaces. But on my side, it felt hollow, like being gently dismissed instead of met.

It made me wonder if our friendship was as solid as I believed it was.

These days, I have a hard time listening to recordings of Shemesh's music, not because it isn't beautiful, but because of what it means now. It used to feel like a lifeline, like someone else was helping me pray when I didn't know how

to myself. Now, when his voice comes on, my body shuts down. I can't take it in the same way. I hear the beauty, but I don't trust it.

He used to say, "I love you," without hesitation. He called on weekends just to check in on us. You could see that the friendship mattered to him, which is why, when it came time to protect the friendship, standing by us would have meant risking the comfort he'd gotten used to with her. He didn't.

That's when I understood the friendship wasn't going to be protected, not by accident, but by choice. And it's not that he denied it or lied about it. I laid it out, and he shrugged and said that's just what he had to do. I didn't feel him fight for it. No attempt to hold both realities at once, like the decision had already been made for him.

And that's where it broke for me. He didn't stand up when it mattered. And with it, something in me pulled back, the part that thought being close to someone meant you were safe, the part that wanted to believe love meant you'd be protected, the part that still hadn't let go of the hope that if you show up for people, they'll show up for you, too.

The whole thing made me question whether we fit into their lives mostly when it was easy, when we showed up to ceremony, helped, and contributed. But when we became even a little challenging, there was no space for us.

We weren't shut out completely. We were technically welcome back, but only if we pretended nothing had happened.

In that dynamic, I didn't feel like a friend. I felt like a follower. My belonging was conditional on my agreement. And the moment I couldn't agree anymore, I stopped belonging.

Shemesh went along with it. I don't know what he told himself. All I know is that he made his choice. And I had to accept that he wasn't going to do what I wanted him to do.

I'M FINE.

That silence reminded me of something that had happened that I thought I had outgrown when I was six years old. I asked my dad to tuck me in, like he always did, but that night, for some reason, he just said no. He locked himself in the office where he worked and refused to come out.

I remember crying outside his door for what felt like hours, begging. I must have thought I did something wrong. Why else would he shut me out? Eventually, I gave up and went to bed, but I couldn't sleep. I tossed and turned, waiting

for the door to open, for his footsteps, for anything that would undo what had just happened, some small sign that I still mattered to him. But none came. I think I cried myself to sleep.

Then the next morning, my mom said, "I heard what happened with your dad."

I shrugged. "It doesn't matter. I'm fine," I said.

I wasn't.

Looking back, that night outside my dad's office was like an echo of what I experienced in my grandparents' den, that having needs made you too much. Something clicked in me. If needing got me locked out or kicked out of the family, I wouldn't let myself need. I learned to turn that part of me off.

That's where my wound took form. It's not just sadness or longing, but a deep bruise that learned needing was dangerous, and closeness came at a cost.

I still want depth. I still want closeness. But too often, the version of connection on offer only works as long as nothing gets complicated. I've learned how to stay easy, agreeable, and low-maintenance to keep the peace and to stay included. The cost is that I'm rarely fully seen.

That's why when this friendship ended, it cut so deeply. It didn't come out of nowhere. It echoed what I'd already learned: that when your presence becomes inconvenient, the door closes. And when no one comes back, the reflex is the same one I learned long ago:

I'm fine.

I end up swallowing the need.

Even though I know that reflex by heart, I'm clear now. I'm no longer willing to hold my truth back just to stay connected.

Snot All

That moment outside my dad's door was the beginning of a lifelong pattern. When it hurt, I learned to lock it down. When I needed too much, I turned inward. And when the people I loved went silent on me, I told myself I was fine. The shame around my own need kept finding new ways to surface. The loss of our friends brought it all roaring back.

But there *was* one stretch of time in my life where I didn't keep it together, where I didn't have to perform, at least not too much.

As I mentioned in Chapter Two, when I finished acupuncture school, rather than setting up an acupuncture business, I decided to move to India to be with Monica and her two boys. With that move, I took a position at a healing center called Quiet, where we would treat clients in the morning and then gather for lunch in the afternoons.

We were a patchwork crew of healers: massage therapists, acupuncturists, movement teachers, and more. We came from places as different as India, Spain, Iran, Holland, Israel, and the States, but once we sat down together, those borders blurred. We could sit over long lunches of rice, lentils, and spicy okra, swapping stories about our lives, where we'd come from, what we cared about, and what we were hoping for.

The friends that I met didn't care or even think to wonder whether I was a trust-fund child. To them, I was neither special nor disappointing. I was just Chad, an American. That's all I was to them. And what a relief it was just to be me.

The life I discovered there was nothing I was raised to want. Monica was Italian, twelve years older, divorced, with two young boys. Every part of that

relationship would've been a giant no in the world I grew up in, but none of it mattered once I was actually living inside that life instead of imagining it from the outside.

The rules I'd been handed back home started to loosen. Days unfolded by feel instead of expectation. I was working, cooking, riding my bike through the jungle roads, showing up for her kids, and slowly noticing that I wasn't performing for anyone.

It was in those years, in the simple rhythm of our lives, that I discovered almost a new identity. Who I thought I was supposed to be faded, and a different me began to take form, not all at once, but in these fleeting moments where I felt free without needing to prove it.

I remember Monica and me dancing in a clearing in the jungle, barefoot on red dirt, the air thick with humidity and jungle scent, a warm breeze drifting in from the Indian Ocean. Someone had rigged up speakers, and *Thievery Corporation*, or something else from that early-2000s wave of dreamy, grounded electronica, pulsed through.

Most people were barefoot, some shirtless, dressed in whatever felt good on the skin. No one was trying to look a certain way. These were farmers, healers, and artists. People who lived simply but moved with unselfconscious freedom.

What moved me most was looking around and seeing all ages dancing together: teenagers and elders, toddlers on shoulders, people in their sixties and seventies, all dancing as if age never existed. It was just music, movement, and communal rhythm.

It reminded me of being at a bar or bat mitzvah and dancing the *Hora*. That sense that we were all caught in this communal moment of joy. But in this case, there was no choreography or circle. Just freedom. People passing joints around. Nobody scanning the room or pretending to be something that they weren't. Everyone belonging in this tribal sense of release.

And yet something in me kept whispering that this wasn't who I was supposed to be. I was supposed to be put together. This was not put together. This was me coming undone in the best possible way. And somehow, it felt purer than anything I'd known.

THE CRASH

Eventually, Monica and I split, and I came home. I loved my life there, but I couldn't see a future I could build on. Between the guilt of being away from

my parents, the instability of visas, the sense that I was living on family wealth I hadn't earned, and my own struggle to find a place inside Monica's family, all of it caught up to me.

So I came home hoping to build a life that felt like my own. At first, I felt like I could still hold on to the new identity I'd discovered there, but then in 2008, when the financial crash hit, something in me woke up. Each morning, I'd open the news and see my inheritance quickly dissolving away. I was rattled inside, feeling completely unmoored. I don't think I'd ever felt that exposed.

That was it. I had to find a way to be an earner. So I hired a coach, and she taught me how to forecast my finances and held me accountable until I earned what I projected. Within six months, I'd doubled my numbers. But underneath the obsession to make money was really me just trying to feel safe again.

If you'd seen my old website before the financial crisis, you'd have landed on a picture of a guy lying on an acupuncture table with needles sticking out of every inch of him, his face, chest, feet, even his ears. The caption read, "Now, tell me again. How does this help my stress?"

It definitely didn't scream sleek wellness aesthetic. And honestly, it was perfect. It basically said, "I know this looks weird, but I'm not going to try to convince you otherwise. Here I am. Take it or leave it."

But as the digits on my brokerage screen slid lower each morning, that irreverent, grounded part of me faded. What once felt steady now seemed reckless. Fear stepped in and took the wheel.

So I took the site down, built a slicker one, cleaned up the tone, dropped the jokes, and started to look professional. And with it, that irreverent, unfazed part of me disappeared, too. All of a sudden, that was someone I couldn't afford to be.

But the more polished version worked. I started making money and gaining traction. And then I went from being an acupuncturist to having a coaching career that looked pretty successful from the outside. I was finally able to say with a straight face, "See, Grandpa, I do make money."

And I needed that. I did. I needed to know I could put my head down and actually build something of my own. I'm not ashamed of that chapter. It showed me what I was capable of.

But there is a part that's hard to admit. Even coaching, the work I fought so hard to discover, had turned into a performance. I could easily slip into the role of the guy who knew how to hold space, ask the right questions, and reflect back what wasn't being said. But even here, I had something to prove, and I got rewarded for it while other parts of me were cracking underneath the surface.

The truth is, I didn't just build a business. I built an identity. One that looked wise, but was just another mask. The more I succeeded, the more trapped I felt. Like I'd finally found something I was good at, but couldn't stop performing long enough to know if I still wanted it. My career had become an addiction. I knew it was warping me. But I couldn't put it down.

And it wasn't just work I couldn't put down. It was also my yoga practice. I stayed loyal to it long after I knew better. I continued to bow to self-abuse in the name of tradition, even when I knew it hurt.

FROM CONTROL TO INTIMACY

Even after I stopped going back to Mysore and lost contact with the wider Ashtanga community, the old patterns stayed in my body, especially the drive to push harder, to prove myself, and to override physical pain. That wiring didn't start with me; it came straight from the source of the method.

Pattabhi Jois taught that the body had to be purified and brought under control, that spiritual clarity came through discipline. And I absorbed that belief. I came to see exhaustion and pain as the price of progress. I learned to distrust my own instincts for rest, softness, or moderation. I kept believing that if the poses were extreme enough and the pace relentless enough, I could somehow wipe out the part of me that felt fragile and tender, the very part that had brought me to yoga in the first place. I imagined a sudden moment when everything unresolved in me would disappear, like it had never been there at all.

As I wrote in Chapter Five, eventually my body couldn't hold the strain anymore. It started saying no, and it wasn't subtle or soft. That no cracked something open. It made me realize that what I'd been calling devotion was, in many ways, disconnection. And it forced me to start asking the question I had avoided for years: *What if discipline wasn't supposed to hurt?*

In the last few years, I've had to rethink yoga. It's no longer about discipline and control, but about a relationship with my body, with my breath, with myself. Not bypassing what I feel. Not blasting through it. Just staying. Listening. Moving closer, not pushing through.

The old version said: *override*. This one says: *stay*, especially in that tender spot, the one that tightens when I feel vulnerable, the one that used to make me push harder just to avoid it. When the ache rises in my chest, and I want to breathe it away, stretch past it, or power through it, the work now is to stay

with it. To listen. To let it speak through breath and movement. To trust that it carries something I need to hear, something I can't discover through force.

Some days, I can stay with that vulnerability long enough to let the breath soften me. Slowly, the body opens, and in that opening, something lets go. Not all at once, but just enough to reveal what's underneath: that tenderness, still waiting.

Other days, I override without realizing it, the old reflex kicking in before I catch it. I only notice it afterward, when everything feels off: tight, dull, or drained. But even that doesn't feel like failure anymore. It's just another moment to return. Another chance to listen more closely next time.

And in those moments where I stay and the ones where I miss it, I remember what this has all been for: to be in relationship with myself. To stay connected to whatever is moving through me, whether it's pleasure or pain, strength or softness. To keep showing up. To keep listening. To learn how to stay without abandoning what's here.

I've stopped chasing breakthroughs. I don't believe in some transcendent state waiting for me. I believe in this moment, and in this body. It's staying with that tender spot at the heart of it, and in letting the ache teach me how to soften, how to move, and how to love what's here.

That's the shift: from control to intimacy.

LETTING THE BODY SPEAK

These days, I still show up to my mat, but I've also started dancing. After years of overriding, pushing, and performing, dance gave me a way to move that wasn't about progress or purification. It was just about being here, in the pleasure of music and movement.

And what surprised me is that this, too, felt like practice. Not in the way I had been taught, but in a way that still asks for presence, still calls for devotion, only now through instinct and rhythm and aliveness.

My teacher, Kathy, was the one who first showed me how. Not as a guru, but as a friend who had been dancing longer than I had. There was no power trip, no demand to override my instincts. No pressure to bow at her feet or treat her like some enlightened being. Just an invitation to trust my body, to let it speak, not as a path to achievement, but as a path to expression.

Sometimes that happens on a Sunday morning in a big gymnasium with Melissa and a hundred or so friends. Sometimes it's at Esalen, a retreat center

perched above the cliffs of Big Sur, where the ocean pounds the rocks below, and the air smells like salt and sage. We're in a room full of sweat and motion, in a community where no one needs to explain anything. We just move.

At first, everything feels tight. My movements are contained. I'm self-conscious. I can feel that subtle fear of not wanting to look stupid. The music is slow, spacious, not telling me what to do, just offering something to move with. Just enough to help me feel my breath, feel my feet.

As I keep moving, I notice I feel a little freer. The energy builds layer by layer. The attention that was in my head starts to drop down into my body. I stop correcting myself so much. I let the beat start to lead.

Then my body begins to move the way it wants to move. I start to feel the music moving through me, like it knows what I need before I do. None of my shapes are planned anymore. They just happen. I twist. I sway. I reach. The tracks get bolder, more alive, and so do I. I doubt any of it looks graceful, but I don't care how it looks anymore.

I'm starting to trust how it feels. And the more I trust it, the freer it gets.

Somehow in that movement, I can feel the old story loosening, the one about how to move, how to be. The more my body lets go, the more I do, too.

This is the life I wasn't supposed to want. It doesn't look like the one I was raised for. But it's mine.

A few weeks ago, Melissa and I had one of those arguments we unfortunately seem to find our way back to. Normally, we recover fairly quickly. This time, we didn't. We both walked away feeling raw, misunderstood, and alone.

A few days later, Greg reached out. He offered to hold space if I wanted to talk.

My first instinct was to deflect the offer. We've known each other for only a year and not that well. But something in me, maybe the crack that had just opened, made me say yes.

We got on the call, and I started telling him what had happened. I was careful at first, maybe not quite trusting he could hold me, but he just listened.

At some point, I broke. I lost it. Full-on sobbing. I remember having my hand over my face, trying to hide. And Greg said gently, "I'd like you to take your hand down so I can see you."

For a second, I hesitated. But then I made the choice. I lowered my hand and let him see me crying, snot running, a complete mess. In that moment, I wasn't keeping it together. I was just being me, snot and all. I let myself be seen, and that felt different.

It took me decades, but I finally said yes when someone reached out. I didn't

deflect or pretend I was fine. And then, I let myself be seen, not as a doer trying to prove something, not as a schnorrer begging to be let in, but just as I am. The doorway didn't change. I did. I stopped waiting for proof that it was safe to walk through.

My Way Home

I didn't write this book because I wanted to. I wrote it because I had to. But that's not how it began. At first, I thought it was just a project, a way to market my work. A former client suggested I put together a "funnel." I didn't even know what that meant. Basically, I would write a training, he'd run ads, and people would sign up to work with me.

So I did it. I pulled together something on helping entrepreneurs push through the roadblocks I had seen over and over. On the surface, it worked fine. It was polished, smart, maybe even useful. But when I read it back, it did not sound like me.

Before we put it out, my friend Malu asked what it was really about. I told her it wasn't about anything, just a sales tool. She shook her head and said, "That doesn't sound like you. I bet it's about something more." But it wasn't. So we launched it anyway. Two people signed up, and the funnel flopped.

But I couldn't stop circling back to what I'd written. There was something underneath it that kept tugging at me. What began as a marketing idea cracked open something bigger: the questions and stories I'd buried for years. That was when the writing started to shift. The polished training gave way to something more raw and closer to the bone.

I didn't know it then, but what I was really doing was knocking on that same closed door I'd been standing outside my whole life, the one that always seemed to shut whenever I needed to be met. Writing became the first place where I didn't wait for someone to open it.

This book grew from that shift. The very material I once tried to package

into a sales tool became my mirror. Those roadblocks I thought I was writing about in others turned out to be my own.

WRITING FOR MY LIFE

This was during the stretch when my health was breaking down, the time I talk about in Chapters Four, Five, and Six. It was also when I was taking a writing class on Zoom with my friend Lori. She'd give us a prompt, set a timer for five or ten minutes, and the only rule was: tell the truth. Write the way you write. Don't edit.

Lori loved to remind us of something May Sarton once said: "If we are to understand the human condition, we have to be willing to go naked." [18]

Truth-telling and nakedness were the same thing in that class, and it both terrified and freed me.

My classmates wrote the raw, unfiltered truth. They wrote about addiction, bad sex, estranged parents, you name it. Much of it was unfiltered, and I loved it. That class gave me permission to finally write about the pain in my gut, the frustrations of being chronically ill, the betrayal of our friends, and the love and gratitude I felt for Melissa for sticking by me in such a dark time.

Each piece I wrote felt like a small loosening from the inside. Every time I told the truth, I felt the air shift, less holding it together and more letting myself be held.

Sometimes, when I shared with the group, I could see my words landing, their faces changing, and sometimes even tears. Sometimes laughter. And slowly, through that process, I began to find my voice.

The more I wrote, the clearer it became that what was missing from that original version was my own story. As I mentioned in the Intro, one of my proofreaders asked me, "Why should someone like me listen to you?" The training was for leaders, founders, and creatives, and he was right. I hadn't taken their path. So why should my perspective matter?

That question sent me digging into my own story, trying to uncover what I shared with my clients. And the more I wrote, the clearer it got: like many of them, I'd spent my entire life trying to convince anyone, myself included, that I measured up.

That's when this book stopped being a project and started becoming my mirror, a way to uncover how I landed in such a dark place. At some point, I decided my tender heart was a problem to fix, a flaw to overcome. Maybe it

started in the den at my grandparents' house. Maybe it was when my father began shutting down emotionally. Maybe it was growing up in a wealthy suburb where perfection was the price of belonging. Or having a brother with a mental illness who took his life. Wherever it began, achievement and success became my escape valve. They were how I kept distance from feelings that felt too tender to bear.

WHAT A MAN WAS SUPPOSED TO BE

I learned early that to get love, I had to mold myself to other people's expectations. I had to be easy and low-maintenance. My parents already had enough to worry about with my brother. They didn't need to worry about me, too.

And then, after my brother died, my body snapped to attention. It knew exactly what to do. I stepped into the role of being okay, both to protect my parents and for the sake of appearances, so we didn't look so fucked up.

The grief lodged in my gut, buried beneath holding my shit together. That's when I learned that a man shuts down his own need, even when it's unbearable. To stay lovable, I had to keep the messy parts out of sight. Anytime I tried to touch my grief, really touch it, it slipped away again, like mist in my hands. There was sadness in there somewhere. I knew that. But it was slippery.

Even though my body kept trying to show it to me, I used yoga to override it. I assumed the goal was to purify it, to burn it off through discipline and control. But my body kept saying *no*, louder each time, until finally it screamed at me to fuck off.

Still, I kept trying to find ways to ease the weight. That's when I veered off the path I was supposed to follow. Instead of taking the expected path into business or finance, I became, of all things, an acupuncturist and herbalist. But I carried the same pressure to prove myself in that career. I doubled down on results. I had to be a real earner. That meant I couldn't be average. I had to be exceptional. And when the results were hit or miss, the old rule kicked in: either you're exceptional, or you're nothing. So I ended up tearing myself apart.

Then I stumbled into coaching. And for a while, it felt like relief. I could let go of performance. I could be curious and present. I could be myself. But even that turned into a trap. I got good at playing "wise and helpful." But underneath the success, something inside said no. My body broke down even harder. I got really sick. And when Melissa and I were cut off by the people we really trusted, it wrecked me. My health completely went to shit.

I want to say change came in one cinematic breakthrough. But it didn't. It was a long grind: feeling like shit, then a little less shitty, then maybe somewhat normal, and then back to feeling like shit again. What carried me through wasn't revelation. It was small, ordinary things: boundaries, rest, refusing to push myself past empty. It was saying no, again and again.

And somewhere in all of that, without me even noticing at first, something shifted. I lost the compulsion for validation. What I wanted instead was something not so obvious: to feel at home within myself.

That was a big shift. For most of my life, I lived as a collection of roles: the polished one who kept it together, the performer who said the right things, the achiever who proved he deserved the seat at the table, the boy who fit what others needed, the man who hid his pain. But somewhere along my healing journey, it dawned on me, not just intellectually but in my body, that if I kept performing those parts, it would kill me. It already damn near did.

QUICKSAND

Just the other week, Melissa and I were out of sync, and she asked if I still found her attractive. Instantly, I felt that old pull to perform, to say, *Of course, you're the most beautiful person in the world. I love only you, blah, blah, blah.* That line would've smoothed everything over.

But the demand to say the "right thing" lit up my whole body with quicksand-like feelings. I wanted to give the answer and move on, but this time I let myself feel it instead of shutting down.

What came out was different: "Yes, I am attracted to you. But I hate being put on the spot like that. I'd rather say it when it's honest, not when it's demanded."

The second I said it, my shoulders dropped and my breath came back. It was such a small thing, but it felt like something inside me finally gave way, a hinge loosening between performance and honesty.

THE STANDOFF

With Melissa, the boundary created connection. But with the people who taught me to perform, it isn't always that clean.

Recently, I tried to bring this new honesty to a call with my mother. She fell into a familiar loop, asking for reassurance: "I always tried my best to be a good mom... Did I do anything good?"

In the past, the performer would have jumped in to save her. Instead, I tried to stand my ground. “You did a lot of good,” I said. “But it isn’t my job to tell you that so you can feel that way. I can’t give that to you.”

I waited for the breakthrough. Instead, she pivoted completely. “I’m not telling you to change... I just hope that you want to be with us.”

She hadn’t heard me. I was talking about emotional sovereignty. She wasn’t talking about Christmas. She was trying to have me steady her again. And I had just said I wasn’t willing to do that anymore.

“I have to run,” I finally said.

I hung up and sat in the silence. I hadn’t “fixed” anything. In fact, I had just performed a different role: the therapist son. I had used my boundaries as a shield, and we had missed each other completely. It was messy and incomplete. But I realized that coming home doesn’t mean every conversation has a happy ending. Sometimes, the practice is just staying with yourself when they don’t.

LETTING MYSELF BE

These days, it’s harder to fake it. That doesn’t mean I don’t still feel guilt and shame about it. Recently, we had friends over. We all got stoned, and Melissa was being her outrageous self, which I absolutely adore. That night, she was on fire. She was hilarious and had the whole room laughing. For a while, I was right there with her, laughing so hard I could barely get a hit off the joint.

At some point, my energy dipped. I got tired and didn’t want to play along anymore. Instantly, the guilt hit, like I wasn’t being fun enough, or worse, that I was being weird. In the past, I would’ve pushed through and faked it. This time, I let myself slide into being a little more introverted.

The next morning, the shame was right there, not for anything I said or did, but for slipping out of the part I was supposed to play. Maybe I’m not the star or the center-of-the-room guy I always wanted to be. Maybe I never was. Maybe that was just a role I learned to survive.

The guilt still shows up when I’m not “on,” but I’m learning to find some acceptance for the part of me that never really got to show up until now. He isn’t always polished. He can be reserved, even a little distant, the kind of quiet that can be mistaken for aloofness. Underneath, though, I’m just careful. That’s how I learned to guard the most sensitive parts of me.

But that’s not to say I don’t want to reveal what I think or feel. I do. I just wish someone were genuinely curious, someone who actually wants to know what

makes me tick. More than anything, I want someone to ask and stay with me long enough to hear the answer. It happens so rarely, and every time it doesn't, it stings.

That pain shows up sometimes at holiday gatherings with the old crew. Around the table, the talk drifts from whose kid got into which college to the latest kitchen remodel or the vacation to Italy. My life doesn't fit that script, but I'll nod along, ask questions, and mean them. The hard part is when that same curiosity isn't returned. I can't tell if the path I've taken is too foreign for them to know what to ask, or if they just like hearing themselves talk. Either way, it hits the same: that old wound that nobody really gives a shit about my experience.

That longing to be seen used to turn into ambition. If I couldn't get someone to care about my experience, maybe I could at least get their respect. If curiosity wasn't coming, maybe applause would do.

NOTHING TO PROVE

Just the other day, an assistant to a big-name Silicon Valley founder emailed me. Once upon a time, I would've killed for a client like that. My whole nervous system would've lit up: finally, confirmation I was worth something. Instead, I sent back a short note about how I actually work and where I'm not a fit. The second I hit send, my chest unclenched, and the relief felt better than all the applause I used to need.

It's not that I'm done helping people find clarity. I love that work. I love guiding people into their bodies, helping them hear what they're trying to tell themselves. I love the moment when something clicks and the next step becomes clear. I still care deeply about this work.

But for years, shame drove me, the belief that I was just some trust-fund kid who had everything handed to me. That fear kept me always trying to prove I was better than anyone's imagined judgment. But that grip has loosened. Maybe it's because I've already coached enough high-powered people to know I don't need to prove myself anymore. Or maybe it's because getting sick loosened shame's grip on me. Whatever the reason, it's not gone, but it doesn't run the show anymore. It's not my job to justify my life or persuade anyone of my value.

What matters now is much simpler: coming home to the life in front of me, to Melissa, to the land we live on, and to my own heart.

And it's a sensitive one, this heart of mine. It feels everything deeply. That tenderness has made my life complicated and pushed me to bend toward the

wants and needs of others. If I'm honest, it has shaped everything I've lived. It's my sacred wound, but not something to fix. It makes me the man I am, the ground I stand on, the force that keeps me alive and searching. And yeah, sometimes I roll my eyes at how fucking sensitive I can be. But I'd rather be tender and alive than polished and dead inside.

I used to think being a man meant you could have feelings, but only the tidy ones, the kind you could package neatly and never make anyone uncomfortable. Now I know it's the messy ones that matter. They show me when I'm off course, and they bring me back to myself.

But that's not to say that I've always seen it that way. I used to think that the goal was to get to some final state where all that messiness was gone.

NO FINISH LINE

When I was practicing yoga with Pattabhi Jois, he would often say, "Do your practice, and all is coming." I thought that meant if I did enough yoga, I'd heal all my wounds, and then I'd feel eternally blissful. That bottomless weight in my gut would vanish. And then, like the Oscars, someone would hand me an award and say, "Congratulations, you made it." I even pictured myself standing on that stage, thanking my guru, my parents, and everyone who helped me get there.

Needless to say, the award never came, but if there's any prize, it's learning not to run from the ache but to listen to it. The ache doesn't hand me answers. It shows me the cost of all the ways I've performed, betrayed myself for love, and bent to belong. It's the same ache that used to keep me waiting outside, wanting someone else to say I was enough. Now it's just a reminder to stay with myself, to keep the door open from the inside.

Only then, if I stay with it, do the choices come. Not grand visions, but small, ordinary steps. *Do I pause? Do I say no? Do I say yes?* These are the choices that let me live as I am, true to myself. And that is where the old bind finally breaks. When I stop abandoning myself, I stop needing to perform for you. I don't have to choose between connection and honesty anymore.

I am finally learning how to stay. I am learning how to trust what I sense. Not just to trust it, but to speak from it rather than continue to swallow it down. To let what I feel become how I relate, so I can finally stop betraying myself to belong. It turns out there is a third way. It's not that I am either a doer or a schnorrer. And I'm just discovering it.

The Performance Trap

When I finally stopped running from the ache, I didn't find a diagnosis. I found a boy who was still waiting to be let in.

In the previous chapters, I told you the story of how I built my life around a specific kind of drive. From the high schooler playing *The Wall* to win approval, to the acupuncturist trying to prove he was legitimate, to the executive coach overriding his body's signals to earn his keep.

But looking back, I see they were never about ambition. They were about love. This is the hinge where my story stops being about me and starts showing you the mechanism of performance.

Before we turn the page to the practices, we have to understand why we perform. We have to look at the performance trap not just as a career problem for high achievers but as a relational survival strategy for anyone who learned that simply being was not enough.

We come into this world wired for one thing above all else: connection. We don't just want it; we require it. And the trap begins the moment we learn that connection is something we have to earn.

THE STILL FACE EXPERIMENT

There's a well-known experiment in developmental psychology called The Still Face Experiment. An infant sits across from a parent or caregiver they rely on. At first, everything is normal. Smiles move back and forth. Sounds are answered. Faces respond. The baby relaxes into the exchange because something essential

is happening between them. The baby is being met and related to, and feels connected.

Then the adult stops responding. The adult remains physically present but offers no reaction. Their face stays neutral. No response. Nothing is returned. What happens next is consistent enough that researchers see it again and again.

The baby usually doesn't cry right away. At first, the baby tries to restart the interaction. The baby smiles bigger, reaches more, and makes more sounds, working harder to get a response. These are attempts to restore the exchange.

When nothing comes back, the baby may fuss or cry. He or she will often look away, turn their body away, or pull out of the exchange. Some babies try to settle themselves by bringing a hand to the mouth or sucking on their fingers.

That sequence is the point. By the time an infant is only a few months old, he or she expects an exchange, a back and forth. They expect that when they reach out, someone will respond. Emotional connection is not a bonus for a baby. It's something the baby depends on to feel steady and safe.

The experiment isn't saying that one missed moment harms a child. Life is full of missed moments. What matters is whether someone comes back. Whether the blank face softens, whether the exchange resumes. Attunement doesn't have to be perfect. It just has to be enough of the time, and when it breaks, there has to be repair.

The trap begins when the nervous system learns, over time, that reaching doesn't reliably work. That's when you stop expecting anyone else to steady you and start handling it on your own.

Most of us remember that feeling. The room went quiet, the face went blank, and something in you tightened. Maybe it was a parent who was stretched thin. Maybe it was a parent who set high standards. Maybe it was a home where things ran best when you didn't need much.

Whatever the form, the lesson was the same. Just being was not enough to stay connected. Something had to be done. Something about you had to change to keep the connection. That adjustment kept you alive. It also became the seed of your performance trap.

THE UNIVERSAL DISGUISES

Performance doesn't always look like success. Sometimes it looks like staying small. Sometimes it looks like holding everyone else together.

For some people, it shows up as achievement: If I win, I'll finally feel like I'm

enough. If I get the grade, the title, the company, then I'll be wanted when I walk into the room. The approval isn't the point. The connection is.

For others, it looks like care: If I solve your problems and manage your emotions, then maybe I won't be left out. Being needed becomes the way to stay close.

For me, it became my job. I was the guy who people called when they were falling apart. I knew how to track tone, match breath, steady myself, and steady them. On one level, I was helping, but at a deeper level, I was earning my keep. I was proving I wasn't a schnorrer, that I deserved the seat I was sitting in by showing up client after client perfectly.

Then there's the kind of performance that doesn't speak at all, invulnerability: If I don't cry, if I'm fine no matter what, then I won't be a burden. That was a trap I lived in for years until the day I slipped.

This is how the trap works. It doesn't happen all at once. It happens in the quiet, everyday repetition of reading the room. You get so good at performing not having needs that you start to believe it's who you are. You forget there was ever a version of you who asked for things, who cried, who wanted too much.

The performance isn't about strength. It's about survival. It's the strategy you honed over a thousand moments when the faces in front of you stopped responding, and you figured out again and again what you had to do to keep the bonds from breaking.

THE MAP OF BELONGING

I didn't just wake up one day deciding to be an anxious overachiever. I learned it in a family where performing was the price of admission. We all grow up with a map of how to be loved. My map was shaped by three distinct landmarks. My brother's volatility, my father's emotional distance, and my mother's fragility.

My brother Scott had moods like a weather system we all orbited. He could flip without warning. Once, he chased me down the hall and kicked my locked bedroom door off its hinges, splitting the wall around the frame so badly it had to be rebuilt. Living with that kind of instability taught me to be hypervigilant. I learned to read emotional currents and anticipate what might come next.

If my brother taught me to manage the room, my father taught me the cost of needing. When he retreated into his office, I got the message: *don't ask, don't interrupt*. This was one of many experiences where I learned that if I knocked too hard, the door would remain shut. So I learned to not need.

Then there was my mother. She loved us fiercely, but she was stretched thin. With my dad on the road for weeks on end to put food on the table, and my brother in crisis, she was carrying the weight of the family alone. She needed an ally, not another problem. The unspoken demand was clear: *Be the one I don't have to worry about.*

So, I became the good kid. I learned to offer reassurance and sound wise. I figured out early that being okay was the best way to be loved by her.

But I think it's important not to pretend I was a saint in all of this. I didn't just passively shrink. I often met my brother's outbursts with teasing and cruel barbs. I knew how to set him off, and I pushed anyway. I also knew how to meet my dad's emotional distance with defiance, hoping it might crack something open in him.

You might think I'm blaming my family. I'm not. I'm just describing the conditions that shaped me. And two things can be true at once. They did their best, and I still had to shut down parts of myself to stay connected.

This was the map I followed. I learned not to add to the chaos. I learned that being loved meant being easy, being low-maintenance. And to earn my place in that house, I had to disconnect from the parts of me that needed too much, felt too much, or asked for more than anyone had to give.

So, how does a child learn to mistrust what they feel and follow the map anyway? It starts when the messages don't match.

THE MECHANISM: THE DOUBLE BIND

I want to be precise about this because understanding it is the key to undoing it.

A double bind is a no-win situation where you receive two contradictory messages at once. One message is explicit, what's said out loud. The other is the signal, what's communicated through tone, eyes, posture, or silence.

Their words may say, "I love you. Come close." But the body stiffens when you do. The words say, "Tell me what's wrong." But the face goes blank with overwhelm. The voice says, "Everything is fine." But the jaw is clenched tight enough to snap. One channel invites you in. The other warns you away.

Most people assume that if no one yelled, hit, or humiliated them, then their upbringing didn't shape them. But what we pick up as children isn't mostly verbal. It's relational. It's energetic. We absorb what's felt long before we understand what's said. And when those two things don't match, when the

signal contradicts the story, we don't know what to trust. We hear the invitation, but we also feel the warning.

Because we can't challenge the story without threatening the bond, we learn to distrust our own reality. We start to believe that the confusion isn't out there. It's in us. We decide that if we feel unsafe when we're told we're safe, our own body must be wrong.

THE OVERRIDE

And if the body is wrong, then it must be silenced. This is the moment the override begins. To survive the double bind, I had to split myself in two. I installed a mind that watched the room and a body that I learned to ignore.

So, I did what worked. I stopped listening to the signals my body was picking up. My gut, my loneliness, my no. Actually, I did more than stop listening. I learned to treat the body's signals as something to conquer. I absorbed the logic I learned on the yoga mat, that pain was the price of purification, and if I pushed hard enough, I could burn the weakness away.

I learned to read the room before I read myself. I started living entirely by the official story that I was calm, steady, and low-maintenance. I perfected the art of looking fine so no one would assume I was a schnorrer.

THE CONSEQUENCE

But you can only override the system for so long. The sickness I described in the previous chapters, the gut pain, the insomnia, the crushing fatigue, wasn't just a medical issue. It was the cost of the override. My body was the only part of me honest enough to admit that the strategy had failed. It was screaming because I had spent thirty years refusing to listen.

The ache in my gut was the somatic memory of the boy outside the locked door. The tightness in my chest was the grief of a son who didn't know how to grieve a brother he wasn't sure he loved. The emptiness wasn't a void. It was a space where I was supposed to be but had vacated to make room for the role I got stuck playing.

That ache is what I call the sacred wound. The wound is the imprint of the compromise. Not just one but thousands of them. It's the nervous system

memory of the trades I made again and again: *I will bury my anger to keep the peace. I will bury my need to stay strong for everyone else.*

These choices didn't disappear. They were stored in the body in the form of tenderness, ache, and contraction.

But the wound rarely shows up alone. It's guarded by a whole inner crew of protectors. They show up as perfectionism, tightening the standards so you're never exposed. They show up as the lone wolf, refusing to rely on anyone, so you're never let down. They show up as overwhelm or fog, shutting the system down when the load gets too heavy to bear. We tend to regard them as our character defects, but they're not. They're strategies. More than that, they are often our superpowers.

THE PARADOX OF PERFORMANCE

The still face teaches you two moves. First, you reach, you try harder, you get brighter, funnier, more impressive, more useful, hoping the connection comes back online. And when that doesn't work, you learn the second move. You pull in, you go quiet, you handle it alone.

But the double bind is what makes the traps stick, because it doesn't let you fully withdraw. It tells you you have to stay in contact, but you can't do anything. You can't name what's happening. You can't risk conflict. You can't ask for repair. So you learn a third move: perform connection.

That performance becomes a skill set. You learn how to manage yourself, manage the space, manage the other person, and keep everything looking fine. The drive that makes you a high achiever? That was your refusal to give up on the still face. The empathy that makes you a great leader? That was your survival map for the double bind.

Our gifts, talents, capacities, and strengths often come out of the wounding. That's what makes it paradoxical. In one sense, there's a deep pain. In another sense, that pain forged capacities. The question is whether we can offer our contribution without still having to pay the old price for it.

But the reason we keep paying that price, the reason these protectors still take the wheel of the bus today, is because of time travel.

TIME TRAVEL

This brings us to the present day. You might wonder why a text message, a piece of feedback, or a few seconds of silence from a partner can feel like a life-or-death crisis. It's because of time travel. The performance trap collapses time.

When you're in a conflict and feel that sudden disproportionate spike of panic, you're not reacting to what's happening now. You're back in the moment when your performance was the only thing keeping the bond alive.

I experienced this when Shemesh and Sofia suddenly cut ties with us. Their silence didn't just feel like a breakup. It felt like exile. In my body, I wasn't a fifty-year-old man losing a friendship. I was the six-year-old boy sobbing outside his father's locked office door. The present moment collapsed into the past, and the old protector took the wheel.

We act out these old maps every day. We keep signing the old contract: *I will perform. I will fix. I will disappear*, hoping that this time it will finally secure the belonging we crave. But it never does. Because true belonging requires you to be there. And the trap requires you to disappear.

THE THIRD OPTION

When we time-travel back into the bind, our options shrink. We feel like we only have two choices. Fight, push back, dominate the moment, force ourselves to be seen, or submit, people please, collapse, abandon ourselves to keep the peace. That's the trap. You think you have to choose between connection and your own truth.

But there is a third option. The third option is the move that didn't exist in the den back when needing anything, even comfort, was seen as proof that you didn't deserve respect. It's the ability to be strong and open. It's the capacity to say, "I'm not going to leave you, and I'm not going to leave myself."

This is where the work of Part Two begins. If the wound was created by turning off the receiver, by disconnecting from our own internal signals, then the healing comes from turning it back on. You have to repair the relationship with your body so you can feel the signals again.

But here's the catch. You can't think your way out of the double bind. The trap didn't form in your logic. It formed in your nervous system. It lives in the reflex that tightens your chest before you've even had a thought. That's why the work ahead isn't about mindset. It's about contact.

We don't reach the wound through the stories. We reach it through the body.

This isn't about becoming someone new. It's about coming home to the person you were before you learned you had to disappear to belong.

The ache you've been running from isn't the problem. It's the signal, and it's the way back.

PART TWO

From Understanding to Embodiment



Stories and Tools for Meeting the Sacred Wound

How to Use This Section

In the chapters ahead, you'll see how I teach my clients to rewrite the contract to perform. When I say "contract," I mean the old rule beneath the performance trap, the implicit agreement many high performers learned early on: the place in you that learned you're only as good as your performance. Worth has to be proven. Rest has to be earned. And parts of you get left behind in order to stay valued, wanted, and relied upon.

You just saw the double bind, how you learned to ignore your own instincts to protect those important relationships you depended on. You learned to override them so you wouldn't lose the connection. When that old panic spikes, you time travel. You react as if you're back in the past, and you reflexively act out the old survival strategy before you even have a conscious thought.

What actually changes things is learning to offer yourself what was missing back then. It's not just when the face went blank, but when you lost connection. When the people you were dependent on turned away, when they were preoccupied with their own worlds, and you lost the emotional lifeline you needed. And so you offer that attention right in the moment the chest tightens, the stomach drops, or the urge to abandon your needs shows up.

It's not insight that's needed right away, but attention. A steady, nonintrusive presence that doesn't rush in to fix, explain, or override what's happening. At first, that attention meets the protectors, the parts that want to manage, perform, or disappear. If you can notice them and stay without forcing them to go away, something softer begins to surface: the tenderness you've been guarding, the vulnerability that had no place to land before, the sacred wound.

When that ache is met with steadiness rather than pressure, the system relaxes. You feel more of yourself return, not all at once, but enough. And it's from that wholeness that choice returns. Not the old reflexive choices like fight or submit,

but the capacity to stay present with yourself while staying in relationship. That is what makes a different choice possible.

The chapters ahead show you how to interrupt the performance trap through story and through practice. You'll see how this pattern shows up as overwhelm, the inner critic, emptiness, self-abandonment, and the pressure to perform, and you'll learn how to work with it in your own life, too.

As my friend and teacher Kathy Altman says, borrowing a line from Laurie Wagner, a writing teacher in the Bay Area, "We practice in the straightaways so that when the curves come, we know how to lean in." This work doesn't really work as a crash course. It works through steady practice. Practice builds memory in the nervous system, so when the pressure spikes, you're not trying to learn it in the moment; you're just doing it.

That said, sometimes you find the work when you're already in the thick of it. If that's where you are, whether you're spiraling, feeling numb, caught in the familiar push to get it right, or about to react to a difficult text, skip straight to the "Try This" practices at the end of each chapter. Think of these as in-the-moment anchors. They're brief, body-based sequences designed to interrupt the reflex to perform, fix, or smooth things over, and help your system settle enough to see what's actually happening before you do anything.

If you're not in a crisis, read the chapters in order. They'll show you different expressions of this pattern. And through the stories, you'll begin to see the bigger picture, including how the same contract wears different costumes.

For a quick reference to the practices in Part Two, go to herstwellness.com/book-bonus.

THE TWO FRAMEWORKS: SENSE AND STEP

There are two main frameworks I'll keep coming back to. Think of these as your go-to tools.

Quick aside: in Chapter Three I take some shots at coaching culture, including the "fizz in your ginger ale" vibe from my coach training, so yes, I'm about to hand you acronyms. But they're not meant to be cute. They're here for one reason: practicality. These are tools distilled into something you can actually remember when you're activated.

Here's SENSE and STEP.

Everything you just read in the previous chapter is what it looks like when the trap takes the wheel. These two frameworks are how you interrupt it in the

moment. SENSE is the inner half. It's what you do when you feel the blank face, and your system starts to time travel. It brings you back into contact with what your body is saying.

SENSE isn't about managing or analyzing experience, and it isn't about getting rid of what you feel. It's about making contact with the body's signals: panic, shame, grief, overwhelm, and self-attack. These aren't errors. They're signals pointing to the old agreement. SENSE teaches you how to stay with those signals long enough to restore trust in the body as a source of information.

That kind of contact is necessary, but it doesn't complete the work. If SENSE is the inner half, then STEP is the outer. It's where the inner experience makes contact with the outer world again and again, not as a final correction, but as an ongoing negotiation. STEP helps you catch the moment the trap narrows your world into two options, then it helps you choose the third option: staying in relationship with another without abandoning yourself, too.

So the arc is simple: come back from time travel, restore contact, then take one small step that doesn't require you to abandon yourself to stay connected.

Let's start with SENSE. You'll see SENSE laid out step by step. But in practice, it isn't linear. You move through the steps in the order you need, not the order they're written. Sometimes you start with a sensation. Sometimes you notice a protector first. Sometimes you can name what's here before you can feel it clearly. That's all part of the practice.

What matters isn't doing it right. What matters is the return. Over and over, we notice where we leave. Sometimes that's distraction. Sometimes it's a realization, a memory, a story that suddenly makes sense. Either way, we keep coming back to the body and check the response.

The anchor is sensation. The body is the place carrying the implicit memory: the tightness, jumpiness, heat, panic, fatigue, and dullness. That's where the information lives. That's also where the insight gets metabolized. You don't stay in the head and build a theory. You drop back into sensation and let the system show you what shifted, what tightened, what's softened, what's still bracing. Then you name that and return again.

The work begins the moment you notice you've left the present. It might start as a thought, like *I'm going to mess this up*, or a sensation, a clenched jaw, a hollow chest, or a behavior, like reaching for your phone.

SENSE

The first step in SENSE is:

S. SLOW THE BREATH

Slowing the breath is the entry point, because when the nervous system is high, you're time traveling. Your past is interrupting the present. This step is the break, where you're pausing the old reflex to argue, fix, please, disappear, or push through as if nothing is wrong.

If you're overwhelmed, you use the straw breath method: inhale through the nose for a count of five, then exhale slowly through pursed lips for a count of seven. If you're in a meeting or caught in a spiral, you don't need to do a full breathing exercise. Just take three deliberate breaths. You aren't trying to relax. You're just creating a split second of space between you and the voice in your head.

E. ENTER THE BODY

We don't try to silence the mind. Racing thoughts are a mirror. They're reflecting something your body is already holding. Treat them like a cue to check the body again. Make a U-turn out of the thoughts and back into sensation.

Ask yourself: *Where do I feel this thought reflected in my body, the throat, chest, or belly?* That's it. You're not analyzing. You're just locating where you feel the strongest sensation.

N. NAME THE QUALITY

Use simple words to describe the sensations. Is it hot and frantic? Heavy and numbing? You can also use a simple image if that comes more naturally, like a clenched fist, a weight on your chest, or a buzzing wire. If the sensation is hard to find but your mind is racing, name the part that's here: the inner critic, my five-year-old, the problem solver, the stoic.

Naming creates a little distance, not to get rid of what's here, but so you can notice it without getting swept up in it. We don't ask it to leave. We acknowledge it. *I'm noticing a tightness in my chest.* That simple act of naming unblends you from the sensation. You're no longer the tightness. You're the one witnessing it.

If you feel sleepy, distracted, numb, or have an overwhelming urge to check your phone, name that, too. It's information. It's your nervous system protecting you from what once felt like too much. Just notice that and gently return to the sensation.

S. STAY

When something hurts, the reflex is to fix it, explain it, or shove it away. Staying asks you to do something different: let it exist. Feel the knot, the heat, the

tightness, without trying to change it. You're not fixing anything. You're acknowledging it, like finally turning toward a friend who's been trying to get your attention and simply saying, *I see you*. We offer it the one thing it didn't get back then: steady attention.

You might drop a question into the body: *What are you trying to prevent? What are you worried might happen?* Rather than going to the mind for the answer, we wait for the body to respond. When an insight arrives, it might take the form of a memory, a fear, or a realization. Then we drop right back into the body. We notice whether the tightness has shifted, or the chest softens, or things actually get more tense as a result. If it tightens again, you name that, too, and return. If a protector steps forward, you acknowledge it and stay. If something settles, you stay there as well.

This is the loop: you notice what's here, name it, and come back into sensation again and again. You're not moving forward. You're staying in the same place with more contact each time. And often, somewhere in that staying, the protector relaxes just enough for what it's guarding to appear. That's where the ache of the sacred wound reveals itself: the imprint of the compromise, the nervous system's memory of what you buried to stay connected.

At first, it's a sensation. Then, as you stay, it might give you a story, an image, an insight, the truth of the trade you made. You don't get it all at once. You come back again and again, each time feeling a little more of what's been held there.

E. EQUANIMITY

If Stay is making contact, Equanimity is learning to remain with what you've touched. Stay says *hello* to the feeling. Equanimity invites it to sit with you for as long as it needs.

Equanimity doesn't mean calm. It means you stop bracing. You stop demanding a timeline. You stop trying to get to the end. Your mind will want to jump in with old questions: *How long is this going to last? What's the fix? What am I not seeing?* Equanimity means you don't answer. You come back to the body and let the sensation do what it does. Let it peak, let it settle, let it move, let it stay.

The key move here is keeping your attention on the sensations without getting overwhelmed, distracting yourself, or rushing to fix it. You're teaching your body a new truth: *I can feel this without abandoning myself*. This isn't about chasing relief. It's about breaking the habit of escape.

WHEN TO MOVE TO STEP

You'll know it's time to move to STEP when something small shifts. Maybe the breath settles. Maybe the jaw loosens. Or maybe you simply stop fighting the moment. That's the signal that the system has a little more room. From there, you can move to STEP and make one small next move that doesn't sign the contract again.

STEP

If SENSE brings you back into contact with yourself when you're triggered, STEP is where you use that contact to find the third option. Under pressure, you usually either push harder or abandon yourself. STEP is the pause that interrupts that reflex, so you can choose one next move that keeps you in relationship without having to leave yourself.

S. STILL

This is the pause that comes before action. It's a condensed SENSE, just enough to slow down, feel what's happening in your body, and stop the reflex from driving. This is not the moment to fix, explain, or react. Yet you're not stepping away from the relationship. You're stepping out of the reflex. You're creating enough stillness to choose your next move on purpose.

T. TUNE IN TO THE TRADE

This is where the double bind shows up. Something in you wants to remain connected. Something else knows you are about to lose yourself to maintain that connection. This is where you notice the compromise forming.

Ask yourself: *What part of me is about to go quiet so the connection stays intact? What feeling am I about to bury to keep the peace?* Name the trade. And once you've done that, move to the next step.

E. EXPAND OPTIONS

Under stress, it can feel like you have only two options: either you say it in a way that escalates tension, or you don't say it at all. That's how the double bind works. Your system gets narrow and starts acting like those are the only two options. The bind says it's one or the other. **Expand Options** is how you discover it's both.

It's where you interrupt that narrowing. You look for the move that didn't exist back then: not attacking them, not abandoning yourself. Staying in the

conversation while staying true to yourself. This is the third option: the ability to stay connected without selling yourself out.

P. PRACTICE: BREAK THE SILENCE

The double bind taught you to tune yourself out and avoid contact. Practice is the moment you reverse that. You put into words what your body has been sensing all along but learned to keep silent. By naming the breakdown or stating the boundary, you end the silence that keeps the trap in place. Practice is where you say the part you usually swallow: name the breakdown, state a boundary, ask for a pause, or tell the simple truth of what's happening.

And you're going to miss it sometimes. That's normal, and you don't need to memorize any of this. These aren't rules. They're reminders. You will forget this in the moment. That's expected. Sometimes you'll notice only after you've reacted. That still counts.

What matters is this: these frameworks aren't rigid formulas. They're rough maps, not strict instructions.

ONE LAST THING

Think of Part Two as a field guide. It's not about mastering anything. It's about getting reps. Each practice helps you pause, feel what's happening in you, and then take one small next step that doesn't require self-abandonment or blowing up the relationship.

Over time, you'll start to catch the moment the old bind kicks in, and you'll see the third option. Do that move enough times and your system starts to trust a new truth: you can stay connected with another without also abandoning yourself in the process.

Methods: Breaking the Performance Trap

In the chapters ahead, you'll learn these tools through client stories, not as formulas to memorize, but as mirrors to help you see the performance trap in your own life. Specifically, those moments when you convince yourself that you have to win the award to be wanted, manage someone else's emotion to stay safe, or pretend you have no needs just to avoid being a burden.

These stories are meant to help you move beneath the performance and reclaim the part of you that had to go quiet in order to belong.

The tools that follow aren't theoretical. They're practical, but not mechanical. You're not executing steps to get a result. You're staying responsive to what your body is actually doing in the moment and letting the next move come from that contact. They help you interrupt the trap, drop below the protector layer, and reconnect with the signals you've learned to ignore: the knot in your gut, the tightness in your chest, the quiet internal *no*.

From contact, a different kind of action becomes possible, one that doesn't require betraying yourself.

As you read, pay attention not just to the tools, but to the pace. Notice the pauses, the slowdowns, and the refusal to fix the feelings too quickly. We're not managing symptoms. We're rebuilding your capacity to notice them.

These tools are here to help restore your body as a trustworthy source of truth, one moment at a time.

Sometimes what comes up won't be subtle. It might be panic, shame, or the fear that if you stop performing, you stop mattering altogether. When that happens, don't rush past it. Stay, not to get rid of it, but to make contact.

Often, what shows up isn't just pain, but that exhausted part of you that's done trying to earn your right to exist.

THE FIRST TOOL: SENSE

Heather didn't rise in her company by being seen. She rose by being strategic. She knew how to read a room before the room knew what it even wanted. That instinct started early, not as a skill, but as a survival pattern.

She learned to curate herself around a father who saw her as a threat. She once told me, "I was a thorn in his side. He wanted me to excel, and the second I did, I became a problem. I was constantly working for his love."

When we first started working together, she looked polished and capable. She'd been handpicked by the founder to lead a fast-growing company. But inside, she was spiraling.

In every meeting, she would rehash what she said, shrink from how she came across, and default to pleasing the founder instead of holding her ground. "I hate how I show up," she said. "It's not how I want to lead, but I can't seem to get out of my own way."

She had done therapy. It helped, but it never touched the part that clamped down before she could speak. "It felt like we were circling the story," she said, "instead of meeting the place where my body shuts down to keep me safe."

That distinction matters. We can narrate our history forever, but the place that learned connection requires performance doesn't live in analysis. It lives in the body. If we want to change, we don't argue with the part that clamps down. We rebuild connection to the signals you had to silence.

One morning, she came into session after a difficult meeting. The founder had challenged her point in front of the group. She had smiled through it and stayed professional, but all morning her mind had been racing. *Why didn't I say something? I should have pushed back. I blew it.*

As she recounted the story, I watched her breath become shallow. I paused her. "That sounds like the inner critic," I said. "The one that comes in fast with post-game analysis. See if that's right."

She closed her eyes and nodded. "Yeah," she said. "That's the one. It doesn't miss a thing."

"Okay," I said. "Let those words be there. Acknowledge them and breathe with me."

We moved into the straw breath method. I had her breathe in through the nose for five, exhale through pursed lips for seven. We stayed there for just a few rounds. The breath got smoother and longer. I watched her jaw loosen. Her face changed. Her words started to slow down.

That was **S. Slow the Breath**. I wasn't trying to get her to relax. I was sending a signal to her nervous system that it was safe enough to pause.

From there, we moved to **E. Enter the Body**. This is the U-turn out of the thoughts and back into sensation. I asked her to bring the meeting to mind, not to analyze the story, but to notice what her body was doing right now.

She said her throat felt tight. I asked, "Is it unpleasant or more neutral?"

"Unpleasant," she said. "Like a clamp."

That was it. She wasn't analyzing the story. She was just locating the sensation. I asked her if she could name the quality, whether "clamp" captured the whole feeling, or whether there was another word that fit better.

Then she went quiet. Her hand moved to her throat. "Clamp is right," she said. "It's protecting something."

That was **N. Name the Quality**. Naming it creates a little distance so you can notice a sensation instead of getting swept up in it.

Then we moved to **S. Stay**. I said, "Let the clamp be there. Don't try to fix it. Just make contact." She nodded. "And ask it what it's trying to prevent, what it doesn't want to happen."

She went quiet again. After a moment, her shoulders lifted. "Pressure," she said. "If I don't contain it, I'll say too much, or I'll say the wrong thing."

"And then?" I said. "Notice how the clamp in your throat reacts. If you did say the wrong thing..."

She swallowed. "I get in trouble."

"Good. Come back to the body. Notice how it responds to that memory," I said.

Her hand moved to her throat again. "It's tighter."

"See if you can keep that tight throat company," I said.

A few breaths passed. "It shifted," she said. "It's lower now. In my belly. It feels like a stone."

"A stone?" I asked. "How heavy is it?"

"Heavy," she said. "Like sitting at the dinner table, knowing exactly what I'm not allowed to say."

"Right now, your body thinks you're back there, at the dinner table," I said. "See if you can stay with that weight."

Her breath snagged, then released.

"Notice what happens in your body," I said, "when you remember that table."

Her shoulders pulled in slightly. "The stone presses harder."

"Just notice that," I said.

A few seconds passed. “It’s not as sharp,” she said. “Still heavy, but quieter.”

That was memory, not stored in thought, but carried in her body.

Then I watched her face change. She swallowed hard and went a little pale.

“Something just shifted,” I said. “What’s happening now?”

“I feel nauseous,” she said. “Like I might throw up.”

“Okay,” I told her. “See if you can stay with that. Keep breathing. Let the nausea rise and fall. Don’t fight it. Just surf the wave.”

The nausea rose, peaked, and then slowly moved through. She didn’t throw up, and she didn’t leave herself, either. She stayed present, even when it got intense.

When it finally passed, I watched her breath smooth out again. That was **E. Equanimity**. If Stay was asking her to keep contact with the feeling, Equanimity was building that capacity.

She wasn’t calm, and the nausea didn’t vanish immediately, but she learned how to ride the wave. When the intensity rose, she didn’t let the intensity of those sensations take the wheel. She just rode the wave all the way to shore.

And then something else arrived, a truth that had been waiting underneath.

“I spent my whole life making myself smaller,” Heather said. “Toning down my intelligence, my humor, my joy.” She paused. “It never felt safe to show up fully. When I did, people pulled away.”

We didn’t have to go looking for the hidden cost. It showed itself when she stayed. When the intensity passed, something softened, and the truth was right there.

“It started with my father,” she said. “He demanded everything but gave nothing. I bent myself around him.”

I said, “So even when you did everything right, you still couldn’t win.”

Her eyes filled. “Yeah,” she whispered. “It really wasn’t safe.”

She didn’t try to fix the ache. She just made contact with it. She stayed with it long enough for the signal to be received, not overridden. It wasn’t a feeling to get rid of. It was a part of her, and turning toward it ended the standoff. She stopped bracing against the signal, so the signal stopped screaming back to be heard.

THE SECOND TOOL: STEP

In the double bind, staying connected required overriding what you felt. Your body learned that its signals weren’t safe, so protection took over.

SENSE is how you stop living only from that protective layer and return to what's actually happening in your body. The goal isn't understanding. It's contact. When you stay with sensation instead of overriding it, the signal you once had to bury begins to show itself.

STEP turns that contact into choice. You're no longer reacting from the urge to please, prove, or abandon yourself. You're responding from a self that isn't trying to justify its existence.

This kind of action doesn't come from urgency. It comes from staying long enough for the body to speak and listening before you react.

And it starts right after **S. Still**. This is different from S. Slow the Breath. Slowing the breath is how you use the breath to settle the body. Still is the moment you stop and don't automatically do the thing you always do.

Still is that split second of space before your nervous system repeats the old move. It's the moment where the reflex loosens just enough for you to choose something different. That's what makes a new response possible.

Here's what that looked like with Heather:

A few months into our work together, she came in and told me about a meeting from earlier that week. In real time, she noticed the old pattern start to fire: her throat tightening, her mind speeding up. She could feel that old reflex to be agreeable kick in.

But this time, she slowed her breath. She checked her throat and noticed the clamp. She didn't wait for the sensation to disappear. She didn't have time for that. But she did wait for one small thing: she waited for the signal to break through.

That was **S. Still**. Stillness wasn't a pep talk. It wasn't a mindset. It was a physiological break that came from contact. She felt the clamp, made contact briefly, and interrupted the reflex to sign the contract again.

She could still feel the reflex to smooth the tension and be agreeable. But instead of following it, she asked herself: *What am I about to swallow right now?* Not *what would make this easier?* Not *what would calm everyone down?*

She stopped trying to manage the room and looked at the contract. What was the cost of this trade? It was costing her clarity and her self-respect. She realized she was no longer willing to pay that price just to earn her place.

That was **T. Tune In to the Trade**. The fear was still there, but it was no longer driving. The signal was.

From there, she broke the binary. The old trap insisted she had two choices: abandon herself to keep the peace or attack him to be heard. She found the third option, staying connected to the signal without blowing up the relationship.

That was **E. Expand Options**.

Then came **P. Practice**. Practice isn't just a communication skill. It's the act of ending the override. The double bind trains you to keep the signal, your gut, your fear, your *no*, hidden in order to keep the bond safe. Practice reverses that.

It takes what your body knows and brings it into the relationship through spoken language. It's the moment you make the implicit explicit. This might look like a cleaner sentence, a direct request, or simply naming the breakdown: "I'm noticing I'm starting to shut down. Can we slow down for a second?" Or: "I'm not ready to agree yet. I need a minute to think."

This is the way you break the old contract.

Heather said, "I want to make sure we're aligned before we move forward, because I do have a clear rationale for this direction. And if there's a breakdown in trust, I'd rather name it than dance around it."

It was clear, direct, not sharp, not apologetic. Just straight.

The founder paused. "Fair point," he said. "Let's talk through it."

Later that day, one of her direct reports messaged her: "The way you held your ground gave me courage," she wrote. "You showed me what's possible."

That's STEP. It starts with stillness, waiting for one small shift, enough room to make a new choice, then tuning into the cost of the trade, expanding beyond the binary, and taking one practice step that doesn't sign the old contract again.

This is how change actually happens, not in one big leap, and not permanently, but again and again, through small, embodied choices. Relief may follow, but relief isn't the goal. Self-trust is.

You've just met Heather. Next, I'm going to tell you Mary's story. Hers is a version of overwhelm, what it looks like when the system gets flooded, and the contract demands you carry it all.

In the chapters that follow, you'll see a few different forms of the performance trap, and you'll learn how to work with each one, not as a glitch, and not as a failure, but as a doorway. Overwhelm, the inner critic, emptiness, self-abandonment, and the pressure to perform. These are the exact places the old contract is running. When we meet them with breath and sensation, they stop being dead ends. They become the entry point. Contact first, then choice. Over time, these reps teach your system a new rule: you don't have to perform to belong.

Overwhelm

Mary lit up every room she walked into. She was a force. She moved through the world with ferocity and speed, a studied indifference that looked like confidence. But it was armor, a mask that said she didn't care. One she admitted to carefully constructing. "I try to put up this front," she said, "like I don't give a fuck. But deep down, I do."

Beneath it, though, was a heart that cared more than anyone realized, one always bracing for the moment the ground might give way. That detachment had been a survival tactic, a learned response to a childhood where love was conditional, and stability could vanish at any moment.

She had built a swimwear company with a clear mission: to help women feel powerful in their own skin. Stretch marks, scars, softness, all of it. The brand was rooted in a belief she could name in an instant: that women deserve to feel confident in their bodies, just as they are. "Loving yourself, loving your body," she'd say, "letting women come in all shapes and be beautiful no matter what."

But there was a story that went with her mission. It was personal. Years earlier, in a relationship that ate away at her confidence, her body had been treated as something to control or fix. Her boyfriend would say, "You should go to the gym. Build your butt." She remembered throughout the whole relationship never feeling like she was enough.

And for a while, the brand did what she'd hoped. Women posted photos in her designs, sunlight on skin, a hip cocked, a laugh caught mid-frame, stretch marks and scars in plain view. They looked proud. Something bigger than a brand began to take form.

But while the swimwear company solved one problem, it kept another one

intact. She was helping women reclaim their power while quietly carrying a rule she'd learned young: *you only get to belong if you keep winning*.

When the ground gave way, when COVID lockdowns ended and sales dropped, the momentum vanished. She had too many employees, too much inventory, and costs she couldn't cover. The numbers turned fast. The debt landed hard. But the number itself wasn't the issue. It was what it woke up inside of her.

She didn't grow up with a lot of stability. In China, where she was born, her family had gone from rags to riches until her father was arrested and everything collapsed. Her mother moved them to Canada to start over.

Canada was cold, but the expectations were even colder. The message was relentless. Even when she placed in the top one hundred, a real achievement in a school with thousands of students, it wasn't enough. When she broke a swimming record and brought home a certificate, the response was blank. It was the still face. There was no "good job" in that house, just the next thing to prove that worth had to be earned, and love came with conditions.

She once told me, "If I don't keep getting better, no one's going to want to be with me. My mom, my friends, anyone."

So she pushed hard, all the time, always overdelivering, overperforming, not to shine so much as to survive. She'd say, "I put 110% of my energy into everything. That's just how I am." But it wasn't just how she was. It was how she coped. It was a learned strategy to avoid the terror, fear of stillness, because if she stopped, even for a second, she feared everything might collapse again.

Watching her business unravel pulled her straight back to the time her father was arrested and everything changed. She felt afraid, guilty, and completely helpless. She sat at her computer, barely breathing, frozen. It was that familiar feeling, that the ground was vanishing beneath her feet again.

Somewhere along the way, she had made it mean she was to blame, in that childlike way that still feels true in the body, like if she had been better, somehow, her father wouldn't have gone to jail. They wouldn't have had to leave China. And her family would have stayed whole. She didn't talk about it like that, but you could see it in her body: the way her breath got short and shallow, the heaviness in her chest, the panic attacks where her heart raced, and she felt like she couldn't breathe. The message was there, even when she couldn't put it into words.

As the numbers worsened, it wasn't just a business problem. It felt like she was about to disappoint a whole bunch of people who were connected to her: the women on her team who believed in her, the customers who'd built

a community around the brand, everyone she felt responsible for. And that's what made it so loaded. If the business went under, it wasn't just inventory and debt. In her body, it registered as: *I'm letting them down. I'm failing everyone who counted on me.*

The thoughts got vicious. *You should have seen this coming.* And behind it, a darker one: *If you can't hold this together, you've failed the people who believed in you.* It sounded like her mother's voice, where only perfection earned approval. She had trained herself to live with that kind of criticism and just keep going. But the pressure never let up.

THE DOORWAY

When I suggested we focus on her breath, she laughed. "I'm not sure breathing is going to fix my cash flow problem."

"It won't," I said, "but we aren't doing this to fix the cash flow. We're doing it to interrupt the spiral."

I asked her to close her eyes and then soften her hands, her thighs, her jaw, her feet. And then I gave her something simple and physical to track. I asked her to inhale through the nose and exhale through pursed lips, like blowing through a straw. I had her direct the breath into the lower ribs and upper belly region, where the diaphragm moved. I told her to imagine it like a small parachute inside her, opening gently on the inhale and floating back up on the exhale.

Once the motion smoothed out, we added a rhythm: five seconds in, seven seconds out. The longer exhale giving her nervous system a clear signal it was safe. At first, she counted silently, then let the counting fade once the rhythm held on its own. After a while, I asked her to let the breath come back to its natural rhythm, but to keep tracking the movement of the chest and belly while she followed the out breath all the way to the end.

As her breath found a steady rhythm, I watched it show up in her face. The little muscles around her eyes eased. Her jaw unclenched. The effort in her expression softened, like she didn't have to brace as hard. The problem on the screen hadn't changed, but it looked like she had a little space from it now, enough to see what was happening without getting swallowed by the shame of it.

Then something flared. She opened her eyes and was clearly irritated. "I hate that I'm like this," she said. "I hate that I get so emotional." She shook her head

like she was scolding herself. “I should be able to handle this. If I could just shut it down, I could think clearly. I could fix this problem and then move on.”

I recognized that specific kind of violence. It was the same voice I used on myself whenever my gut flared, the belief that if I just judged myself harshly enough, I could force my body back into line.

“I know that urge,” I said, “to shut it down so you can get back to work. But has that ever actually worked?”

She went quiet.

“Can we try something different?” I asked.

I asked her if she’d be willing to stop for a second and find the overwhelm in her body, just notice where it lives. I said, “Is it in the throat, the chest, or the belly? Where do you feel it the most?”

She closed her eyes, her face tightening like she was bracing. “My chest,” she said. “Right there.” She put her hand over her sternum. “It’s tight and heavy.”

“Okay,” I said. “Let’s just stay with that. Not to get rid of it, but to keep it company, like you would a good friend who’s having a hard moment.”

I asked her to breathe into the edge of the sensation, to let it be there without arguing with it, and to see if she could soften around it by even one percent. “You don’t have to like it,” I said. “Just don’t push it away.”

We stayed there for a few breaths. She got very still. When I asked her what she was noticing, she said, “It’s still there, but it’s loosening.” You could tell that she was almost surprised. “And it feels older,” she said.

“How old?” I asked.

She went quiet. Then her voice changed. “It’s like I’m a kid. I’m in the doorway of our home. The police are there. I see the uniforms. I see my dad getting taken out. My mom is crying. She’s falling apart. The whole room feels weird, like the air is thin and I can’t hold on to anything.”

She swallowed. “That’s the feeling. That exact feeling. Like the ground is gone, like there’s nothing underneath me to hold me.”

And then, suddenly, the present snaps into place, the business falling apart, the numbers dropping. And what her body heard wasn’t debt or inventory. It was: *people depending on me, and I can’t stop this*. Her team, her customers, her mother back then, everyone watching.

She opened her eyes and said it plainly: “When everything fell apart, I thought it was my fault.”

She didn’t say it as theory. She said it like a fact her body had been carrying for years. For the first time, she wasn’t trying to get out of the experience. She was in it, feeling it, not fixing it. That was the turn, from intellect to body, from

analysis to ache. The breath was how she made that turn.

A DIFFERENT PACE

Any time she touched that tight, heavy place in her chest, where she felt that groundlessness, her system reached for speed, just to feel in control of something. It wouldn't have solved anything. She knew that. But the distraction was familiar.

As the pressure mounted and the numbers kept getting worse and worse, it became clear she was going to have to let people go. Around that time, she totaled her car in an accident. After that, her neck seized up so badly she couldn't get out of bed. Her back ached, her shoulders were locked, and on top of the pain, she was wiped out, not tired like she needed a nap, but exhausted in a way that made basic things feel heavy.

Every morning, her body hurt more, and nothing helped. She tried baths, stretching, meditation, anything she could think of. But her system stayed fried. Naps didn't touch it. Even a full night's sleep left her drained.

This wasn't ordinary burnout. It was shut down. Her body wasn't asking for rest. It was demanding it, a kind of bone-deep exhaustion that couldn't be fixed by fixing. For the first time, it wasn't just her mind saying she'd hit a limit. Her body said it, too. *Stop*, it demanded.

We kept noticing the speed, the inner urgency, the drive to fix, to prove, or to outrun the ache underneath it. We held it as a strategy of self-protection, a learned response to all that instability she grew up with. And every time it showed up, we practiced not obeying it, just noticing it, letting the urge rise without letting it take the wheel, so she could pause long enough to choose a different response.

THE DECISION

One morning, buried in emails and numbers even worse than she expected, she didn't jump straight into problem-solving. She leaned back in her chair and put one hand on her chest and the other on her belly. And she took a breath. It was shallow at first, shallow and tight, but as she kept breathing, it started to relax and open inside. It took a while, but the overwhelm started to let go, little by

little, and it started to be replaced by a steadiness as the breath lengthened and smoothed out.

As she let go of the breath, let go of controlling it, she stayed still long enough to feel that tightness in her chest that she usually blew past. She could still feel the weight, the fear, but she could see it clearly: how she had spent three years holding on to the business, to the debt, to the identity of the girl who made her first million at twenty-three years old.

And she could see the trade. She could see the cost of the contract she had signed. She could see how, in all her efforts to hold her team together, she hoped that all of it would prove that she could finally be enough, that she was different from her father, that if she'd just worked harder, she could create a different story.

But the numbers didn't lie. All of her pushing, *do-something-now* energy wasn't working. The business couldn't be saved. And for the first time, she saw that bankruptcy wasn't a failure, but a way to start over. So she filed.

She had built everything trying to be enough. But what freed her was admitting the old story was done.

And then, in a mushroom ceremony, she met the part of her she had been running from her whole life. She felt herself become her father. Felt what he never said. Heard the apology she had always needed: *I'm sorry I wasn't there for you and your mom. I failed you.*

That was the release she needed, not just of the business, or of the debt, but of the need to be validated by someone who could never give it. Of the need to perform. Of the need to be impressive. Of the need to be anything other than herself. The ache of having carried too much, too early, had surfaced. It wasn't a business lesson. It was the shape of her sacred wound.

A few months later, she moved to a new city. There, she began building something different, not an online brand, but an experience. A place for recovery. A place for breath. A place for bodies to land. She stopped trying to be impressive. Stopped trying to inspire. Stopped trying to prove.

She didn't pivot just to survive. She was replanting. She had outgrown her container, and instead of forcing the roots to keep growing in depleted soil, she moved the whole thing. And for the first time, she stopped living like everything depended on her holding it together.

Try This: Overwhelm

Where this fits: This is the first step in SENSE. It's what you do when you can feel the overwhelm taking over. You're not trying to fix the situation yet. You're just settling your system enough to see what's actually happening.

When Overwhelm hits: it usually doesn't start with a clear thought. It starts in the body. Your chest tightens. Your breath shortens. Your vision narrows. The mind wants to fix it, but that only makes things worse. You're not just overwhelmed by the situation. You're overwhelmed that you're overwhelmed.

TRY IT NOW:

1. **S. Slow the Breath:** Start with the breath. Slow it down. This is your anchor. Use the straw breath to interrupt the panic. Inhale through the nose, then purse your lips like you're blowing out through a straw, and exhale slowly. If it helps, count it out: five in, seven out. You're signaling your nervous system that you're safe, even if the deadline is still there.
2. **E. Enter the Body:** Get out of the story and into the physical sensations. Shift your attention to your lower ribs and upper belly region. Picture your diaphragm like a small parachute, expanding on the inhale and floating back up on the exhale. Give your mind this one physical job, so it stops spinning.

3. **N. Name the Quality:** Once the breath settles a little, name what you're noticing. Is your chest still tight? Is your stomach in knots? Just name the quality. Tight. Heavy. Buzzing. You're still not fixing anything. You're acknowledging what's happening in there, so you don't have to fight it.
4. **S. Stay:** Let the counting go and let your breath find its natural rhythm. Don't go back into the problem yet. Just stay with the rise and fall of the breath for ten more breaths, offering this feeling your steady attention. You aren't trying to make the overwhelm go away. You're waiting for the signal to be received.
5. **E. Equanimity:** When you stop fighting the overwhelm, you might notice the physical sensation gets louder for a moment. That's okay. Widen your attention to make room for it. Don't try to solve the tightness. Don't try to breathe it away. Watch the sensation shift into heat or tingling. You're not trying to force the water to be still; you're building the capacity to hold the wave.

IF YOU LEAD, COACH, OR SUPPORT OTHERS

Often, when someone you work with is overwhelmed, the first instinct is to help them strategize. You might ask, "What's the priority?" or help them make a list. But in that moment, problem-solving won't touch the overwhelm. It isn't a planning issue. It's a physiological state.

For Mary, it was her locked neck and pounding heart. In moments like that, problem-solving doesn't help. Making contact does.

High performers often use speed to mask their fear. They believe that if they stop, everything will fall apart. So when they start spiraling, don't ask them to explain the problem. Ask them to pause. Guide them directly to the breath. Keep it simple. Keep it concrete.

Have them inhale through the nose and exhale through pursed lips, like they're blowing out through a straw. That slow, resisted exhale lengthens the out breath and helps activate the vagus nerve. This signals to the body to down-shift.

Count it out for them: five in, seven out. The slightly longer exhale shifts the balance towards safety, and the counting gives their mind one simple job so it stops spinning.

At first, they might resist. Like Mary, they'll feel that the breathing won't fix their cash flow problem or their deadline. Validate that, but keep them in the practice. Remind them you're not trying to solve the problem yet. You're trying to bring their prefrontal cortex back online so they can get a little space from it and see it with more perspective.

Once the physical intensity softens, expect the self-judgment to show up. They might say, *I should be able to handle this*, or *I hate that I'm so emotional*. When that happens, help them make a U-turn from the story in their mind to the sensations in their body.

Ask, "Where does that overwhelm live in your body right now? Is it a weight in your chest, a knot in the stomach? Is it unpleasant or more neutral?" You can even invite them to place a hand there.

Remind them they don't have to fix the feeling right away. They just need to offer it steady attention, to let the signal be received.

As they make contact, they often stop feeling so fused with the overwhelm and start feeling a little separate from it, like they can notice it instead of being in it. That's the shift, from the one drowning in the spiral to the one witnessing it.

The Inner Critic

Most people hear that harsh voice in their head and think it's just them. They don't experience the inner critic as a part of themselves, but as the truth about who they actually are. When it shows up, they take it as evidence that something is fundamentally wrong with them, that they should maybe be more disciplined, tougher, less sensitive, more put together.

If it accuses them of lacking willpower or tells them it means something about who they are, they believe it. The critic's message becomes proof of a character defect, not something to be questioned. But if you can step back even just a little and see it as one voice among many, something starts to change.

You start to notice what it goes after and when it shows up. The critic doesn't just comment on our choices. It questions our right to belong. When we're tired or uncertain, it comments on the plan, the timing, and the risk. But it doesn't stop there. It subtly turns the verdict inward.

It's not really saying the plan won't work. It's saying there's something wrong with you. And when that voice gets loud enough, it doesn't feel like a thought you're having. It feels like the truth about how things actually are.

I sometimes ask my clients to imagine their life like a school bus. You're meant to be the driver with the hands on the wheel and the eyes on the road, but you're not riding alone. There's a whole inner crew on board, and each one is running a strategy meant to keep the sacred wound covered because somewhere along the way, it learned that being seen could come at a cost.

There's the perfectionist tightening the standard because being flawed once came with consequences. There's the overthinker running the same scenarios again and again because uncertainty never felt safe. There's the pleaser staying

easy to be around, so you don't have to risk the old fear of rejection. There's the lone wolf refusing to fully rely on anyone, so you never have to face what it felt like to need and not be met.

There's a whole host of parts in there, but often the loudest one, and the one that tends to sit shotgun right next to the driver, which is you, is the inner critic. And because this part sits so close and never stops commenting on your driving, it's hard to distinguish its voice from yours. It's commenting on everything. It wants access to the wheel, and it has a compelling case for why it belongs there.

It believes that if it stops pushing you, you'll come undone, and that you won't just rest, you'll fade out. It insists that staying productive is how you stay worthy, and that if you ever lose your edge, you'll be exposed as a nobody, a fraud, a loser.

It makes the threat brutally simple: *If I stop being harsh with you, you'll lose your edge, and then you'll lose everything.*

When the thing that's been driving you for years suddenly stops working, the inner critic gets loud. That's where Marcus and I started.

For years, his life was nonstop: calendars packed with meetings, pressure, urgency, performance, travel, the constant sense of being needed, the constant confirmation that he mattered. He was used to being the most successful guy in the room. He knew how to win.

Then the schedule that kept him busy and gave his life meaning began to fall away. A new business he thought would cement his place as the guy who always comes out on top started to falter. Then he lost millions in a deal that turned out to be a scam.

Losing the money was humiliating, but what came after was even worse. The period of his life where he was needed, consulted, and deferred to was over.

He said it bluntly: "I have no one to have tough conversations with, because I'm not important anymore. When work goes away, the only people left are friends. With work, you're important."

That was the silence he was facing. There were no meetings to lose himself in, no inbox to clear, no Slack pings, just a shit ton of empty space: long days, open hours, and his body still running on stress, even though there was nothing he had to respond to.

That's when the inner critic whispered that he was stalling, sitting there, waiting for some miracle that was never going to come. It told him that money and success had only ever been a front, that people reached out because of what he had, not who he was, that without work, he wasn't important anymore. It asked whether any of it had been real, whether his success had just been a fluke,

whether he was actually worthy at all.

And then it delivered its sharpest verdict: *You peaked at thirty-five, and now it's all downhill from here.*

He told me he was spending most of the day in front of the TV. Time disappeared, the same hoodie for days. The TV stayed on, not because he enjoyed it, but because it drowned out his thoughts for a while.

And then there was another layer, the part he didn't want to admit at first, because it felt humiliating to say it out loud. While the outside world saw someone taking a break, he was cycling through long binges of stimulants, nicotine, and anti-anxiety medication to push through the blankness of his days.

Sometimes he could get a small break where he felt clear again. Then the crash would come.

THE SHAME SPIRAL

And after the crash came his second addiction: self-disgust. The inner critic loved that. That's when it ramped up its harshness. It called him *lazy* to light a fire under his ass, to force action. Sometimes it worked. He used shame as a fuel until fear took over, not abstract fear, real, physical fear: heart racing at night, dread about what he was doing to his body, the feeling he'd crossed some line he couldn't uncross.

Fear became both the problem and the fuel. When it got too much, he reached for something to quiet it. Then came the rebound: more anxiety, more dread, and the inner critic used that as proof he was broken. It was a perfect trap.

Around that time, a friend texted him about the Colorado leg of a trip, a weekend that led into rooms full of venture capitalists, the old life, the life where he knew exactly how to show up. Marcus stared at the screen, fingers hovering over the reply. He almost said yes, but then he backed out with an excuse.

He said he was struggling to sleep with the altitude in Tahoe, but that wasn't the real reason. One of the investors on the trip was someone he really hated right now because of a deal that had gone gnarly, and he couldn't stand the idea of being in that room, feeling exposed and unsure of himself.

This was his pattern. When something felt too exposing, he reached for a story so he could exit without saying what was actually true. He wasn't tired. He was afraid of being around people with full calendars who still got trusted to make decisions, afraid that without work, he wasn't important anymore, afraid

the ruthless CEO he'd previously known himself to be had vanished, and what remained was a man in front of the TV just trying to get through the day.

THE BATHROOM STALL

When we finally followed the critic back to where it learned its job, Marcus didn't have to think long.

"School," he said. "It was just a huge cultural shock. When we moved in the late nineties, my English wasn't good, grammar, accent, everything."

He was the only brown kid in a school he experienced as mostly white and well-off, and he could feel it the second he walked in.

The classroom wasn't just a classroom. It felt like a stage. The teacher called on him to read. He stumbled. The words came out wrong. The other kids mocked him by mimicking his accent. The room turned on him. He got called names: immigrant, the sand n-word, and worse.

And from that day on, he lived by one rule: *Don't let yourself be seen struggling.*

Later, he told me about eating lunch in the bathroom when he first moved to Florida. Not because he wanted to be alone, but because he was so afraid of people. He would go into a stall with a sandwich and sit there protecting himself, trying to avoid the whole scene of sitting at a table, being by himself, and feeling shame about it, or worse, sitting with other kids and getting verbally attacked for being brown. So he would go into that stall, his feet pulled up so no one would see his shoes under the door. He'd wait for the bell so he could finally come out.

What struck him was how much this pattern was still alive in him. "I didn't know it was this much," he said. He always told himself it was good that it happened because it shaped him.

But as he let the memory come into focus, you could feel the cost. No child should ever have to eat in a bathroom because he doesn't feel safe with other children. And that was part of the paradox for Marcus. That scene helped build the ruthless part of him that would never let anyone get one over on him again.

When he broke down to a tutor after being targeted and called names, the tutor told his parents, but they didn't say anything to him. Not because they didn't care, but because they didn't know how to respond to the situation, and they didn't have room to hold it.

It was the still face. So he met it alone, and the critic stepped in because no one came. It helped him adapt.

What made this harder for Marcus was that he wanted to feel closer to his parents, but he didn't know how to do it with them. As an adult, he could talk about what was going on inside him in English. He could name the loneliness, the fear, the numbness, the shame in his chest.

But with his parents, the language was Gujarati, and that's where they still lived, not just in language, but in how the whole family worked, what you're allowed to express, and what you keep private. He was trying to build a new way of relating inside the same old family world he came from.

He told me one day, "I can talk to you in English, but I can't talk to them."

And when he did try, it didn't create comfort. In fact, it often invited more fear and anxiety. The moment he showed vulnerability, his mom got anxious and went straight into fixing and advice.

So the old rule strengthened itself: *Don't tell the truth. If it makes people you love more anxious, just deal with it yourself.*

STAYING WITHOUT FIXING

So what do you do with a voice that's been trying to protect you since childhood? You don't fight it into silence. You learn first to see it.

The work with Marcus became simple, repetitive, and unglamorous, more like physical therapy than insight. Over and over, we practiced one central move. He would bring up a trigger he commonly faced, like when it was his turn to open up in a leadership circle, or the feeling of being betrayed or manipulated by a partner, or the memory of being taunted in school.

Then we would drop the storyline and go straight into sensation. He could often feel it immediately. When he did, he reported a tightness in his chest and a pit in his stomach, along with the sense of being stuck like he was in limbo.

Underneath that was a body-level feeling of not being safe, plus an instinct to retreat back into himself. He also noticed aggressive energy that eventually tipped into physical exhaustion, along with feelings of being small and unworthy.

Mentally, it showed up as foggy and heavy-headedness, and often the most dominant experience was numbness, a lot of it.

And instead of doing what he normally did, fixing it with a new plan, or numbing it with more TV or substance, he practiced staying with it from a

neutral place. A few breaths, no solution, just noticing it, keeping it company, letting it be there without reacting.

As we toggled back and forth like that, trigger to sensation, story to body, the feelings often started to loosen. He would feel more present and lighter.

He learned the difference between pain and panic. Pain is real. Panic is the lie that says it's too much to bear.

He learned that sensations eased up when he stopped trying to shut them down with TV, stimulants, nicotine, or meds. That was the real practice, letting the feeling run its course without medication, without distraction, and without turning on himself.

Sometimes he did it well. Sometimes he relapsed into old patterns, and then came the old verdict: *See, you're hopeless.*

I smiled when he told me this. I knew that spiral well. It's the exact moment the inner critic jumps in to say: *See, you haven't changed at all.* It loves a relapse.

"That's the trap," I told him. "It's using your slip as evidence that you're broken. But a slip isn't a verdict. It's just a slip." The work wasn't about being perfect. It was about not letting a rough day define him.

What Marcus was actually grieving was an identity. He'd been the ruthless CEO, the most successful guy in the room. Now he was a minority investor, dependent on other people's decisions, feeling occasionally played and unsure of his own instincts. When he was the CEO, he felt untouchable. Losing that role took that feeling away.

And it wasn't just the role he was grieving. It was the loss of the map that had kept him safe: *Be important. Stay in motion, and you won't ever have to feel exposed.* That map gave him status and protection, but it also kept him from the deeper thing underneath, the fear that, without achievement, he was still that kid in the bathroom stall trying not to be seen.

This was the work, not reframing, not pep talks. The work was in the body, dropping the story, finding the sensation, naming it precisely, and staying with it without rushing to make it better. That's where the shift began.

PASSENGER, NOT DRIVER

When we reached the end of our work together, he set clear boundaries for himself: no to tying his worth to business, no to comparison, no to proving, no to numbing out to TV when what he actually needed was contact, no to bypassing loneliness with stimulants, and then pushing himself with shame.

And then his yeses: presence, listening, becoming steady instead of spectacular.

At the very end, he said something that reframed the whole story.

“I have an antenna. It’s sensitive. I pick up on people fast. For most of my life, I treated that like a problem, because it made me scan rooms and second-guess myself.

“I was always tracking how I was being seen, whether I was safe, whether I belonged. After what happened when I was a kid, that antenna stopped being about connection. It was how I protected myself to make sure nobody could get one over on me again. It kept me from getting hurt, but it didn’t help me belong.”

He could see it more clearly now. The antenna wasn’t the wound. The wound was the fear underneath it, the fear of being exposed and not belonging. The antenna was what he built on top of that. It was how he stayed a step ahead.

And as he practiced stepping out of threat mode, that same sensitivity could become a capacity for people, not a tool for dominance, but for connection. He started to care more about being a good, connected friend than winning, and to hold that sensitivity with appreciation instead of only shame.

These days, Marcus keeps things quiet. He’s not trying to prove anything. He just shows up when people are stuck and offers help.

A close friend wanted to start a sauna and cold plunge business. He helped her build it. He took a small piece, then stepped back and let it be hers. He did it out of love.

That voice didn’t vanish. It rarely does. But it lost its authority. It was still loud, still demanding, but it didn’t get to drive the bus anymore.

Try This: Inner Critic

Where this fits: You've already grounded yourself with the breath. Now the next step in SENSE is getting out of your head and into direct contact with what's actually happening on the inside. At this point, insight isn't what helps. It's precision that helps. Presence that helps. You aren't trying to argue with the critic. You're trying to change your relationship with it.

When the Inner Critic hits: it doesn't show up with a name tag saying, "Hi, I'm the Inner Critic." It just feels like the truth. It feels like you really are behind, broken, or about to be exposed as not as confident as people think. The instinct is to fight it, argue with it, or work harder to appease it. But the goal isn't to silence the voice. The goal is to create separation from the voice, to stay in the body, and keep contact with what's happening without getting completely identified with what it's saying.

TRY IT NOW:

1. **S. Slow the breath:** Start by slowing the breath. If you did the Overwhelm "Try This," it's the same move here. The Inner Critic runs on speed. It wants you to react, explain, fix, and prove. Before you engage with any of that, you need to steady yourself. You need a little space between you and that voice. Take at least three deliberate breaths. Inhale slowly. Exhale even slower. You aren't trying to relax. You're interrupting the reflex to believe what it's saying.
2. **E. Enter the body:** Don't debate the critic. Don't answer it. Just drop the story and go straight into sensation. There's often a mirror reflection

between what the critic is saying and what's happening inside your body. See if you can locate it. Look in the throat, the chest, the belly. Notice where it lands. If you don't find it in one clear spot, soften your awareness to include the body as a whole, and see if you can sense the overarching tone throughout. You're not analyzing. You're locating how the critic's message is showing up in your body.

3. **N. Name it:** Then name the quality, not the story. The quality: tight, heavy, hot, numb, buzzing, foggy, shut down, unsafe. Give it a simple label. That naming is what helps you get a little more separation from it. It reminds you that you're the one noticing the feeling, not the feeling itself.
4. **S. Stay with it:** Once you've named what's happening in your body, stay with it. No story or fixing. This is the U-turn from the narrative in your head to the sensation in your body. The critic wants a solution. The body asks for contact. Tightness doesn't need a solution right now. It needs to be felt. You might drop a question into the body: *What are you trying to prevent? What do you not want to happen?* Then wait for it to respond.
5. **E. Equanimity:** The critic wants you to contract, to shrink away from the shame or the fear. Equanimity is the refusal to shrink. It's the act of widening the container. If the shame feels hot, let it be hot. If your stomach drops, let it drop. Don't try to solve the situation, and don't see if the charge is draining yet. As I told a client recently, this part doesn't want to be solved. It's asking to be allowed. You're building the capacity to feel the verdict hitting your body without believing the story it's telling you.

IF YOU LEAD, COACH, OR SUPPORT OTHERS

If you're working with someone who's hijacked by their inner critic, your first instinct is usually to debate the facts or offer reassurance. You might say, "No, you did a great job," or, "That's not true, you are valuable." It's a natural move, but it tends to keep them locked in the same fight. Trying to prove the critic wrong often feeds the loop. They don't need you to win the argument for them. They need help stepping back from the inner battle. The first job isn't reassurance. It's helping them create a little separation from the voice.

A lot of high performers, like Marcus, believe that the harsh voice is the source of their success. They worry that if they stop listening to it, they'll lose their edge and become lazy. You're not trying to get rid of the critic. You're helping them shift their language from "I am failing" to "A part of me feels like I'm failing." That small change gives them a stable place to stand.

When they get stuck in a story like "I'm stalling" or "I'm washed up," bring them out of the narrative and back into the body. Ask where the judgment shows up right now. Is it a tightness in the chest, a pit in the stomach, a clamp in the throat? Then have them stay with that sensation for a few breaths without fixing or explaining. That's often how the shift happens. Not by outsmarting the thought, but by making contact with what lies underneath.

Watch out for the fixer instinct here. High performers will often try to feel the sensation just to make it go away. If they try to solve the feeling, they will only get tighter. Remind them: this part doesn't want to be solved. It's asking for steady attention. It's asking to be received.

And when they start describing themselves in ways that aren't quite true, name it. If Marcus says he's lazy, but what's actually there is fear, call it fear. If someone says they don't care but they're clearly hurt, call it hurt. You're not doing this to correct them. You're helping them see the pattern more accurately so they have a real choice.

Your job isn't to make them feel better on the spot. It's to make the loop visible so they can recognize it and relate to it differently. And it helps to treat the critic as a protector rather than a villain. Most of the time, it's trying to guard them from shame, rejection, or the fear of not belonging. You might even encourage them to ask the voice: "What are you trying to protect me from?" "What are you afraid might happen if you didn't do this inside of me?" The analysis and stalling usually aren't character defects. They're old strategies that once made sense.

The goal isn't to silence the voice. It's to create enough separation that they can take the wheel back.

Emptiness

Jake would drive for hours with repetitive EDM pulsing through the speakers. His eyes were on the road, but he was barely aware of the drive itself. He wasn't daydreaming. He was in a trance, a kind of mental tunneling.

While the beat looped, his mind would drop into that deeper gear where he worked through plans before they ever happened: a new hire, a warehouse expansion, a deal no one else saw coming. He'd run the play in his head and feel that click, the internal yes, before he spoke a word. He called it manufacturing reality.

To him, visualization wasn't fantasy. It was the mental version of building something real before it actually existed. If he could see it and genuinely want it, it would start to take shape. He didn't think through the business so much as feel it, like the solution was already baked in, and he was just revealing it piece by piece.

And then, once the vision was locked in, he moved like a train. If you slowed him down or added friction that he thought was unnecessary, he'd run right through you. He saw hesitation as how you lose. He built this company with no partners, no outside money, just intensity, repetition, and the refusal to flinch when it got hard. He'd absorbed every hit and kept going.

Lately, he'd gotten obsessed with Kabbalah, not because he was Jewish, he wasn't, but because it felt like someone had finally written down the thing he'd been doing his whole life. He'd say, "This is what Kabbalah is, right? It's your thoughts becoming real. It's like magic. It's how you turn what you're daydreaming about into reality. It's how you take what God wants or what

your source wants and bring it into the world. This is what I do when I'm manufacturing reality."

His friends thought it was weird. I didn't. I'm Jewish, and I barely know anything about Kabbalah, but I felt touched that it meant something to him, like it gave him words for the way he'd always operated. At least the way he understood it.

"Kabbalah," he would say, "came down to three things: desire, will, and focused intention." He didn't find faith in it, just language for what he already did.

He was motivated less by money than by the friction of the game itself. A beach did nothing for him without the pressure, the opponent, the next level. He felt deadened. He didn't know how to rest.

When his schedule opened, he'd get anxious. He didn't trust things to keep going without him checking on them. If he wasn't on top of it, he worried something would get missed and start falling apart.

He had trouble relating to people about everyday problems, because his mind was usually on big deals with big consequences. He could be rigid, transactional, and sometimes even be labeled robotic. Not because he didn't care, but because he trained himself for a decade to solve, deliver, and stay on top. Connections became secondary.

It was his thirtieth birthday, and he was parked in his truck beside a lake in the fading light. There were no fires to put out or decisions to make. All the systems were running. The quarter was locked in. The ops team didn't need him anymore.

By every measure, he had what he'd spent his whole adult life chasing. "Look at me," he'd say. "I can buy a plane. I live in this incredible house. I've built this life with no investors, no partners, just vision and hard work. I can manifest like crazy, and somehow I still don't feel a whole lot."

The reality he built arrived exactly as he designed it in his mind, but when it did, he felt nothing. The freedom, the success, none of it touched the part of him that had been waiting to feel different. It wasn't sadness, it wasn't even depression. It was emptiness, the realization that getting everything he wanted didn't change how he felt.

His phone sat face up on his thigh. The screen was dark. He unlocked it: no messages. He locked it again. He waited. He checked it one more time, like maybe the signal was slow.

Still nothing. Someone should have said something by now, a friend, his sister, maybe an ex. But the silence didn't just feel like nothing. It felt like a

message, like people either forgot it was his birthday or they remembered and chose not to reach out.

The night was quiet, and that quiet got under his skin. He couldn't stand the idea that the people who were supposed to care didn't, or worse, that they did and chose not to say anything. His mind then defaulted to its old circuitry: metrics missed, KPIs, who was coasting, who needed to go.

The mental dashboard flickered, but none of it registered. He pressed his thumb to the center of his breastbone like he was trying to dislodge something stuck in there. It wasn't pain exactly, more like a dull pressure he couldn't quite explain.

Then he thought back to the night last year at a bar with a group of friends. Mark had asked him, gently, almost as a joke, "Do you ever just stop?"

Jake didn't know what he meant. "Stop what?"

"The pushing, the obsessing?"

Jake smiled like it was nothing. He took a sip of whiskey and said, "What? And let you guys catch up?"

The room laughed. He didn't.

But sitting in his truck beside the lake, the question came back: Why do I keep pushing? He'd always driven himself like that. It worked. That's how he got here.

But now, with no tasks in front of him, just a birthday and the quiet, he felt restless and empty.

That night, Jake called me. He hadn't planned on it, but the pressure in his chest had gotten too hard to ignore. The only ping he got for his birthday was that ache.

"Happy birthday, man," I said. "How's it feeling?"

Jake laughed, looked away. "I'm in this unreal spot. I'm in front of this beautiful lake, and I've just watched the most incredible sunset, but I don't feel anything. I thought thirty would feel different, like I'd have it figured out by now."

Neither of us said anything for a moment. Then I added, "Turning thirty can bring up a lot. You've worked hard to get here. What did you think it would feel like once you arrived?"

Jake said, shaking his head, "I have all this freedom. I don't answer to anyone, but it doesn't feel like freedom. It feels heavy, like a weight in my chest, like I'm carrying something I can't put down."

He kept trying to make sense of it, why he felt nothing, why the life he'd built didn't feel the way he thought it would. He was reaching for an explanation the

way he reached for everything else. Tighten the focus, solve the problem, and then move on.

I recognized that spin. I decided to name it.

“I want to say this because I struggle with this too,” I told him. “It’s easier to hang out in concepts and philosophy than it is to meet your own embodied experience.”

He looked at me, annoyed that I had interrupted his flow. He wanted to finish the thought, to solve the puzzle.

“Pause the analysis for a second,” I said. “Just notice what your body is doing right now.”

He hesitated, shifting in his seat like he wanted to argue. Finally, he said, “It feels tight in my chest.”

“Good,” I said. “Not good that it feels tight in your chest, but good for noticing. Stay with that. Don’t fight it.”

He tried, but his eyes drifted, his energy dropped, and then I watched his head start to nod, like he was trying to stay awake.

I said, “Let your body rest in that exhaustion, not to get rid of it. Just notice that it’s happening.”

He gave a small, embarrassed laugh. “Yeah, I guess I’m getting a little sleepy.”

“Yeah,” I said. “That’s your system protecting you. It doesn’t want you to feel what’s underneath, so it shuts down. It pulls the plug.”

And then I added, “You thought when you finally arrived at the place that you are, that the noise would quiet. You thought that if you finally won the game, the pressure to prove yourself would stop, but it doesn’t. That doesn’t mean you failed. It means all the effort didn’t deal with what was underneath. It kept it out of view.”

And that’s where he made his familiar move, the one that had built his whole life. “So how do I fix this?” he asked.

I laughed. It was the exact question I ask every time I hit a wall. I want the hack. I want the way out.

“That’s the move,” I told him. “You’re trying to treat your soul like a supply chain issue. You’re trying to use will and intention to manufacture a different feeling. But you can’t manifest your way out of this. The point isn’t to escape it. It’s to stay with it.”

He frowned. “So I’m just supposed to sit here and feel this?”

“Yes,” I said. “That question, How do I fix this?, is just another way of saying, How do I get rid of this feeling? And it’s asking you to stop trying not to feel it.”

He nodded slowly, like something finally made sense. Jake stared down at his hands. "I've been avoiding this. All the stuff I buried is still here, waiting."

I nodded. "Can I ask you something?" He looked up. "Who's the one still carrying all of this?"

He hesitated. He looked away, clearly irritated. "I don't know, does it matter?"

And then I jumped in. "Just notice the part of you that just entered the conversation. It's trying to dodge what's underneath."

Then I watched him exhale hard. "This is dumb." But then he caught himself. "I guess... I guess it's the kid version of me."

I held his gaze, and then he said, softer this time, "The boy who learned that if you're hurting, you're on your own."

And then I watched him swallow. "You spent your whole life trying to outrun him," I said, "but he's still there." I nodded. "See if you can stay with him. Don't push him away this time."

And then he said, "When we were kids, my sister kept complaining about stomach pain. My mom kept brushing it off. Told her it was just anxiety, until one day she collapsed at school. Her appendix had burst. Big stuff like that happened, and they missed it every time."

"After the divorce, we had nowhere to go. My dad lost his job, and my mom was so focused on trying to take him to the cleaners that the only place we could afford was a trailer. I was dating this girl at the time, and her parents made her break up with me. Said I was trailer trash."

He laughed, but there was no humor in it. "That's what I came from."

He exhaled slowly. Tears welled up in his eyes, and he didn't wipe them away. His hands stayed pressed to his chest, like he was holding something fragile.

"I'll be transparent with you," I said. "I feel connected to you at this moment. Do you feel that with me?"

He looked up, surprised. "Yeah," he said, "I do."

"That was the brilliant logic of a kid," I said. "If you had let yourself feel the grief of your family falling apart while living in that trailer, you wouldn't have made it out. You learned to numb your feelings to survive, but you aren't in that trailer anymore."

He didn't answer. He didn't argue. He just let out a long breath, and for the first time, I saw his shoulders drop. The fight had gone out of him.

As we completed our session, I told him, "That was a lot. I just want to make sure you're okay before we say goodbye."

He looked at me, exhausted, but present. He took a slow breath like he was

testing his own lungs. “You know how Mark asked if I ever just stop?” he said.

He looked out at the dark water and then back at me. “I think I am finally slowing down,” he said. “Right now.”

The birthday text never came. Jake didn’t grab his phone or pretend it didn’t matter. He just sat there with the empty feeling. It wasn’t easy, and it wasn’t dramatic either. He didn’t fix it. He just didn’t run from it for once.

Try This: Emptiness

Where this fits: You've already slowed the breath. You've already made contact with the sensation in the body. Now the next step is staying. And I want to be clear about what I mean by that. You don't need to analyze what you're feeling. You don't need to understand where it came from. You don't need to figure out how to fix it. You're learning how to stay with it long enough for your system to register: *I'm not alone in here anymore*. Because that's what emptiness really is. It's not the absence of feeling. It's the somatic memory of the still face. It's feeling numb, alone, and disconnected from yourself all at the same time.

When Emptiness hits: it can look the way it did for Jake. On the outside, everything is working. The life is built. The pressure is off. And still you feel flat in the body. It can feel like a numbness that makes even good things feel distant. The instinct is to override it or go looking for a reason you feel that way. But the shift starts when you stop treating it as a dead end and treat it as a doorway. Turn toward it.

TRY IT NOW:

1. **S-E-N: Slow, Enter, Name.** Start with the first three moves you've practiced: Slow the breath, Enter the body, and Name the quality. In the state of emptiness, this can feel counterintuitive because there isn't a loud sensation screaming for attention.
2. **S. Stay** This is the move Jake didn't want to make. The mind will go, *Okay, great, how do we fix this?* But that question is the same escape hatch, just

dressed up as problem-solving. Instead, stay with the sensation for a few breaths. Don't fight it. Don't try to get rid of it. Just keep contact with it. You're waiting for the receiver to come back online.

3. **E. Equanimity:** Often, when we stop running, we hit a wall of numbness. The mind says, "I feel nothing, I'm stuck." Equanimity here means keeping the numbness company. Don't try to force a feeling. Offer it steady attention. Just sit next to the blankness. Is it heavy? Is it gray? Is it static? Treat the numbness as a valid guest rather than a problem to solve.
4. **Go Deeper:** If you want to go one layer deeper, ask the question I asked Jake: Who's the one still carrying all of this? Don't rush the answer. Just notice what happens when you ask it. A lot of the time, the feeling shifts from *something is wrong with me* to *there's a younger part of me in here that hasn't been met*. And that's the whole point. You're not trying to erase the emptiness. You're trying to stop abandoning yourself inside of it.

IF YOU LEAD, COACH, OR SUPPORT OTHERS

If someone you lead, coach, or support is touching emptiness, your instinct might be to help them get out of it. You might want to offer insight, reassurance, or a clear next step. But that moment doesn't call for action. Emptiness doesn't need to be solved. It needs to be received.

Many people, especially high performers, treat emptiness as a glitch or a failure. They try to analyze or outsmart the ache. They want to force themselves back into a higher state. But the move here isn't to fix the feeling; it is to treat the emptiness as a doorway.

Remember, **Equanimity** isn't about being calm; it's about capacity. You aren't asking them to feel "better." You are helping them build the capacity to stay with the discomfort or the nothingness without collapsing into it or running away.

Often, you'll see protectors show up. Some people will get sleepy, foggy, or dissociate. Others will shift into hyper-intellectual mode, searching for the "root cause." This doesn't mean the work isn't happening. When they start to drift or nod off, remember that it's okay. It means the nervous system is doing exactly what it learned to do when the feeling once felt too much. Help them see that the sleepiness or the fog is a protector. Staying with the protector is still staying.

If they hit a wall of numbness, they might say, "I don't feel anything, I'm stuck." In that moment, don't try to dig for a "real" emotion. Simply ask: "Can you offer that numbness your steady attention?"

Remind them that this emptiness is often the somatic memory of the still face, the moment no one came. The antidote to the still face isn't a solution; it is presence. By meeting the numbness with steady attention, you're widening the container to include the parts of them that had to go offline.

Self-Abandonment

When Lisa told me what happened, she described it like it was just a hard day. A rough message at a bad time. But from where I sat, it was more than that. It wasn't just about the text. It was about what the moment revealed. Not about someone else, but about her.

These aren't the kind of moments that blow up your life, but they do leave a mark. And if you don't look at them closely, they start to change the way you move through things, often without realizing it.

It happened at a basketball game with her daughter, Sienna. The scoreboard was lit up, the crowd roaring as Caitlin Clark was introduced. She watched her daughter jump to her feet, beaming. Lisa found herself smiling for the first time in weeks.

And then her phone buzzed.

She checked it without even thinking. It was Jonathan. They had been texting that morning, when he asked her to rate her own leadership on a scale of one to ten. With modesty, she replied, maybe a seven.

She had just pulled off one of the biggest events of the year, sick and with very little support. She was holding up the world.

And in the middle of this beautiful moment with Sienna came his reply.

"I think it's probably closer to a two out of ten."

When she saw the words on the screen, she froze. Even though a part of her wanted to respond, to defend herself, she didn't. She couldn't. Here she was, finally getting one-on-one time with her daughter. She didn't want to let this moment be hijacked by her work yet again.

But it had been. And she was desperately trying to stay present.

Normally, this would have just felt like a coaching move, a tool Jonathan had picked up from somewhere. She knew he was challenging her. They both understood the technique, something meant to strip away ego and spark growth. Usually, she could meet him there. But this time it landed like a sledgehammer.

Yes, he was trying to provoke something, to call her into something bigger. But in that moment, she was already completely depleted. He only saw the potential he believed she was leaving on the table. What he intended as a push toward her power felt like an attack on her worth.

To Lisa, in that moment, it didn't feel like a challenge. It felt like a betrayal. This was the man she had built the company beside. They were opposites, but they made each other better. She trusted his intellect, his vision, and had always felt honored to be the one he entrusted with so much of it.

And for years, he had seen her as the strong one. The one who could hold anything. Not someone who got sick, or wore down, or needed backup. Because that was the version of her he believed in. The distance she felt now wasn't just disappointing. It was disorienting. It would have been one thing if it were an enemy, someone looking to poke or provoke. But this came from someone who had always believed she could carry anything, and now, in this moment, couldn't seem to register her humanity, her effort, or the weight she'd been carrying for so long.

On paper, it was just bad feedback. In any other job, you'd shrug it off. But for a high performer whose safety relies on being the one who holds it all inside her, it was seismic. It wasn't the number that cracked her. It was the realization that her strategy of perfection had stopped working.

They had come to a place in their working relationship where she kept trying to take full responsibility. She'd name her flaws, soften her defenses, stay accountable, and hope he might meet her with grace. But more often than not, her vulnerability wasn't received. It was misread. Sometimes it was even used against her.

And that's when the old instinct kicked in. She had always carried this superpower, the ability to let things go. She knew how to swallow the sting so everything could keep going, so the show could go on. That's why she didn't type a furious reply. She didn't even draft one.

Beside her, Sienna was electric, cheering for the Indiana Fever. Lisa forced a smile. Her body was there, but her mind was spinning. She had already left the room. She turned her phone over and told herself, *Not now. I'll deal with this tomorrow.* But even as she did, she could feel it. This was a turning point.

Not because of Jonathan's message alone, but because it surfaced a deeper

truth she could no longer ignore. She could keep making herself small to keep the peace. Or finally stand up for the part of her he kept stepping on. Whether he meant to or not didn't matter.

When she joined our call that week, she looked like a shell of herself. Exhausted. Fragile in a way I had never seen before. She had pulled off a massive global event on a short runway, all while sick with COVID and with almost no support. She had played the hero until the very end. But what I saw in front of me was something else entirely.

"I've been on the verge of tears all day," she said. "I feel completely wobbly. And yet here I am still performing, still overextending to serve everyone else like nothing's wrong. Like I'm fine. But really, I'm just a ball of mush."

"What cracked it open?" I asked.

"That text," she said. "From Jonathan. When he says I'm a two, it doesn't just sting. It confuses me. I usually think of myself as someone who owns their part. But lately I can't even tell if it's actual feedback or something that just messes with my head."

"I start wondering if the failed hires, the breakdowns behind the scenes at the event, the pressure I've been under. Maybe it's all my fault."

She knew Jonathan wasn't trying to hurt her. He was trying to provoke her power. Still, the way he did it, with intensity rather than attunement, struck right at the core of how Lisa had always earned safety.

Her whole identity as a leader was built around being the one who held it all together. The one who didn't need help. The one who could own the mess and keep going.

But now the more she tried to take responsibility, the more she was questioned. The more she softened, the more exposed she felt.

What once had been her strength, her steadiness, her self-reliance, was no longer protecting her. It was starting to unravel her from the inside.

So I asked her, "What's at stake when even your strength starts to cost you something?"

Her eyes filled. "The magic," she said. "That's what I don't want to lose. I'm not here just to be the steady one. I want to lead in a way that makes people feel alive. Like they're part of something meaningful. Like they can touch the wonder of just being here."

And that was what was being threatened. Not her ego. But the deeper longing beneath it. The part of her that had spent a lifetime contorting to earn safety. To be good. To be steady. It wasn't just Jonathan's words that cut. It was the way she kept bending herself to meet what he needed. Even when it pulled her

further away from who she really was.

"That sounds like your inner critic," I said, leaning on a familiar tool.

"The part of you that believes you aren't enough."

Lisa frowned. "No," she said. "It doesn't feel like a critic. It feels true. It feels like I am failing."

I felt a spike of my own pressure. The urge to be the expert. To find the right label. To fix it for her. But I caught myself. I took a breath.

"Okay," I said. "I missed you there. Let's back up. If it's not a critic, what does it feel like in your body right now?"

She closed her eyes. Made a U-turn into the body. And waited.

"It feels empty," she said slowly. "Like static. Like I'm floating about three feet behind my own head. I'm not really here."

"Okay," I said gently. "Sounds like a freeze response."

"Yeah," she whispered. "I feel frozen in here."

"Let's stay right there," I said. "Don't try to thaw it out yet. Just notice the distance you feel from your own body."

It wasn't until we sat with that sensation for a long, uncomfortable few minutes that the real answer surfaced. The silence wasn't her attacking herself. It was her leaving herself. It was self-abandonment.

That's what most leadership books skip. The moment when your greatest strength, your competence, your composure, your ability to carry everything, starts costing you. What once kept you safe starts to feel like a trap. On the outside, it still looks like excellence. But on the inside, it's just survival. Slowly, the thing everyone counts on you for starts pulling you further away from yourself.

Lisa wasn't just facing a challenging work relationship. She was bumping into a pattern that had shaped her entire identity. It was the one that told her that if she held everything together, needed nothing, maybe, just maybe, she could get the loving that she always longed for.

And that strategy went back to her childhood, growing up with a brilliant but unpredictable father, and in a house where emotions could flip in an instant. She learned early that having her own needs made her a problem, especially around people who were already overwhelmed. She learned to keep the peace by being perfect. She tucked away anything messy. Anything that might get in the way. Anything that could add to the chaos of her home.

When you build a life around a role like that, you start believing that if you ever slip, no one will be there to support you. Until something breaks through and you realize you just can't keep doing it the same way. You feel the cost of it.

I watched her face as she sat with the weight of it. That moment when something hits not just in your mind, but in your body. “This freeze you’re in. It’s not just a reaction,” I said. “It’s a deal your body learned to make. You’re buying peace. I just want to look at what you’ve been paying with.”

She looked down at her hands, then up at me. Her eyes were full. “You asked what was at stake earlier,” she said. “It’s the magic. That’s what I’ve been paying with.”

I nodded. “Yeah. You’re giving up your spark so he can stay comfortable. You’ve been absorbing his stuff, so he doesn’t blow things up.”

She took a breath. “All of it,” she said. “I’ve been taking all of it on. I honestly thought that was my job.”

“Well, it was how you survived,” I said. “And it worked. You got really good at holding everything. But now it’s wearing down the part of you that makes you feel like you.”

Then I saw the smallest shift. Her mouth softened. Her shoulders gave a little. And for the first time all session, her eyes stopped scanning and actually settled. She was coming back to herself.

“I can’t do both anymore,” she said. “I can’t keep playing the role and still feel like myself.”

“That’s the definition of a double bind,” I said. “You feel trapped between two impossible choices. You fight back and defend your dignity, and then you risk blowing up the partnership. But if you stay quiet to protect the relationship, you do it by abandoning your own truth. That’s why you froze. Your body didn’t know which loss to choose.”

“So what’s the move?” I asked. “Until now, the only options you’ve had were either blow things up or go quiet and keep holding it all. What else is possible?”

She looked out the window. Thought for a minute. Then turned back.

She was clear: “I hand it back.”

“What would that sound like?” I asked. “Not for him. For you. Just say it for the part of you that’s tired of carrying it.”

She picked up her pen and jotted something down. Then she read it out loud. “I’ve been picking up on your stress without even realizing it. But I can’t keep doing that anymore.”

I smiled. “How does that feel in your body?”

She nodded slowly. “Scary but honest,” she said. “It feels clean.”

“That’s it,” I said. “We’re not here to change him. We’re here to stop pretending you have to shrink yourself to make things work.”

She gave herself a deadline to have the conversation with him: Friday. It

wasn't to win him over, but to stop carrying what was never hers to carry in the first place.

That's what this work is. Not fixing everything. Just seeing clearly when the old ways of surviving are no longer working. When what used to protect you is now wearing you down. And deciding to do it differently.

It's not easy. But that part of you, the one that still remembers what it feels like to be alive, is still there. It's not broken. It's just been waiting to be let back in.

Try This: Self-Abandonment

Where this fits: SENSE is how you stop overriding the implicit channel. It repairs the relationship with yourself by listening to the signals you learned to ignore: the freeze, the sting, the tightening. STEP is how you take that inner repair into the world to revise the old contract. The double bind traps you in a binary. You feel you must either dominate the moment or disappear to keep the peace. STEP creates a third option. It allows you to stay in relationship with the other person without leaving yourself behind.

When self-abandonment shows up: it often hits right after a sharp message, like a text, a comment, or a look, and the reflex kicks in fast. You either want to defend yourself, or you want to take full responsibility just to make the tension stop. You feel the urge to fix the dynamic immediately, even if it means swallowing what you actually feel. That is the moment this is for.

TRY IT NOW:

- I. **S. Still:** Put the phone down. Not forever, but just for a beat. Don't explain yet. Don't write the paragraph. Don't rush into fix-it mode, because when that critique lands, the body often freezes or it starts sprinting. It wants to do something right now so the discomfort goes away. Instead, you interrupt that. You take one breath, just one, and remind yourself: *I don't need to fix this right now*. If the urgency feels unbearable, name it for what it is: a protector, a part of you trying to earn safety by being quick, competent, or agreeable. Then take another breath.

2. **T. Tune In to the Trade:** Ask yourself: *What's the cost of this trade? What am I giving up right now to keep the peace?* This forces the hidden contract into view. You aren't just deciding what to do. You're acknowledging that the price of being easy is your own reality.
3. **E. Expand Options:** Stress creates a binary. Either you fight, defend, attack, or you submit. Maybe you cave in or try to fix it. **Expand Options** means finding the third option that's neither. For example, you don't have to explain yourself or attack them. You can say, "I need to think about that." You're refusing to let the binary drive the bus.
4. **P. Practice:** Speak the implicit. The double bind trained you to live in a split. You feel the *no* in your body, which is the implicit channel, but you act out the *yes* to keep the peace. That's the explicit channel. Practice is the act of ending that split. It isn't just about changing your behavior. It's about verbalizing the reality your body already knows. Until you speak the implicit truth out loud, the trap stays in place. You might say, "I've thought about it, and I'm not willing to take that on," or "I notice I'm rushing to fix this, and I need to pause," or "I can own my part, but I'm not going to carry the weight for both of us." The goal isn't to win a fight. It's to break the silence. You're taking the truth of your nervous system and finally bringing it into the relationship.

IF YOU LEAD, COACH, OR SUPPORT OTHERS:

If you're working with someone who's caught in self-abandonment, your instinct will usually be to help them resolve it. You'll want to ask, "Okay, well, what's the next step?" But that's not what they need.

What they need first is a pause. Self-abandonment isn't a strategy problem. It's a nervous system reflex. It's a speed problem. Your job is to slow them down enough that they can hear the signal they're trying to override.

A lot of high performers default to managing the other person's mood. They leave their own experience behind so the other person feels okay. But the first move isn't to fix the external situation. It's to help them stop leaving themselves.

Remember, they're trapped in a double bind. In the stress of that situation, it feels like there are only two options. Either push back and look difficult, or stay

quiet and lose themselves. If they protect their dignity, they fear the relationship will blow up. If they protect the relationship, they do it by erasing themselves. If you push them into action too fast, they'll choose the second option again, because it's the old survival strategy.

Instead, validate the bind. Name it plainly: "Of course, this feels impossible. You're trapped between fighting them or abandoning yourself. Either way, it costs you."

Then expose the trade. Ask them: "What's this costing you? What are you suppressing right now to keep this person comfortable?"

Then have them find the third option. Help them find the words, the sentences, the phrases, even the whole paragraphs that let them name what they've been carrying but haven't known how to say out loud yet.

Sometimes it takes time. You go back and forth. You try one version, then another. You help them feel into what's true, not just what sounds good, until finally something clicks. The language lands. It feels solid in the body, like *yes*, *this is it*. I could actually say this.

That's how they stop disappearing in hard moments. Not by saying everything perfectly, but by saying something. Something that they've been holding back. And saying it in a way that feels like them.

The Pressure to Perform

I wrote this book to help me find a way back to the boy I had to cut myself off from in my grandfather's den. It's a manifesto against the unspoken contract that says I've got to push myself past my limits to earn my right to belong. Then yesterday, when I finished what I thought was the final draft, within hours, a friend in marketing and I were on Zoom talking about how to bring it into the world.

We were talking about a podcast that lets people see what I am writing about, how I work in real time. It would show me working directly with people one-on-one. And the whole project stopped being the book and became logistics. Who would I bring on? How many sessions would it take? Would it need to be in person or on Zoom? What about cameras, lights, and microphones? Who edits? How much does it cost?

I kept agreeing to it. I kept saying yes. But I could feel my whole body bracing. It's not that the work scares me. It's the production. Putting it out there has a way of turning it into a job I don't really want, at a pace my system doesn't tolerate.

Underneath all the questions was that familiar drop in my stomach. And there it was, right on time: the pressure to perform.

I thought writing this book meant I was done with this, like I'd finally learned the lesson. Then, the second I finished it, I had to sell it. I was right back inside the thing I'd just spent 200 pages naming. My mind spun out into the old familiar trap.

Option A. The doer's option: I say yes. Yes to the podcast and the plan. I turn it into a full production: gear, setup, sessions, editing, the whole thing. And to

keep it moving, I do what I've always done. I override my body and treat its signals like they're in the way.

The upside is obvious. The book gets out there. I'm not hiding. I'm doing.

And then there's Option B. That's the schnorrer's option: I quietly put the book on Amazon, mention it to a few people, and act like it doesn't matter. That's the move. Act like I don't need anything, because this part cares a lot. It just can't bear what it would mean to want readers and not get them. So it plays it cool.

That's the part of me that says I wrote it for me. That it was my therapy. If anyone reads it or not, it's fine.

And then I feel the truth under all that. It feels like I didn't even try. That I stayed small. Then the shame comes, because now I'm not just ignored. I'm also the guy in the den. The one who couldn't stand on his own.

It feels like admitting I'm just a rich kid with a hobby. The exact identity I spent my twenties trying to prove I wasn't.

Either I override myself to prove I'm a doer, or I stay small and shame myself as a schnorrer.

THE 3:00 A.M. WAKE UP

Last night I felt the contract in my body. I woke up at 3:00 a.m., sleepless, hot, and parched. My body was buzzing. My gut was in knots. I sat there with one question.

Is this a warning about the way I know I can get when I decide something has to work?

Part of me wanted to stay still and listen. If I didn't rush to fix it, maybe it would tell me what it was trying to protect.

But another part panicked at the implication. Because if this was a warning, then it meant I'd already started doing the thing I always do. Gearing up to override myself to make the plan happen.

It's not that I was afraid of the sensation. I was afraid of what it was pointing to.

And then the old question showed up, and the panic deepened.

What's wrong with me? Why does my nervous system freak out the moment I start pushing?

THE GEOGRAPHY OF PANIC

I walked into Alaya's treatment room this morning, tired and wired, my system still humming.

"It feels like I'm in a no-win situation," I told her, staring at the ceiling. "Either I push and override myself, or I retreat and let it die quietly. And underneath it is the question on repeat. 'Why can't I just handle this?'"

"I hear the question," she said softly. "But before we answer it, let's pause. Can you describe the geography of the feeling?"

I closed my eyes.

"It starts in the solar plexus," I said, "but it climbs up into my floating ribs like a tunnel."

It felt like a tube of electric energy. Panic with a burrowing edge, moving from my gut toward my heart and settling as pressure behind my eyes.

"Okay," she said. "Let's make room for that."

For a moment I could. Then instantly my attention slid. Something in me kept hitting the off switch.

"Just stay in your body," she said.

I tried to stay with it. But the familiar sleepiness arrived. Underneath the sleepiness was the feeling of being held down, an invisible weight pressing through my chest.

Then I heard myself say it.

"This feels so unfair."

Then a voice cut in, stern and immediate.

"Life isn't fair. Whoever said life was fair? You can have all your wishes, but there's no such thing as fair."

I could feel Alaya go quiet.

Then she said, "What if I take on that voice for a moment so you can hear it from the outside?"

She leaned in and let the edge come through, mimicking the dismissal.

"Life isn't fair. What made you think it ever would be?"

Something in me tightened. I knew that energy. It was the energy of the men in my lineage. The one that says: *don't feel, don't complain, just deal with it*. It was a misguided protector trying to make sure I was never seen as weak or soft.

Once I heard it outside my own head, I could let it go.

"Now come back," she said. "Back to the sensation."

When I turned back toward the solar plexus, the image shifted. The tunnel wasn't a tunnel anymore. It was armor.

"It's like a shield across my chest," I said. "It drops into the solar plexus and wraps around the lower edge of the ribs like a band. Like a bronze shield."

It reached further down into my quads, the tops of my feet, and into my toes.

"And it's gold," I added. "Golden."

For years, I treated that tension as a glitch. But lying there with that golden shield on, I saw what it was, armor. The same armor I built to survive the den. A reflex I've practiced my whole life to push panic back down. Clear the throat. Swallow hard. Puff the chest. Smile. And keep going.

Alaya rested her hand lightly on my sternum.

"Is this okay?" she asked.

I nodded.

I felt the armor soften. And behind the shield, I saw what it was protecting. A line of wounded flesh. A gash that had been stitched up, but not well. It wasn't a clean surgical scar. It was a crude repair job done in the dark. The way a child stitches himself back together when he realizes no one else is coming. Like the morning I looked at my mother after a night of crying outside my father's locked door and stitched over the need by saying, "It doesn't matter. I'm fine."

The stitches, that reflexive "I'm fine," weren't proof that I was healed. They were proof of how delicate the repair still was.

The wound had one clear message: *You're not fine. You can stop pretending now.*

The Doer and the shield weren't there to make me successful. They were a tag team. One part of me pushing forward. The other part bracing over the wound so I could keep going. But the wounded flesh underneath was telling me I couldn't do it that way anymore.

THE THIRD OPTION

I can feel myself agreeing to the podcast without conviction. Saying yes with my mouth while my body prepares for impact. That's when I feel the shield sliding back into place.

I can't override myself again. I need to use the map I wrote for everyone else. So I did the simplest thing I know how to do. I stilled myself. Not to calm down. Not to fix it. But to notice what was happening before I sprinted into the plan. My body was already bracing. The part of me that knows how to make things happen was waking up.

And with it came the old trade. Push harder. Ignore the signals. Pay later. I

know that trade by heart. I've done it enough times to recognize the first few steps.

And then underneath all that, a third option appeared. Not prove myself or pull back. Something subtler. Build it in a way my body could actually agree to. I didn't have to turn my office into a studio overnight. I didn't have to spend a small fortune to make the work look legitimate. I could start smaller. One conversation. One recording. A simple setup. No set. No spectacle. Just enough structure to capture what happens when I'm actually with someone.

The difference wasn't whether there were cameras. The difference was whether I had to put the shield on to be on camera. And if my body said no, then no would count. That was the third option.

Action without overriding myself.

I wrote my friend, the guy helping me with the marketing, and told him the truth. I said that I'm still in on the podcast, but for now, could we start with the audio? I want to see how it feels before I go all in.

I'm clear about the next step, but I know I'm not fixed. The armor is still there, but now I know what it is. It's a shield protecting a boy who had to stitch himself up. And now I can feel what that shield is covering.

So I can make choices that don't require the shield. Not because the pressure is gone. But because I'm finally listening.

Try This: The Pressure to Perform

Where this fits: This is for that specific moment when the email lands, the stage lights go on, or the opportunity feels like a threat. In that split second, the trap narrows your world down to two bad options. Either you force it, or you pull back.

When the pressure to perform shows up: the instinct is to tighten up, push harder, and hope your body cooperates. You override the signal to get the outcome. But the shift happens when you stop overriding and actually listen to what your body is telling you.

TRY IT NOW:

1. **S. Still:** When the pressure to perform hits, your body treats the deadline like a threat. It says, *If I don't do this right now, I'm not going to be safe.* **Still** is the moment you catch that and interrupt it. This isn't just put the phone down. It's refusing to let the doer take over. It's choosing a pause before you act, so you can feel what's happening in your body and stop the automatic override. You're proving to your nervous system that you can be here without rushing, without performing, and without making a promise you can't keep.
2. **T. Tune In to the Trade:** In that stillness, look at the deal on the table. The performance trap asks you to treat your body as secondary. The bargain is simple. You give up your vitality, your aliveness, in exchange for approval, momentum, or control. Ask yourself: *What am I about to sacrifice to make*

this happen? Scan the body. Buzzing in the legs, a rigid band around the ribs, heat, tightness? That's not just nerves. That's the early cost showing up. Name the transaction. If you do it this way, what does it cost you physically? And can you afford that cost right now?

3. **E. Expand Options:** Stress creates a binary. It says you only have two options. Push through and burn out, or quit and fail. Expand options is where you find the third choice. Action without hiding. Ask yourself: *Is there a way to do this work without overriding my body?* Can you do the task without the tension? Can you give the presentation without pretending you aren't nervous? Can you send the email as a person rather than as a professional? You're looking for the move that allows you to stay in the relationship without leaving yourself behind.
4. **P. Practice:** Take one small action from that new place. The old habit relied on you hiding your stress. Practice reverses that by saying what's actually true. It might be by saying, "I need a minute to think about this," instead of an automatic yes. It might be admitting "I'm feeling a little tense about this launch," instead of acting like you have it all under control. The goal isn't to be perfect. The goal is to stop hiding the effort it takes to be you.

IF YOU LEAD, COACH, OR SUPPORT OTHERS

If you're working with someone who's caught in the pressure to perform, your instinct is usually to encourage them. You might want to tell them, "You've got this," or "You're going to do great." But high performers often interpret that encouragement as a demand to hide their fear. They hear, *pretend you're okay, so I don't have to worry.*

They'll smile and say they're fine while they're physically overwhelmed. Instead of hyping them up, help them slow down. Notice if they're speaking fast, smiling tightly, or holding their breath. That's the guarding.

Pause them. Ask, "I hear the plan, but what's happening in your body right now as you say that?"

Help them see the impact. Ask, "If you do it this way, what's the physical toll? Is that a cost you can afford right now?"

Remind them that the goal isn't just the result. It's how they are while they're doing it.

Sometimes the most helpful thing you can say is, "You don't have to deplete yourself to get this done. Let's find another way to do this where you don't lose your vitality along the way."

EPILOGUE

The Hidden Trail

My mind keeps circling back to the scene I mentioned in the introduction. I'm in the den. The fireplace is glowing, and the olives, celery, and cucumbers are laid out perfectly on the tray. My grandfather swirls the scotch while laying down the family rule. "There are only two types of people in the world, the doers and the schnorrers. And in this family, we are doers, not schnorrers."

Looking back, I see it wasn't just a rule. It was the moment I signed the contract. It was the moment the performance trap took hold. The boy with his feet barely touching the floor didn't just learn a work ethic. He learned a survival strategy: I will perform. I will achieve. And I will never need anything because that's the price of admission to this family.

But here's the thing: the strategy is what sent me on the journey that became this book. Without that message, without that crushing weight of the performance it demanded, I never would have gone searching. I didn't deserve that pressure, but it carried information. It forced me to look underneath the strategy.

It was a hidden path, and once I stepped onto it, it started leading me home. At the worst of it, when it was two in the morning and my gut was in knots, I went looking for a story big enough to hold what I was feeling. I found the story of Chiron from Greek mythology.

Chiron was a wise centaur who was accidentally struck by a poisoned arrow. The wound never healed. And because he was immortal, he could never escape its pain. Yet out of that pain came his gift. He became the teacher of heroes, passing on medicine, music, and prophecy. His pain was the source of his wisdom.

That story helped me look at my pain differently. Chiron's wound turned into the very thing he had to give. I realized mine had done something similar. The map I learned with my brother's volatility, my father's withdrawal, and my mother's need for steadiness taught me that love had to be earned through performance. And while that hurt deeply, it also shaped the way I learned to care for others. And it sent me into the healing profession. Pain was the source of my gift.

Over time, I began to wonder if there was some design in this pain. What if the ache we all carry doesn't just hurt us, but also points to a deeper truth? What if it's a trailhead taking us home?

That shift in perspective began to widen. I started to see my parents differently, not just as the people who hurt me, but also as the people who'd been carrying their own unhealed stories. And on top of that, they were raising a son who spiraled into addiction, then mental illness, and finally suicide. They were in an impossible situation.

Some might read Chapters Six, Seven, and *The Bridge* as my criticism of them. That's where I described feeling trapped in the role of the good kid after Scott's death, maintaining appearances so my parents wouldn't have to worry about me. Later, I wrote about how need or vulnerability could get you shut out. I wrote about the night I cried outside my dad's office door, begging to be tucked in, and the way I learned to swallow my need and call it fine. I also wrote about the map my body made in our house.

Finding the Chiron story helped me see that it didn't excuse what happened. It just helped me see the bigger picture. They did the best they could with the pain they carried, and then they were handed an impossible grief.

I also see more clearly now where my father's distance came from. Unlike me, his childhood wasn't just marked by emotional withholding; it was darker and more brutal when he was a child. He was locked in his room for entire days, his father coming in at irregular intervals to beat him with a brush. That kind of cruelty leaves scars you carry for a lifetime.

Compared to him, I had it good. My hurt was real, but his was far heavier. I never found out whether my grandfather was abused in the same way he abused my father, but I do know that the rules he laid down in the den didn't come from nowhere.

His family started with almost nothing. His father, who was my great-grandfather, came over from Slovakia as a boy, worked days while he put himself through night school in chemical engineering, and built a lighting company in Chicago with his brother. The company grew from nothing into a real oper-

ation, with its own factory, its own glass works, and offices in four cities. He was an inventor. By 1931, he and his brother held fifty patents between them, including the cube tap, the little block that lets one outlet take several plugs.

Then the Depression hit. A product failed, the lawsuits piled on, and the crash finished the company. Everything my grandfather had grown up inside was gone. He was in law school then, and when the five dollars a week from his father stopped coming, he sold light bulbs door to door to survive.

That collapse left a mark on my grandfather. For him, the fear was tethered to reality. He had watched everything disappear almost overnight. I suspect it was out of that fear that his rule took shape, the schnorrers' rule, the belief that there was nothing worse than having to rely on others.

But I didn't actually experience the circumstances that made him afraid, and yet somehow, I inherited the fear. He had lived through losing everything, while I grew up with far more security. Still, some part of me expected it all to disappear overnight.

Sometimes I wonder if what I carry isn't mine alone, but a reflex that got passed down. My grandfather was haunted by the shock of sudden loss and the fear of losing everything again. My father was scarred by brutality and neglect, locked in rooms and beaten at random until vulnerability itself felt unsafe.

The circumstances were different, but both taught the same lesson: never be caught needing. For them, that lesson came from lived experience. Beneath their terror was something almost hidden. An unspoken mourning for what had been taken: safety, trust, the simple feeling of belonging.

Their grief had a real object, but mine is strange. I didn't inherit breadlines. I've had options and help available to me, but I've spent years bracing for a collapse that wasn't actually happening. I inherited the flinch, and to protect myself from it, I built that golden shield I wrote about in the last chapter.

The cost of that shield wasn't financial ruin. It was the years I made myself smaller, tighter, and more driven than I needed to be. What I'm learning now is that the flinch has a twin. It's the longing underneath it.

Fear makes you clamp down. The ache is what's left when you can't clamp anymore. And strangely, that ache is the opening. When it's finally allowed to be felt, it doesn't break you. It softens you. It returns you to the part that was buried under the rule.

I'd heard my grandfather could be sharp, but the man I knew was different. I only knew him in his later years, and by then he wasn't hard at all. He was sweet, tender, and deeply loving. Yes, he lived by the schnorrer's rule, but I mostly met what was underneath it.

When I was in my early teens, he became my best friend and confidant. My dad was on the road a lot, and my grandfather stepped into that space as a kind of surrogate father. During the years I was being bullied in high school, he was the one I trusted, the one I told the truth to, the one who made me feel less alone.

People say he mellowed as he got older, that the sharpness faded. And if that's true, I got the gift of that softness. His father had gone soft the same way before him. And I see my father beginning to touch something like that now, too. I'm just starting to catch glimpses of it myself. Maybe grief is the passageway. Maybe when we finally mourn what was taken, it gives us access to what's been hidden underneath all along. Maybe that's the work of a lifetime.

I see my mother differently now, too. Her pain looked nothing like my father's, but it left its own mark. She grew up in a house where hunger was the rule. Her mother, a former dancer who struggled with anorexia, made thinness the only proof of worth. Meals were half a sandwich, if that. Snacks were ice cubes. The cabinets were locked. The message wasn't subtle: Unless you're thin, you're not worth anything.

And my mom was never thin for very long. She spent her life cycling through diets, her value always hanging on the number on a scale. I'm sure that's why she made sure we had more than enough food, love, and comfort. But she never really let herself have those things without guilt.

Even now, she hides candy in drawers, not because she craves sugar, but because it's her way of saying, You don't control me anymore. Her mother's been dead for decades, but the judgment still haunts her. At eighty-two, my mom is still fighting a ghost.

In the end, I can see that we've all been carrying pain we didn't choose: my grandfather's terror, my father's scars, my mother's deprivation, Scott's torment, and my own ache. Each took a different shape, but there's a thread running through them all. Inside each of us is a tenderness we've longed to feel. That tenderness, not the wounding, is the legacy I want to carry forward.

FINDING YOUR DOORWAY

If you've come this far, you've probably had your own rule handed to you without your consent. Your own moment when a part of you lost its sense of belonging. Maybe your rule was like mine: *Don't be needy.*

Or maybe it was: *Don't be angry. Don't be sad. Don't be scared.* Maybe it was:

Always smile. Always be the strong one. And never show how much it hurts. Whatever it was, the rule gave you strength, but it also cut you off from something essential.

I wrote this book not to glorify the pain, but to help you turn back toward the ache you've been running from. To see that like mine, yours may also be a doorway. You don't need to memorize a whole system to do this.

You just need to slow the breath when the overwhelm spikes, drop out of your head and into sensation, name what's here without becoming it, and keep company with the feeling until it reveals the younger self inside it. Then you carry that truth outward. You pause before you act, you tune in to the trade you're about to make, and you choose the move that doesn't require you to abandon yourself.

That's what coming home means. Not arriving at some perfected version of yourself, but returning to the parts you've left behind. You don't have to fix anything. You just have to stay with yourself.

BACK TO THE DEN ONE LAST TIME

I come back to that den one last time. I see that boy with the soda water and that drop of scotch in it. His feet barely touching the floor. I see him absorbing the rule, and I want to tell him what I've had to learn the long, hard way:

You don't have to choose between being strong and being vulnerable. You don't have to pick between doing and belonging. You can be both.

That boy couldn't have known that. He had to lose parts of himself and then go looking for them again. He had to get hurt, get lost, and slowly find his way back. That's what being human looks like. We don't get to skip the painful parts, but we do get to go back and reclaim what we left behind. We do get to choose a different way forward.

We all have our own version of that den, and we all have our own version of the rule, too. But the rule isn't the end of the story. If you're willing to turn toward what it cost you, it can become a doorway back to what's sweeter and truer than the performance ever was.

Keep Exploring

If you'd like to keep exploring, I've provided guided audios and one-page practices at herstwellness.com/book-bonus. And if you'd like to build these practices and get some support around that with me, you can check out The Performance Trap Practice at herstwellness.com/practice.

Acknowledgments

To my Grandpa Sam. You laid down rules that came from your own terror, and I know you were trying to protect us. One of them was clear. *Needing help made you weak.* I've spent years unlearning that. But I also knew another side of you. When I was being bullied as a teenager, you sat with me and helped me stand my ground. You were my first therapist and my closest friend. When you grew frail, you still made time for me. I'll never forget the day you looked me in the eye and said, "I won't always be around, but just so you know, I'm proud of you." That sweetness landed in my heart, and I carry it with me still today.

To my wife, Melissa. Long before I sat down to write this book, you stood with me in the darkest hours I describe here. We went through almost everything in these pages together. You listened to me endlessly as I poured out struggles, frustrations, and half-formed ideas. You were never just a yes-person. You questioned me, challenged me, and helped me sharpen my voice even when it pissed me off because I hadn't asked. You also fed me when I lost track of time. You slipped salads onto the counter. You waited with dinner when I disappeared into my office until six. I know I drove you crazy at times. I know I neglected you while obsessing over this book. I'm sorry for that. And still, you stayed open, patient, loving, and steady. This work exists because you made room for it and for me.

To my parents. We went through a very dark season after Scott died. For years, our connection was sometimes frayed. Now, in your eighties and my early fifties, we get to share more ordinary sweetness. Just yesterday, we sat together, and I read you a section of this book, the part where I described the abuse Dad endured as a child, and the neglect Mom carried. Naming those burdens out loud was emotional for all of us. It also felt like something completing itself.

Dad, you've been my closest friend. Mom, you've always believed in me. Having Melissa in the mix makes these years even sweeter.

To my brother Scott. Your life and your death shaped me in ways I'm still discovering. Sometimes for better, sometimes for worse. This book carries your imprint. In the flesh, you were difficult. Even now, I'm not always sure how I feel about you. But you shape my path, my work, and my way of seeing the world. I wish you were here to read these pages.

To my in-laws, Ned and Elaine Coon, and Mary Coon. You've embraced me like a son. I wrote this book on your land. Thank you for the home base and for making it possible.

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To my clients, students, and patients through the years. You were not subjects. You were partners. The method I teach in this book became what it is because you let me test it, refine it, and test again. Your courage showed me the contours of the sacred wound and the gifts hidden inside it. Thank you for trusting me with your stories and your lives.

To my colleague and friend Jamie Shapiro, you were one of the first people who believed in me and in this work. Together, we launched Connected Executive Coaching, and you took that vision and ran with it, turning it into a force that brings heart and humanity to the C-suite. You've not only supported me, but you've inspired me, especially in how you bring real care into a world that often forgets what that looks like.

To AJ Patel, Tom Wang, and Nathan Richer. You all started as clients but eventually became friends. You've pushed me to get this message out, whether it was nudging me to write, inviting me onto a podcast, or sparking the idea for an online course. You believed this work could reach more people. Thank you for the spark.

And to the good kid inside me. You carried the weight when I was too small

to hold it. You protected me until I was ready to do this work. You can rest now.

Finally, to you, the reader. Thank you for trusting me with your time. My hope is simple. That you stop seeing your ache as a flaw to be fixed and start seeing it as a signal, whether your rule was to be the good kid, the strong one, or the one who never needed anything. That rule kept you safe. But you don't have to live by it anymore. Your wound isn't a dead end. It's a doorway. May you have the courage to walk through it, to lean on support, and to trust that you don't have to carry it alone.

Notes & Resources

I titled this book *The Performance Trap: The Ache No Success Will Ever Fix* because it names a pattern so common it can start to feel normal. It's not just the relentless drive to prove our worth, the compulsion to overdeliver, or the way it can be hard to enjoy yesterday's success. It also shows up in subtler forms: being the strong one who never cries, the low-maintenance one who never asks for anything, the parent who's drowning but tells everyone, "I'm fine." That subtler version is the clue. It points back to what the nervous system is trying to protect and why performance can start to feel like a requirement instead of a choice.

We come into this world wired for one thing above all else: belonging. Our survival depends on it. A baby can't feed itself, move itself, regulate itself, or protect itself. So the nervous system learns quickly: closeness means safety, while distance means danger. The stakes are primal.

And somewhere early, most of us learned that closeness has conditions. Maybe you learned that if you cry, the caregiver withdraws or gets overwhelmed, so you stop crying. Or you learned that if you're helpful, quiet, and easy, you get warmth and praise. So you become the good kid or the strong one.

This is not a conscious choice we make. It's subconscious. Nevertheless, the choice is this: *I will suppress my needs and become what you need me to be so you don't leave.* The trap begins the moment we learn that connection is something we have to earn.

But the performance isn't the root. It's a sophisticated coping strategy built to avoid something older and more tender. Something I call the sacred wound. The trap is the strategy, and the wound, the ache no success will ever fix, is what all that proving is designed to keep you from feeling.

If you're like some and you hear the expression sacred wound, you might be

wondering if I'm dipping into the mystical or getting a little woo-woo, like I'm about to pass out crystals at a retreat in Sedona while everyone wears white linen. That's not what I mean. I'm not pointing to anything supernatural. I'm naming something human and specific.

The sacred wound is the somatic imprint of all the ways we've traded ourselves, our needs, and our sense of aliveness in order to belong. It lives in the body, not just the mind. It's the tight chest, the braced jaw, the *I'm fine* reflex, the constant push to prove.

The usual advice for high performers is to optimize the trap. Upgrade your operating system, systematize your habits, time block deep work, ruthlessly prioritize, increase leverage, or expand capacity. I'm pointing somewhere else. I'm saying the trap doesn't get resolved by performing better. It gets resolved by turning toward what is underneath it.

This work comes out of my own lived experience, but it's not my personal opinion alone. It's built from the work of people who've spent decades studying what happens when humans live under pressure, how stress shapes the body, how childhood conditioning shapes adult behavior, and how we trade ourselves for attachment.

What follows is the origin story of the map I use in this book, how the performance trap, SENSE, and STEP came together, and the mix of influences that shape them.

THE ORIGIN OF THE TRAP

A few months after Scott took his life, everything went into freefall. In that period of grief and confusion, I entered the Hoffman Institute [1]. Hoffman is a week-long intensive residential process focused on childhood conditioning, particularly what they call negative love, the ways we learn early to chase belonging by adapting to someone else's pain, moods, rules, or approval.

It was there that I was introduced to inner child work. The term inner child can often land the wrong way, not unlike the sacred wound. These days, it can sound soft and squishy, but what I found there wasn't sentimental at all. It was direct and intense. The grief I was facing revealed a younger, terrified, vulnerable layer that needed safety and care, one I hadn't learned how to relate to. It was there that I began learning how to make contact with that part. And that contact became the beginning of what later came to be called the sacred wound.

I learned the term itself in my later thirties in a coaching session with Chuck

Roppel [2]. Chuck was a former Catholic priest before becoming a coach. He helped me see that the patterns I was struggling with weren't necessarily random flaws. They were formed for a reason. Not only did they help me survive my childhood, but they also gave me a sense of purpose. After all, I'd landed in the healing profession. And without those wounds, my gifts might not have come forward.

That's what makes the wound sacred. It's a doorway to our compassion and wisdom. I can't be certain, but I wonder if that term was influenced by his Catholic background, the way Catholics see Christ's wounds as necessary for his compassion. The idea isn't that pain is good, but that what hurts can become a doorway to love. Calling it sacred shifted something for me. It restored dignity to the part of me I'd been trying to fix.

I saw this same paradox echoed in Jung's image of the wounded healer [3]. Not because everyone is a healer, but because the pattern is universal. The thing that wounded you often becomes the gift you carry. Your capacity comes from the place you had to adapt.

As I wrote about in the epilogue, Chiron [4] wasn't powerful because he was immune to pain. He was powerful because he carried an unhealable injury and, in learning to live with it, he developed a rare kind of wisdom and skill. The wound didn't vanish. It got transmuted into his medicine. That's the paradox. The ache can forge your gifts, and it can still send you into the old reflex.

So here's the practical question. How do you stop paying for your gifts by disconnecting from your own truth?

THE LIMBIC WIRING

To find the way out, we first have to understand the mechanism that trapped us. This brings me to a crucial influence, *A General Theory of Love* [5]. In my early days as a coach, I was given a library by a mentor who'd been coaching for a number of years and felt it was time to let go of her old books.

I came across *A General Theory of Love*, and at first I found it hard to understand. But as I dug in, a light bulb went on. Written by psychiatrists trained in academic medicine and teaching in the Bay Area, it offered a rare thing, a big, readable bridge into John Bowlby's theory of attachment.

Attachment theory, in simple terms, is the idea that a child's nervous system forms around early relationships, using them as a template for safety, connection, and what to expect from closeness.

A core idea they name is limbic resonance, their term for the way two nervous systems sync up through face, voice, timing, and touch, so one person's

steadiness helps regulate the other.

Their language about the limbic brain shows its age. The idea of a single neatly bound emotional center in the brain has largely been replaced by a more modern view. Emotion and regulation emerge from distributed networks, not one standalone module in the brain.

But the heart of what landed for me still holds. Before a baby has words, steadiness comes from connection. They borrow it from a caregiver's tone, face, touch, rhythm, and the way things get repaired after they break. Over time, those repeated rounds of being steadied become something they can do on their own.

That discovery sent me digging further into attachment research and developmental studies. And that's when I discovered the Still Face Experiment.

THE BIOLOGY OF PERFORMANCE

To understand the drive to perform, to see exactly how that limbic wiring gets set to prove, I looked at the famous Still Face Experiment by Dr. Ed Tronick [6]. If you want to see the nervous system learn this lesson in real time, there's a simple, devastating demonstration of it.

In the 1970s, Tronick developed a setup where a parent and an infant sit face-to-face. At first, they're cooing and playing. There's a rhythm. The baby smiles. The parent smiles back. The baby's nervous system learns: *I'm safe. My signal works.* Then comes the twist.

The parent is instructed to turn away and then to turn back with a completely Still Face, a neutral expression, deadpan, just a mask.

The baby's reaction is immediate. In phase one, escalation, the baby realizes the connection is broken. So what do they do? They smile bigger. They wave their arms. They screech. They're using every tool they have to say, *Hey, come back. Look at me.* They're escalating their output to earn back the safety.

But in the experiment, the parent holds the Still Face. The repair doesn't come. And when that happens chronically or inconsistently, the infant shifts.

We see phase two, withdrawal. That's when the baby shuts down. They look away. They turn their bodies to the side. They shut down and handle it alone. It's a biological conservation of energy. The nervous system says, *Help isn't coming. I have to handle this alone.* When a baby has to settle themselves, it's simple. They suck their thumb and zone out. It's the body saying, *No one's coming, so I'm going to go away.*

There's an incredible direct link between that infant and the adult sitting in a boardroom today. Because when a kid learns again and again that connection is unreliable, the system adapts. Some people become gold-star chasers not because they love praise, and not even because they want connection. They chase gold stars to calm themselves down, to get a sense of control. If they can do it perfectly, they don't have to risk needing anything from anyone. Perfection becomes a safety move.

Some people go the other direction. They withdraw. They say, *I'm fine*. It looks like disappearing when things get intense. Not texting back, not asking for help, not making a sound. Not because they don't have needs, but because they learned it's safer to handle it alone.

And some people learn a third strategy. They take care of everyone else. They become the capable one, the fixer, the emotional manager. They can feel the room shift before anyone says a word, and they rush in to stabilize it. Being needed becomes the way they stay close. If everyone else is okay, they can breathe.

Different styles, same root lesson. Don't count on being met. So you make safety happen through control.

THE DOUBLE BIND

The Still Face creates the necessity to turn inward. It teaches your nervous system that repair isn't reliable. So you learn to self-regulate alone and decide that control is the only way forward. Only you can take care of yourself.

The Still Face allows you to withdraw. The double bind, however, forbids it. This term, the double bind, was first introduced in 1956 by Gregory Bateson [7] and his Palo Alto Research Group, including Don Jackson, Jay Haley, and John Weakland.

They were studying communication patterns around schizophrenia at the Veterans Administration Hospital. The original schizophrenia causation claim didn't hold up in later research. However, I use the framework here because once you've learned through inconsistent attunement that you're basically on your own, the double bind is the mechanism that forces you to stay in the relationship anyway.

It doesn't just create confusion. It creates a trap. It tells you that you can't leave, fight back, or ask for help. So you take the part of you that already learned to handle it alone, and you stay in relationship anyway, acting like everything

is fine. You start doing whatever keeps the appearance of connection intact. Smiling, achieving, agreeing, even when you're internally alone.

You sense the contradiction, but naming it has consequences. Imagine a manager who's absolutely overwhelmed. Their eyes are glazed over. Their cortisol is spiking. But they say to you, "My door is always open. Tell me what's wrong."

The verbal channel invites you in, but the somatic channel screams, *I can't handle one more thing*. If you believe the words and lean in, you might trigger their rage. But if you point out the body language, you risk being a problem. That's what makes it a bind. There's no clean move.

If you trust what's said out loud, you ignore what your body is picking up. If you trust what your body is picking up, you challenge the story the other person is telling. Either way, something feels dangerous.

You can't step out of the situation. You can't call it out without consequences, and you can't relax into either. So you do the only thing left. You adjust yourself. You shrink your reaction. You manage your tone. You smooth it over. You keep the connection intact, even if it means overriding what you actually feel.

The same thing happens throughout childhood. Maybe it's a parent who says, "I'm fine. Everything's okay." But their shoulders are tight, their eyes are tired, and their voice sounds thin. They're not angry. They're overwhelmed, barely holding it together. You hear the words "okay," but you feel how stretched they are. You can sense that there isn't much room left. If you bring your fear or your sadness, you might add to the weight they're already carrying. And if you say you don't seem okay, you might be told you're overthinking.

So you adjust. You become easier, quieter, and more capable. Not because you don't have needs, but because you can feel how little space there is for them.

As this happens repeatedly, over time, you start losing trust in how to read what's true here. Not just the words, but what the words mean in this relationship. You can't tell if "tell me the truth" is an invitation or if it's a trap. If "come here" means comfort or control. You can't trust the words, but you also aren't allowed to trust your gut.

That's where the override kicks in. When you can't ask what's happening, and you can't trust what you're reading, you learn to do the safest thing in the moment. You mute your own signal and perform okayness. You smooth it over. You stay pleasant, easy, and act like nothing's wrong because that's how you keep the bond intact. To stay connected, you learn a kind of self-separation.

One part of you learns to monitor the space and manage the relationship, while another part inside you works just as hard to mute the body's signals of

danger or need. Over time, that self-protection becomes so automatic that it stops feeling like a strategy and starts feeling like your personality, like that's just who you are.

The ache you feel in moments of vulnerability, what we're calling the sacred wound, is the trace left by all the times you had to override your body and your truth. It marks the moments you set your own reality aside to stay safe, to stay connected, particularly in a relationship you couldn't afford to lose.

The double bind is what creates the dilemma. The signals conflict, but naming the conflict feels dangerous. The override is the solution your nervous system learns to use. Mute what you feel, manage what you show, and keep the bond intact. It works. It keeps connection, but it comes with a cost. You stay fine on the outside by leaving yourself on the inside.

If the bind trains you to betray your own signals, then healing starts in two directions.

SENSE AND STEP

That's where SENSE and STEP come in. SENSE is about the internal repair, and STEP is about the external action.

One more thing about these tools. I didn't invent them. I curated them. I pulled them from lineages that understand how to steady attention and work with reactivity.

Here's the breakdown.

SENSE

The order here is crucial. You can't change your relationship with the world until you stop the override inside your own skin.

S. SLOW THE BREATH

I know how this sounds. When you're in a panic spiral or drowning in work, and someone tells you to just breathe, you probably want to punch them. It feels dismissive. But this isn't magic. It's mechanics.

The inhale is linked to the sympathetic nervous system, the gas pedal. The exhale is linked to the parasympathetic nervous system, the brake. By forcing the exhale to be longer than the inhale, and by adding resistance through those pursed lips, you're sending a direct physiological signal that helps downshift the

system. That's why I recommend the straw breath. Inhale through the nose for five, exhale through pursed lips for seven.

This emphasis on regulation is also one of the core principles of yoga, particularly through the yoga lineage of Krishnamacharya [8], the warrior priest from the grainy 1938 video I described in Chapter One. He's known as the father of modern yoga, and he taught that the breath acts like a mirror for the mind.

When the breath is scattered, the mind is agitated. When the breath is regulated, specifically through lengthening and refining the flow, it becomes the primary tool for reducing mental disturbances. In this view, breath isn't just air. It's the vehicle for *prāṇa*, or vital force, and the organizing force that steers attention toward stability and clarity.

E. ENTER THE BODY

This is the U-turn from story to sensation. We spend most of our lives up in our heads, spinning stories. *He's mad at me. I'm failing.* E. Enter the Body means dropping down to the raw data. This draws on the work of neuroscientist Lisa Feldman Barrett [9] and her theory of constructed emotion.

Most of us assume emotions are obvious and self-evident, like they arrive pre-labeled. Anger is anger. Sadness is sadness. Barrett's work offers a different frame. She argues that the brain is a prediction machine.

It receives raw data from the body, maybe a racing heart, a tight stomach, heat rising in the neck, and then it searches its memory bank to give the data a label. If you grew up in a high-performance environment, your brain is biased to interpret intensity as danger or inadequacy. E. Enter the Body matters because if you skip the sensations and jump straight to *I'm angry* or *I'm sad*, you're accepting the brain's first guess. E. Enter the Body slows you down enough to notice the actual signals, which help you update the label instead of treating it like a fact.

This step also relies on the work of philosopher Eugene Gendlin [10] and his concept of the felt sense. Gendlin argued that people don't change by talking about feelings in the abstract. They change by sensing into the body's quiet knowing before it becomes words.

A felt sense isn't just a physical sensation like a stubbed toe. It's a murky bodily sense of a whole situation. By focusing on this unclear sensation rather than the clear story, the body often shifts, opening up new possibilities for action.

This technique of sitting with the raw data echoes the Buddhist term *sati* [11], which means to remember, remembering to return to the present moment, to

direct experience, not the story about the experience.

And modern trauma therapists like Bessel van der Kolk [12] and Peter Levine [13] point to the same truth. We don't heal by analyzing pain alone but by bringing attention to the body's experience of it. That's where things start to reorganize.

N. NAME THE QUALITY

For me, this comes from the noting practice in the Vipassanā tradition taught by Mahasi Sayadaw [14]. In his method of insight meditation, the practitioner uses mental labels to acknowledge experiences as they arise: *rising, falling, thinking, bearing*. He recommended noting because it introduces a layer of cognitive detachment. Instead of being the anger, you're the observer noting anger. It keeps you anchored in direct experience instead of getting pulled back into the story.

Daniel Siegel [15], a psychiatrist and researcher, modernized this with the phrase, "Name it to tame it." Siegel's research suggests that when you put language to an intense emotional experience, you engage the prefrontal cortex, the thinking brain, which sends inhibitory signals to the amygdala, the panic center, meaning the simple act of naming the feeling biologically calms the nervous system.

I also rely here on the metaphor of the kids on the bus, which I learned from my first therapist, Beverly Peterson [16]. The idea is that your psyche isn't one single you. It's a whole group of parts that formed over time to help you stay safe and accepted. There's the perfectionist part, the pleaser part, the part that gets angry fast, the part that shuts down, the part that feels like a scared six-year-old. They're all in there. And when you get triggered, it can feel like one of those parts runs up to the front of the bus and grabs the wheel. Richard Schwartz [17] built a full framework around this called Internal Family Systems, or IFS.

The move is simple. Name who's driving. Suddenly, you aren't the scared kid. You're the adult noticing the scared kid.

S. STAY

S. Stay can be the hardest step. Every instinct is screaming to fix the feeling or run. We answer five emails really fast. We fix a spreadsheet. We engage in productive procrastination, doing anything to feel competent for a moment so we don't have to feel the ache.

When I first came back from India after studying yoga with Pattabhi Jois [18] and after my first meditation retreat in Sri Lanka, I felt changed, and my

life was changing with it. During that stretch, *When Things Fall Apart* by Pema Chödrön [19] became a good friend. Listening to that audiobook, it kept reminding me of the move I most wanted to make and most wanted to avoid: S. Stay. She talked about the moments when we're activated and want to shut down or pull away.

She writes, "Those are the moments that teach us to perk up and lean in when we feel we'd rather collapse and back away."

It's not just a good idea psychologically. It's also how connection gets rebuilt in the body through a return, a recontact, a repair.

In Ed Tronick's Still Face research, which I mentioned above, the story isn't only that a blank, unresponsive face dysregulates a baby. The other half is what happens next. The parent comes back. The face softens. The engagement returns. And there's reconnection. That return teaches the baby, A break doesn't mean I'm alone. We can find each other again.

S. Stay is the same return turned inward. You keep the younger, hurting part of you company. You say, *I see you. I'm here. I'm not leaving.* It's the opposite of going blank on yourself. It's the moment your system expects you to disappear, and instead, you come back.

It's helpful to know what this actually feels like because there's a recognizable pattern to it in the body. In Chapter Fourteen, I describe the panic I felt as a golden shield wrapping around my ribs that eventually softened into wounded flesh. That shift from protection to tenderness is the core change this work is aiming for. In Internal Family Systems (IFS), that hardness is called a protector. In the body, it can feel like metal, a clamp, a band of pressure that says, I have to handle this.

When you S. Stay, that shield starts to loosen into tenderness. There's often less bracing and sometimes even this message underneath that's simple: *I'm hurting.*

We go here because this is where the sacred wound lives, the imprint of all the ways in which you learn to stay connected to others by tightening up and pushing your own needs aside. The goal isn't some dramatic breakthrough. It's to make contact with what's been held there. To touch it, to feel it, to receive it, to acknowledge it.

Making contact doesn't always feel smooth. Sometimes the first thing that shows up is the old protection. Your mind speeds up. You might go blank. You might feel heat or nausea. You might get distracted. That's the body running the same survival program that once kept connection possible.

But when there's enough steadiness to stay with it in small doses, the system

starts to update itself. The breath releases, the shoulders soften, not because you figured it out, but because something deeper got the message: *This feeling can be here. I don't have to perform to be safe, and I'm not doing it alone.*

This is where an idea from trauma work can help. Peter Levine calls it titration. You make contact with the sensation in small amounts. So S. Stay doesn't mean forcing yourself to feel everything at once. It means pacing the contact. You focus on the sensation for a short moment. Then refocus to another part of your body, say the breath or your hands. Then you return for another short moment. If the shield feels too heavy or the tenderness feels too intense, you back off. It doesn't mean you're failing. You're slowly building trust. This rhythm, touching it and letting go, is often what convinces the protector that it's safe to loosen.

E. EQUANIMITY

Equanimity comes from the practice of Vipassanā meditation, specifically from my first meditation teacher, S. N. Goenka [20]. It doesn't mean floating on a cloud. It means capacity, particularly when the heat is up. It comes from the insight of impermanence, the understanding that everything changes. No matter how intense the feelings are, they will eventually pass away.

E. Equanimity is that increased capacity that happens as we learn to stay. It's receiving a piece of unfair feedback and feeling the defensive rage spike in your chest, but choosing to feel the burn of the anger rather than snapping back or shutting down, which is where STEP begins.

STEP

Insight matters only if it changes what you do. STEP is the part of the map where you take what you've seen and felt and translate it into a different choice in the real world.

When I came back from living in India in 2006, a friend convinced me to do Landmark Education's communication course, associated with Werner Erhard [21]. I'm not going to romanticize Landmark Education. Its sales tactics felt manipulative to me, but it was also a revelation.

It was the yang counterpart to all the yin work I'd been doing in meditation. What hit me wasn't just the insight. It was the emphasis on practice. Not just seeing the pattern, but taking responsibility for it in real conversations, in real relationships. I took away a simple truth: insight can be clarifying, but if it stays inside your head, nothing changes. It starts to matter when it changes the way you relate.

What surprised me was the synergy. The inner work had taught me how to rebuild the relationship with myself. Landmark pushed me in the other direction, to take what I found inside and bring it into relationship, to start revising old contracts.

Eventually, that thread led me to the Co-Active Training Institute and the Co-Active model [22]. Their coaching and leadership training helped me put a cleaner structure around what I was already sensing, a difference between deepening the learning and forwarding the action.

That's where STEP comes in. It's the part of the map that forwards the action, taking what you've seen and felt and turning it into a different choice in the real world.

S. STILL

S. Still can sound a lot like S. Slow the Breath from the SENSE model, but it's different. S. Slow the Breath is physiological. It's about getting your heart rate down and your breath steadier so you have enough regulation to think again. S. Still is more existential.

It's the moment you stop and don't automatically do the thing you always do. This is what Viktor Frankl [23] was pointing to with that often-attributed quote:

"Between stimulus and response, there's a space. In that space is our power to choose our response. In our response lies our growth and our freedom."

SENSE helps create the space. S. Still is you stepping into it on purpose. It's the refusal to act out the reflex. If your pattern is to fix, S. Still is the moment you don't fix. If your pattern is to withdraw, S. Still is the moment you stay put. It's the wedge in the door that keeps the old momentum from slamming it shut.

For Lisa, whom we met in Chapter Thirteen, the reflex was to fix the tension with her business partner, Jonathan. When his critical text landed, her instinct was to defend herself or swallow the critique just to smooth it over. S. Still was the moment she put the phone face down and refused to let the work hijack the moment with her daughter.

S. Still is the moment you feel the urge to write a five-paragraph defensive email explaining why it wasn't your fault, or the urge to apologize profusely and promise the moon to fix it. It's when you choose to do neither. You just hold the tension.

T. TUNE IN TO THE TRADE

The performance trap is the place where you agreed to give up a part of yourself

to stay safe. You learn, usually at a very young age, that to stay connected, you have to give something up. Maybe you give up honesty to keep the peace. Maybe you give up needs to avoid being a burden. Maybe you give up anger or softness because it isn't safe to have it.

This is why T. Tune In to the Trade isn't about values. It's about the trade. The wound is the place where you traded your inner truth for outer safety. Tuning in forces that hidden deal into the light so you can stop paying the cost.

I came to the importance of this step during the darkest period of my life, the crisis I wrote about in Chapter Four. On the surface, my career was exploding. I was the guy everyone called when the wheels were coming off. But privately, I was collapsing. My gut was wrecked. I wasn't sleeping. And I felt like a rotting orange, intact on the outside, but caving in on the inside. I couldn't perform my way out of it. I had to get clear on what was driving it.

That clarity finally arrived in the session with Randall that I described in Chapter Six. When we looked at the knot in my gut, the one that said, I'm holding it together, we weren't just looking at a stomachache. We were looking at a contract I signed when I was young. After Scott took his life, my parents were drowning. The unspoken deal was that the family couldn't handle another problem. So I traded my own grief and messiness to become the good kid. I became low-maintenance. I got good grades. I became the proof that our family was still respectable. The trade was clear: *I will suppress my own needs to ensure you don't crumble. And in exchange, I get to belong.*

Tuning in is about catching that transaction in the moment.

E. EXPAND OPTIONS

Under stress, the double bind collapses your world. You get tunnel vision. Your nervous system tricks you into thinking there are only two choices.

In Chapter Fourteen, I described facing this exact binary. When I finished this book, my mind spun out into two classic options. Option A, the doer's option: I force it. I turn the podcast into a full production. Lights, cameras, editing. I override my body's signals to get the result. Option B, the schnorrer's option: I withdraw. I stay small. I put the book on Amazon quietly and act like I don't care if anyone reads it, just to avoid the pressure.

The trap is believing you have to pick one. E. Expand Options is about finding the third option. The third option is action without hiding. It's asking, *Is there a way to do this work without overriding my body's signals?*

For me, the third option was realizing I didn't need a TV studio. I didn't have to turn my office into a set. I could start small. I could do just the audio. That

was the way forward that didn't require me to push past my own signals.

P. PRACTICE

P. Practice is where you take that third option into the real world. The double bind trained you to live in a split. You feel the no in your body, but you say yes anyway to keep the peace. P. Practice is the act of ending that split. It means saying out loud what your body already knows and what you were trained to keep quiet. It's the conversation, the boundary, the clear no, or the moment you stop overexplaining and simply stay honest even when it's uncomfortable. And it's not just one honest sentence. It's what comes next.

This is something I learned at the Coaches Training Institute. Once you say what's true, you also design the alliance so the relationship stops requiring the old performance. You name the reality, and then you make a small agreement about how you'll handle it going forward.

For Lisa in Chapter Thirteen, P. Practice meant having the conversation she'd been avoiding. She didn't just decide to feel differently. She put the cost into words. She told Jonathan, I can't carry that weight for you anymore. Then they had to face the next question. If she's not carrying it, what changes between them?

For me, P. Practice wasn't a dramatic speech. It was a simple email. After realizing I couldn't do the full video production, I wrote to my friend in marketing and told him the truth. "I'm still in on the podcast, but for now, can we start with the audio? I want to see how it feels before I go all in." And in that one exchange, the rule changed. I wasn't quitting, and I wasn't forcing myself to do something my body didn't want. I was setting a pace my body could actually live with.

This is where Werner Erhard's term "the withhold" points to something useful. We tend to believe our very survival depends on not saying the thing. But when you say it, that hidden pressure drops. You stop organizing your life around what can't be said. And when it's finally said, something in you can unclench. The energy that was spent managing, softening, timing, and editing comes back online.

And it might not be that the other person reacts perfectly. But because your system stops doing the double-bind math, you stop feeling one thing in your body and saying another thing with your mouth. The bracing eases because you're no longer running two tracks at once: the part that's tracking the room to stay safe and the part that's carrying what you actually feel. You come back into one channel, one truth. And from that place, you can deal with what's

happening instead of managing what can't be said.

The other key here is repetition. Nobody gets this in one clean shot. Most of us have practiced our defenses for decades. So you'll miss it. You'll overexplain or go quiet or say yes when you mean no. Then you'll notice, recover, and try again. That's P. Practice, one small honest move repeated until it becomes a new default.

If you zoom all the way out, we've gone from the infant in the high chair, desperate for connection, escalating and then withdrawing, to the adult who can learn to sense their own body, pause the automatic reaction, and step into a new way of relating to the world.

That's the whole point of this map: closing the gap between what you sense and what you say, not becoming better, but becoming one person again instead of splitting into the part that knows and the part that performs. This isn't a personality makeover. It's practice, small moments repeated, where you stop earning belonging and start staying with yourself even while you're in relationship.

And one last thing. We spend so much energy trying to fix the wound like it's a defect. But as I learned in the story of Chiron, the ache isn't proof you're broken. The place you had to adapt is usually the place you developed your sharpest gifts. So what if you stopped trying to get rid of it and started listening? What if it's the part of you that knows what you need to protect, what boundary you need to set, what truth you keep trading away?

Maybe the wound isn't just where it hurts. Maybe it's also the doorway to the medicine you're here to bring.

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Glossary of Terms

the ache of not enoughness

The deep underlying pain that drives the performance trap, which individuals spend their lives running from through achievement. Turning toward this ache, rather than hiding from it, is the doorway back to wholeness.

attachment theory

The psychological theory developed by John Bowlby proposing that a child's nervous system forms around early relationships, using them as a template for safety, connection, and expectations about closeness.

Chiron

A wise centaur from Greek mythology who was accidentally struck by a poisoned arrow that never healed. Because he could not escape the pain, he learned to live with it and ultimately transmuted his unhealable injury into his greatest gift, becoming the teacher of heroes.

constructed emotion

A theory by neuroscientist Lisa Feldman Barrett arguing that the brain acts as a prediction machine. It receives raw physical data from the body and searches its memory bank to give the data a label, meaning emotions do not arrive pre-labeled.

the contract (also the rule)

The unspoken childhood agreement dictating that worth, safety, and connection must be earned through performance rather than being inherent. This rule forces you to leave vulnerable parts of yourself behind in order to maintain connection.

the doer

The archetype of someone who earns their place in the world through relentless achievement and strength. This part uses success to prove they are not weak or needy.

the double bind

A no-win relational trap in which you receive two contradictory messages at once. One

channel invites you in while the somatic channel or body language warns you away, forcing you to abandon your own reality just to keep the peace.

felt sense

Drawn from the work of philosopher Eugene Gendlin, it is a murky bodily sensation of a whole situation rather than a clear narrative or a specific physical pain.

the fixer

An inner role or strategy that attempts to earn connection by stabilizing the room, managing other people's emotions, and solving their problems to avoid feeling left behind.

the gold star monkey

The inner part that works relentlessly to achieve good grades, praise, and external validation. It never feels like the achievements are enough to secure its worth.

the good kid

The inner part that stays easy, low-maintenance, and suppresses its own needs. It adapts to avoid adding to the chaos of overwhelmed parents or caregivers.

the inner critic

The loudest internal protector that judges and drives you. It sits shotgun in your mind and insists that staying productive and harsh is the only way to avoid being exposed as a fraud or failure.

Internal Family Systems (IFS)

A therapeutic model developed by Richard Schwartz that views the psyche as a system of internal parts or protectors that formed to help you stay safe.

level one listening

The shallowest form of listening in the co-active coaching framework in which you are primarily listening to the voice in your own head and waiting for your turn to speak.

level two listening

A state of focused attention in which you track every word the other person is saying with full concentration.

level three listening

A widened state of attention in which you sense the entire emotional field of the conversation. Instead of only hearing words, you notice tone, mood, breath, and tension in the space.

limbic resonance

A concept from *A General Theory of Love* describing the way two nervous systems synchronize through face, voice, timing, and touch. This biological syncing allows one person's steadiness to regulate another.

the lone wolf

The part of you that refuses to fully rely on anyone. It guards against the pain of needing

help and not being met.

name it to tame it

A concept from psychiatrist Daniel Siegel suggesting that putting language to an emotional experience engages the prefrontal cortex, which helps calm the brain's threat response.

negative love

A concept from the Hoffman Institute describing the ways children learn to pursue belonging by adapting to someone else's pain, moods, rules, or approval.

the override

The learned survival mechanism of muting your own bodily signals. You ignore exhaustion, fear, or an internal no in order to manage the room and maintain connection.

the overthinker

A protective part that repeatedly analyzes situations and runs scenarios because uncertainty once felt dangerous.

the perfectionist

The part that tightens standards to avoid exposure. It acts on the memory that being flawed once carried painful relational consequences.

the performance trap

The relentless pressure to prove you are enough. It is the subconscious contract that teaches that worth and connection must be earned through achievement or appeasement.

the performer

The archetype or mask adopted to hide vulnerability by seeking approval through achievement or appearing impressive.

the pleaser

The internal protector that stays agreeable and easy to be around to avoid the fear of rejection.

prāṇa

A yogic term referring to vital life energy. In yoga traditions, breath is understood as the vehicle that organizes and directs this energy.

the sacred wound

The somatic imprint of the moments when you traded your needs and aliveness in order to belong. It is called sacred because the same wound often shapes your deepest capacities and gifts.

sati

A Buddhist term meaning to remember to return to the present moment. It involves anchoring attention in direct bodily experience.

the schnorrer (also the schnorrer's rule)

A Yiddish word meaning beggar or mooch. In the book it represents the deeply feared identity of being needy, weak, or dependent.

SENSE

The five-step internal framework used to interrupt the performance trap and restore contact with the body: S. Slow the Breath, E. Enter the Body, N. Name the Quality, S. Stay, E. Equanimity.

the shield

The physical manifestation of defense guarding the sacred wound. It often feels like golden armor or a clamp over the chest, pushing panic down.

the slip

A moment when someone falls back into the performance trap or old protective strategies. The inner critic may treat it as failure, though it is simply part of learning.

STEP

The four-step framework used to translate insight into real-world action: S. Still, T. Tune In to the Trade, E. Expand Options, P. Practice.

the still face

A phenomenon demonstrated in Dr. Ed Tronick's experiment in which a caregiver suddenly becomes emotionally unresponsive, teaching the infant's nervous system that connection may be unreliable.

straw breath

A breathing technique used in the SENSE framework to calm the nervous system. It involves inhaling through the nose and exhaling slowly through pursed lips.

the tenderness

The underlying vulnerability and ache hidden beneath survival strategies.

the third option

An alternative to the double bind's binary of attacking the other person or abandoning yourself. It allows action aligned with your truth while preserving connection.

The Three Levels of Listening

A coaching framework from the Co-Active Training Institute that categorizes the depth of attention a person brings to a conversation, ranging from self-focused listening to sensing the entire emotional field.

time travel

A somatic phenomenon in which a present-day trigger collapses time and the nervous system reacts as if a past trauma is happening again.

titration

A trauma-resolution concept developed by Peter Levine. It involves approaching painful sensations in small, manageable doses so the nervous system does not become overwhelmed.

Vipassanā

An ancient Buddhist insight meditation practice in which practitioners observe sensations as they arise and pass away without reacting.

the withhold

A term associated with Werner Erhard, referring to an important truth a person believes they cannot say. Naming the withhold often releases hidden relational pressure.

the wounded healer

An archetype developed by C. G. Jung illustrating the paradox that the very wound that injured a person can become the source of their capacity to help others.

Appendix: Practices in One Place

Sometimes you just want the tools in one place. This recap pulls everything together. Use it like a field guide.

Prefer audio + quick one-pagers?

You can find the guided audios and summaries here: herstwellness.com/book-bonus.

SENSE

SENSE is how you slow down when the trap gets triggered, not to make it go away, but to restore contact. It brings you back to the signal system you learned to override: breath, tightening, urgency, the impulse to please, the quiet *no*. The point is not relief. The point is accuracy.

SENSE also matters because you cannot do deep work while your body is in threat mode. When you're activated, your system narrows and you start time traveling. SENSE widens your container again, so you can feel what's true without getting dragged straight into the old reflex.

S. Slow the Breath: Slowing the breath is the entry point. It is the brake where you pause the old reflex to argue, fix, please, disappear, or push through as if nothing is wrong. This is your anchor. You aren't trying to relax. You're giving your nervous system enough safety to pause.

Try This: Use the straw breath method. Inhale through your nose for a count of five. Purse your lips like you're blowing through a straw and exhale slowly for a count of seven. Do this for two minutes. If you are in a meeting or caught in a spiral, just take three deliberate breaths. You are just creating a split second of space between you and the voice in your head.

E. Enter the Body: We don't try to silence the mind. Racing thoughts are a mirror reflecting something your body is already holding. Make a U-turn out of the story and back into the physical sensation. Don't analyze why it's there. Just locate where it lives.

Try This: Ask yourself: *Where do I feel this thought reflected in my body right now? Throat? Chest? Belly?* That is it. You are not analyzing. You are just locating where you feel the strongest sensation. Then ask: *Is it pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral?*

N. Name the Quality: Use simple, direct words to describe the sensations. Naming creates a little distance. Not to get rid of what's here, but so you can notice it without getting swept up in it. We don't ask it to leave. We simply acknowledge it.

Try This: Tight. Heavy. Numb. Blank. Buzzing. Knot in the stomach. If a protector is running the show or your mind is racing, name that too: the inner critic, the overthinker, the shutdown. You aren't looking for relief. You're looking for accuracy.

S. Stay: When something hurts, the reflex is to fix it, explain it, or shove it away. Staying asks you to do something different. Turn toward the sensation without fixing it. Let it exist. Keep it company, like finally turning toward a friend who has been trying to get your attention and internally saying, *I see you*.

Try This: Touch the sensation with your attention for ten seconds, then come back to the breath. Go back and forth. You aren't forcing it to change. You're letting it know it's not alone. You might drop a question into the body: *What are you trying to prevent? What are you worried might happen?* Wait for the body to respond. When an insight arrives, drop right back into the body.

E. Equanimity: If S. Stay is making contact, E. Equanimity is learning to remain with what you've touched. Equanimity isn't calm. It's capacity. Let the sensation be there without pushing it away or getting swallowed by it.

Instead of treating this like a pass-or-fail test, you stop trying to solve the feeling. You stop bracing and demanding a timeline. Your mind will jump in with questions like, *How long is this going to last?* Equanimity means you do not answer. If the heat or shaking intensifies, that's not failure. It's the work.

Try This: Remind yourself: *I can stay. I don't have to fix this to be okay.* Let it peak, let it settle, let it move, and let it stay. If you are shaking, practice shaking without trying to stop. Let it move in its own time.

STEP

STEP comes after SENSE. If SENSE brings you back into contact with yourself when you're triggered, STEP is where you use that contact to find the third option. It's how you take what you felt and start revising the old contract you never chose.

The order matters. You restore inner contact first, then you renegotiate outer terms. Otherwise, you're just acting out the performance trap with better language.

S. Still: Under pressure, you usually either push harder or abandon yourself. Still is the pause that comes before action to interrupt that reflex. It is a condensed SENSE, just enough to slow down, feel what is happening in your body, and stop the reflex from driving.

This is not the moment to fix, explain, or react yet. You aren't stepping away from the relationship. You're stepping out of the reflex. Let the urgency drop so you aren't riding the wave straight into action.

Try This: Say to yourself: *I don't have to decide right now. I can wait until I'm back online.*

T. Tune In to the Trade: This is where the double bind shows up. Something in you wants to remain connected, but something else knows you're about to lose yourself to maintain that connection. Ask what the old pattern is costing you. What are you giving up to stay safe, approved of, or in control?

Try This: Notice the compromise forming. Ask: *What part of me is about to go quiet so the connection stays intact? What feeling am I about to bury to keep the peace? What am I about to trade away right now? My honesty? My time? My need? My dignity? My rest?* Name the trade.

E. Expand Options: Stress makes you think you only have two choices. Either you say it in a way that escalates tension, or you don't say it at all. The double bind says it is one or the other. When you tune in, the view widens, and you discover it is both.

Try This: Look for the third option. You don't have to fix it instantly, and you don't have to cave. You do not have to attack, and you do not have to abandon yourself. You can pause. You can ask a question. You can name what's true without escalating.

P. Practice: The double bind taught you to tune yourself out and avoid contact. Practice is the moment you reverse that. You put into words what your body has been sensing all along. Take one small step that breaks the old contract in real life.

Try This: Say one honest sentence. Set one boundary. Make one request. Name the breakdown. Take one action that is true rather than strategic. Repeat. This is how your system learns a new way.

THE BIG PICTURE

- **SENSE** is about contact. It interrupts the reflex, brings you into the body, and helps you name what's true. It restores access to the signals you learned to override.
- **STEP** is about change. It takes what you discovered through contact and turns it into a lived response. It is how the contract actually gets broken. You stop obeying it internally, and then you stop enacting it externally.

THE TWO-MINUTE VERSION

SENSE

- **S. Slow the Breath:** Straw Breath (5 in, 7 out) to interrupt the spiral.
- **E. Enter the Body:** Drop the story. Locate the sensation.
- **N. Name the Quality:** Tight, heavy, buzzing. Name the protector if it's there.
- **S. Stay:** Keep it company for a few breaths without fixing it.

- **E. Equanimity:** Widen the container. Let it move in its own time. Stay with it without trying to solve it.

STEP

1. **S. Still: Pause.** Wait for the urgency to drop.
2. **T. Tune In to the Trade:** What am I about to give up to stay safe or approved?
3. **E. Expand Options:** Find the third option that does not attack or collapse.
4. **P. Practice:** One honest action. One boundary. One sentence. Repeat.

And if you'd like to build these practices with some support from me, The Performance Trap Practice is at herstwellness.com/practice.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Chad Herst is a mind/body coach, author, and licensed acupuncturist (LAc) who works with high performers caught in the cycle of achievement and disconnection. In *The Performance Trap*, he draws on mindfulness training, body-based practices, and years of client work to help people stop overriding their own signals and find what's underneath the drive to prove themselves, the ache no success will ever fix.

This work began with a phone call in 1991 that changed everything: the loss of his brother, Scott, to suicide. That moment exposed the cost of performance and started a decades-long search to understand the ache beneath success.

Chad holds a BA in religious studies from Columbia College, where he graduated cum laude, a Master of Science in Traditional Chinese Medicine (MSTCM), and is a Certified Professional Co-Active Coach (CPCC). He lives in Northern California with his wife, Melissa, and their Labradoodle, Disco. Learn more at herstwellness.com.

